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INSIDE



OpenAI pledges 'safeguards' for data centre hosts

CHENNAI
OpenAI has announced a set of commitments for communities hosting its future AI data-centre campuses in the U.S., pledging to bear the full cost of grid infrastructure, disclose environmental impacts and not use NDAs with public officials. » PAGE 12



2 tankers catch fire in Hormuz Strait, says Iran

TEHRAN
Two oil tankers and a tugboat caught fire in the Strait of Hormuz, Iran's Revolutionary Guards said, according to local media on Thursday. There has been no confirmation of either incident from maritime officials. » PAGE 14

Agnipath has not been rolled back, says government

NEW DELHI
A day after announcing an extension of the Agniveer engagement period, the Centre on Thursday clarified that the Agnipath scheme has not been rolled back and that the revised arrangement creates a pathway enabling all Agniveers to eventually join the regular cadre of the armed forces. » PAGE 4

Guard arrested in Telangana drug trafficking case

HYDERABAD
A former security guard who built an inter-State marijuana trafficking network with 100 consumers in Hyderabad was arrested after a 60-day hunt by the the Telangana Police. Bhaskar Hazarika, 31, operated a network that moved large consignments of marijuana from Odisha to Hyderabad. » PAGE 3

Naga groups seek political solution to Manipur crisis

GUWAHATI
Nagas took out rallies in conflict-scarred Manipur's Kamjong and Ukhrul districts on Thursday, urging Prime Minister Narendra Modi to help secure a permanent political solution that will end the violence in the State. The Naga groups urged the Centre to stop the "militarisation" of Naga areas. » PAGE 4

ECI announces Summary Revision for 6 States, U.T.s

The annual SSR seeks to enrol eligible voters, especially first-timers; election body says furnishing Aadhaar details in Forms 6 and 8 will remain voluntary; draft rolls are to be published on Nov. 30

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Election Commission of India (ECI) on Thursday announced the annual special summary revision (SSR) of electoral rolls for six States and Union Territories – Arunachal Pradesh, Mizoram, Odisha, Sikkim, Chandigarh and Dadra and Nagar Haveli and Daman and Diu – where the special intensive revision (SIR) has been completed and the final rolls published.

Earlier on October 15, the SSR was announced for 17 States and Union Territories, including poll-bound Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Punjab, Manipur, and Goa. The SSR, an annual exercise, has not been carried out amid the launch of the now controversial SIR of electoral rolls last year. Election Commissioners S.S. Sandhu and Vivek Joshi are understood to have raised this as an anomaly as well among other issues.



Making it count: Youth throng a special voter enrolment camp at a college in New Delhi in September. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

The annual SSR seeks to enrol eligible voters, particularly young and first-time electors, and facilitate advance applications from those who will become eligible on April 1, July 1, and October 1, 2027.

The draft electoral rolls will be published on November 30 this year and the final ones on January 21, 2027.

Furnishing Aadhaar details in Forms 6 and 8 will remain voluntary. No application for enrolment can be rejected, nor can an existing entry be deleted, for failure to provide Aadhaar, according to the SSR order issued by the ECI.

Unlike the contentious SIR process, when enrolling through the SSR, voters do no need to give any documentation proving citizenship or be mapped with earlier electoral rolls.

Among the firsts, in this year's SSR, the ECI has directed that, at the time of polls, "readable PDF" of the alphabetically arranged electoral rolls in pen drive or any other electronic storage device can be provided to the contesting candidates.

This is crucial as Opposition parties have been demanding machine-readable electoral rolls rather than image-based PDFs, so that they are digitally searchable, indexable, and verifiable.

Political parties would also be provided with supplementary voter lists, which were earlier kept only for record and future use.

The SSR process this time would not include house-to-house visits by booth-level officers (BLOs). Instead, both draft as well as final lists would be put up at polling booths.

Autumnal reflections



Visual treat: An idyllic view of Dal Lake, flanked by autumn chinar foliage on its banks, in Srinagar on Thursday. IMRAN NISSAR

24-hour countdown for hearing starts moment an individual is detained: SC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday ruled that an arrest occurs the moment an official "touches" an individual to restrain their liberty, immediately triggering the 24-hour countdown to produce them before a Judicial Magistrate.

A Bench headed by Justice Ujjal Bhuyan said the word 'arrest' is not defined in the penal statutes, past or present, from the colonial Indian Penal Code, the Code of Criminal Procedure or its successor, the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita of 2023.



Ambiguity in the definition of 'arrest' has allowed law enforcement agencies to detain a person for days on end, the Bench noted. PTI

Ambiguous definition

The Bench pointed out that the ambiguity in the definition of 'arrest' has allowed law enforcement agencies to detain a person for days on end, employ third-degree measures, including torture, to squeeze out confessions, before the formal arrest is recorded.

Once formal arrest is recorded, Article 22(2) of the Constitution requires the arrested person to be produced before a Judicial Magistrate, giving the person an opportunity of a hearing.

So far, law enforcement officers and police have calculated the 24-hour rule from the time of formal arrest after search and seizure. The hours and days of prior detention were not taken into account.

Changing the script, Justice Bhuyan said the perceived dichotomy between detention and arrest has led to grave human rights violations.

"The tendency to detain suspects for questioning and manipulating the record to show a later time of arrest is a reprehensible practice... What the investigating officers do, in such cases, is to procure statements by assault, illegal detention and fear of continued detention... The worst violations of human rights take place during the course of investigation," the court observed.

The 24-hour period was a constitutional safeguard intended to act as a safety barrier to check such Executive excess.

Mandate in Article 22

"The 24-hour timeline as mandated under clause (2) of Article 22 of the Constitution would commence from the date and time of detention of the person and when his liberty stands curtailed, and not from the time of his formal arrest," Justice Bhuyan held.

Justice Bhuyan reasoned that the Constitution did not recognise detention dehors (outside) arrest. "Even if a person is touched with a view to detaining, it would amount to an arrest... Thus, the prescription of 24-hour time period would commence the moment a person is detained by the arresting authority suspecting him to have committed an offence, when his liberty is effectively curtailed," Justice Bhuyan said.

The court held that the fundamental rights to life and liberty as enshrined in Article 21 were at the core of Constitutional jurisprudence, and "cannot be tinkered with so lightly, not even under the special statutes".

"Article 22(2) does not sanction the creation of any buffer zone where the liberty of an individual is curtailed for investigating purposes, but not formally shown as arrested. Creation or contemplation of such a buffer zone is unconstitutional," the court held.

Direction to Magistrates

In a series of directions, the court ordered that any person found to have been detained beyond 24 hours by a Magistrate on his or her production, must be released immediately.

The Bench directed that no other time period, except the time necessary for the journey from the place of arrest to the court of the Magistrate, must be excluded from the 24-hour timeline.

The Magistrate concerned was duty-bound to record the actual date and time of detention of the person produced before the court.

The Supreme Court gave Magistrates the discretion to order the release of individuals who were detained for more than was actually reasonable, even if the period had not exceeded 24 hours.

The court was deciding appeals filed by four accused persons in a narcotics case whose formal arrest was recorded only 18 hours later. The Tripura High Court had denied them bail, but the apex court ordered their release forthwith.

ECI restores oversight of IT wing after workflow issue

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

More than three months after the row over movement of Information Technology head Seema Khanna's files, the Election Commission of India has issued a fresh order bringing back oversight over her department through a Deputy Election Commissioner (DEC).

An internal order issued on July 28 by Senior DEC Maneesh Garg had removed DEC Sanjay Kumar from the charge of IT and Information and Communication Technology (ICT) divisions, and given Dr. Khanna a free hand, enabling her to directly report to the Commission. Following this, two Election Commissioners, S.S. Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, had written to Cabinet Secretary T.V. Somanathan on July 29 regarding the work allocation order of Dr. Garg, who had held interim charge of the Administration Department.

As per the current order, dated October 4, Dr. Khanna is required to route the files related to IT/ICT and Grievances/Public Grievance Redressal System (PGRS) through Senior DEC Pawan Kumar Sharma. Dr. Khanna joined the ECI in 2025 on deputation from the National Informatics Centre (NIC). She heads the commission's IT department and oversees its digital infrastructure, including systems for electoral roll management.



S.S. Sandhu (left) and Vivek Joshi (right) had written to the Cabinet Secretary voicing concern on a work order issued in July. PTI

'No change'

ECI sources though insisted that there is no change in the reporting structure of Director-General of IT as she has always been reporting to a DEC level officer. In an affidavit filed in the Supreme Court, the ECI had maintained that the July 28 order had never been implemented. The sources also said that the work allocation orders were issued as per unanimous decisions of the Commission.

The letters to the Cabinet Secretary by Dr. Sandhu and Dr. Joshi, obtained under the Right to Information (RTI) Act by transparency activist Commodore Lokesh Batra (retired), explained their objections regarding Dr. Garg changing the work allocation of officers "within hours of" getting charge of the administration wing "without discussing or informing" them despite "repeated and explicit oral and written" instructions to all officers.

Both ECs had also said that Dr. Garg had "issued similar orders on one earlier occasion" while he was working as DEC (Administration).

Delimitation in-charge

Prakash Rajpurohit, an IAS officer of the 2010 batch, who was appointed as DEC in the ECI, filling the vacancy caused by the premature repatriation of Sanjay Kumar (earlier in-charge of the electoral rolls and IT divisions), would now be assisting Dr. Garg in election planning. He would also be in-charge of delimitation.

Mr. Kumar, who had been DEC from August 2024 till August this year, was responsible for the electoral rolls and IT divisions of the ECI, and had signed the ECI's June 24, 2025, order initiating the SIR in the country.

Got very few complaints on July 20 'police brutality': SC

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday said that "very few complaints" were received directly on the online portal of the High Powered Enquiry Committee (HPEC) inquiring into allegations of police brutality and sexual abuse of women during the July 20 violence sparked by demonstrations against the NEET-UG 2026 question paper leaks.

FULL REPORT ON » PAGE 5

INBRIEF



Christians hold march against attack on churches in Bengal

Hundreds of people from the Christian community marched to Kolkata's Esplanade on Thursday in protest against the rising cases of mob attacks on churches across West Bengal. A mega prayer rally was called by the Bangiya Chirstiya Parishad at the Rani Rashmoni Road in Esplanade on Sunday. A sea of people from Kolkata and surrounding districts rallied from Sealdah, Birla Planetarium, and Howrah to gather at the venue and express their dissent over the attacks. At least 48 such incidents have been reported since May across the State. However, FIRs have been lodged in only 15 cases.

BLO suspended over deletion of 26 names from roll in U.P.

A Booth Level Officer (BLO) was suspended after the names of 26 eligible voters were allegedly deleted from the electoral roll in a village in Bareilly, with locals alleging that the deletions were carried out in collusion with a former village head, officials said on Thursday. District Magistrate Avinash Singh ordered an inquiry into the matter and said strict legal action would be taken if it was established that the names were deliberately removed as part of a conspiracy. A complaint was lodged in this regard by Rahul Gangwar, the village head of Mohammadpur gram panchayat in Shergarh block. PTI

Rahul wades into Gokul Dairy row, alleges BJP trying to steal mandate

Maharashtra govt. move to appoint nominated directors to federation's board after Cong.-backed panel's win is 'theft' of milk producers' votes, says party leader; decision taken as per law: Fadnavis

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI


Rahul Gandhi said after the milk producers defeated the BJP in the election to the Gokul Dairy, the party changed the rules. FILE PHOTO

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Thursday waded into the Gokul Dairy row, accusing the BJP-led government in Maharashtra of trying to "steal the people's mandate and take control" of the milk cooperative through government-nominated directors.

A panel backed by Congress MLC Satej Patil defeated the Mahayuti combine in the elections to the Kolhapur District Cooperative Milk Producers' Union, better known as Gokul Dairy, on October 18, winning 13 of the 25 seats against the ruling alliance's 12.

The State Cabinet recently approved a proposal that could fundamentally alter the balance of power in the cooperative, giving the government the power to appoint five directors to its board, four of them with voting rights.

Set up in 1963, the Kolhapur District Cooperative Milk Producers' Union had an annual turnover of ₹3,966.28 crore in 2024-25. It works with 4.41 lakh milk producers and collects milk every day from 8,009 village-level societies in and around Kolhapur district, making it a significant entity in the region.

Protest march

Mr. Patil accused the Maharashtra government of insulting the people of Kolhapur by trying to take control of Gokul Dairy. He said a protest march will be held in Kolhapur city on November 9 against the government's decision.

Mr. Gandhi said the government's decision to appoint nominated directors after the election was a "theft" of the milk producers' votes and "adulteration in the mandate".

In a post on X, Mr. Gandhi said after milk producers defeated the BJP in the election to the Gokul Dairy, it changed the rules, adding four directors to increase its numbers.

"The BJP has become so desperate that it's going to any lengths everywhere to save power. Those who steal the milk producers' votes, remember - farmers don't forget," he said.

Shiv Sena (UBT) MP Sanjay Raut said the Opposition Maha Vikas Aghadi should come together on the issue, while NCP (SP) MLA Rohit Pawar urged "all those who believe in democracy" to 'gherao' Gokul Dairy during its chairman's election.

Hitting back, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis told reporters in Nagpur that Mr. Gandhi considers Gokul Dairy a national issue as his party recently had to make do with victories of 3,000 to 4,000 votes. The decision to appoint the directors was taken as per law, he added.

State Minister Hasan Mushrif, a leader of the Mahayuti panel, defended the State government's intervention, claiming the move was necessary to restore democratic functioning and hand over the administration to elected representatives.

Bengal govt. unveils new investment promotion policy

The Hindu Bureau
KOLKATA


West Bengal CM Suvendu Adhikari unveiling the policy in Kolkata on Thursday. PTI

The BJP government in West Bengal on Thursday announced a new investment promotion policy, offering incentives to industries that employ more women and assistance for investments in plant and machinery, along with a fixed timeline for the approval of projects.

The new policy, which comes into place from May 9, the day the first BJP government in the State took office, offers up to 120% assistance to a thrust sector unit in a priority area on the share of fixed capital investment made in plant and machinery.

The announcement of incentives marks a policy shift for West Bengal, the fourth most populous State, as the previous Trinamool Congress government passed the Revocation of West Bengal Incentive Schemes and Obligations 2025, retroactively scrapping three decades of industrial incentive schemes and subsidies.

"The previous government had cheated the industrialists," Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari said while unveiling the much-awaited policy document for the revival of industries in the State.

"We will neither have a forcible land acquisition policy like the Left Front nor will we have a flawed land policy like the Trinamool Congress, asking industries to buy their own land without any support from the government," Mr. Adhikari said.

Talks on Singur

The Chief Minister said the government is in talks with vehicle manufacturer Ashok Leyland. "We will do something about Singur," he said. The withdrawal of the Tata Group from Singur in 2008 over protests against forcible land acquisition is considered one of the defining setbacks of the State's dreams of an industrial revival.

Recovery of ₹1.02 crore from Trinamool office sets off a political clash in West Bengal

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

A political row erupted in West Bengal on Thursday over the recovery of ₹1.02 crore from an All India Trinamool Congress (AITC) office in Sarisha in South 24 Parganas, with Diamond Harbour MP Abhishek Banerjee alleging that the police planted it.

Mamata AITC leaders said they had vacated the office located in Mr. Banerjee's constituency after the change of government on May 4. "The deliberate planting of fake and fabricated evidence at a property vandalised six months ago by BJP goons, which subsequently became a scene of crime under police investigation, is a brazen attempt to subvert justice and manipulate the investigation and misuse the machinery of law," Mr. Banerjee wrote on social media late on Wednesday.



Mamata Trinamool leader Abhishek Banerjee. FILE PHOTO

Additional Superintendent of Police (Zonal) Abhishek Majumdar said the cash was recovered on the night of November 3 after prolonged questioning of Sumit Roy, Mr. Banerjee's personal assistant, who was arrested in a land grab case on September 10.

"We got a lead and conducted a raid at a location related to a Trinamool Congress office," he said, adding that the police are verifying who ran the office. They are yet to establish the source of the money or any link to the case.

Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari alleged that the money belonged to Mr. Banerjee, referring to him as *"bhatija"* (nephew).

"This is just a small amount," he said, claiming that Mr. Banerjee and his aide earned such sums in an hour and a day respectively. He said action would be taken as per the law.

'Will move court'

Mamata AITC MP Mahua Moitra said the vandalised premises had been returned to the owner on May 21 and a police complaint lodged. "You recovered cash 160 days after we vacated the office?" she said. She warned the police against taking illegal action and said the party would approach the court.

Violence mars third phase of Rajasthan panchayat elections

Mohammed Iqbal
JAIPUR

Polling in the third phase of panchayat elections for sarpanch and ward panch posts in 27 districts of Rajasthan on Thursday was marred by clashes, stone-pelting, allegations of bogus voting and protests at several places. Supporters of rival candidates clashed in Sikar, Chittorgarh, and Balotra districts.

A dispute between supporters of two sarpanch candidates turned violent at Delsar village in the Nawalgarh area of Jhunjhunu district, with the two sides allegedly attacking each other with sticks and batons. A youth from Punjab's Hoshiarpur died in the clash, while two others sustained injuries.

The police detained several persons for questioning and seized vehicles. At Bassi in Chittorgarh district, police resorted to a lathi charge after supporters of two candidates clashed over alleged bogus voting. Tension prevailed in Sikar's Sami village after stones were hurled at a vehicle near a polling station. Sarpanch candidate Arun Pareek was allegedly assaulted by his rival and around 50 supporters at Bhojya Ki Dhani village panchayat.

Voting cancelled

Voting for the sarpanch post was cancelled at Ludi Jhabar village panchayat in Rajgarh panchayat samiti of Churu district after the nomination of the only candidate was rejected during scrutiny. No election was held in the absence of a candidate.

Polling was held in 3,716 village panchayats under 116 panchayat samitis for 3,716 sarpanch and 34,218 ward panch seats.

Residents of disputed villages in Kotia cross Odisha boundary to vote in Andhra Pradesh polls

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

Several voters from Kotia gram panchayat, whose jurisdiction has long been disputed between Odisha and Andhra Pradesh, crossed the Odisha boundary on Thursday to cast their votes in the mandal parishad territorial constituency and zilla parishad territorial constituency elections conducted by the Andhra Pradesh State Election Commission.

The Odisha government had deployed 16 platoons of police and erected three border checkpoints, restricting people's entry and exit. However, several voters sneaked out from the borders to cast votes.

The Andhra Pradesh government had set up a polling booth for villagers of Kotia at Sariki in its State boundary.


Odisha government had deployed 16 platoons of police and erected checkpoints, restricting people's entry and exit. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Political parties in Odisha accused leaders from Andhra Pradesh of bribing people to get their votes. "Some were taken to the other side of the boundary on Wednesday. After casting their votes, they returned," said veteran Congress MLA Tara Prasad Bahinipati, who hails from Koraput district.

Similarly, Bhrugu Buxipatra, a senior BJD leader, said a few had crossed borders to vote. However, this time, the people of Odisha were successful by not letting Andhra Pradesh set up its polling booth inside Odisha, he said.

Koraput Sub-Collector Fabi Rasheed said security personnel and Executive Magistrates were deployed in boundary villages to prevent untoward incidents. "Villagers did cross the border, but we have no idea if they voted in the Andhra Pradesh elections," Ms. Rasheed said.

Rahul invokes Lord Shiva to challenge BJP's 'avatar politics'

NEWS ANALYSIS

Anuj Kumar


Congress leader Rahul Gandhi and SP chief Akhilesh Yadav have used religious and historical imagery to take on the BJP. FILE PHOTO

Speaking at the INDIA bloc's *'Vote Bachao, Desh Bachao* (Save the Vote, Save the Country)' rally at Ramlila Maidan in Delhi, Congress leader and Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi once again used religious imagery around Lord Shiva to outline his vision for an inclusive India.

Aggression, compassion

It seems Mr. Gandhi seeks to reinforce the pluralistic side of Hinduism without abandoning aggression altogether. He did not just talk of dethroning the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), he vowed to send the top leadership of the ruling dispensation to jail if voted to power and, in the same vein, promised to open *'mohabbat ki dukan* (shop of love)'.

In Hindu philosophy, Lord Shiva best represents the convergence of these two seemingly contradictory forces. It is not that Lord Ram, an avatar of Lord Vishnu, could not be characterised as inclusive, but observers say, politicians seek to tell new stories, invoke different gods when they feel the sentiment is ripe. In the run-up to the 2014 Lok Sabha election, the Right-wing ecosystem urged the electorate not to be charmed by the beatific smiles of the gods but to "understand the meaning of arms in their hands".

From this rhetoric emerged the images of an angry Hanuman and a rugged, stoic Ram in popular iconography. After the Ram Temple consecration, the narrative changed to *"Jo Ram ko laayen hain hum unko layenge* (Those who brought Lord Ram, we'll bring them)", with posters of Prime Minister Narendra Modi holding the hand of Ram Lalla.

Now, challenging the BJP's "avatar politics", Mr. Gandhi has brought the most egalitarian deity in the triumvirate into the mix. Lord Shiva is simultaneously the fierce agent of cosmic destruction and the ultimate symbol of radical, pluralistic inclusivity.

He is depicted crushing a dwarf-like figure beneath his foot during his *tandava* (cosmic dance) as *Nataraja*. This figure is *Apasmara*, the demon of ignorance, arrogance and delusion, traits that the Congress and its ecosystem repeatedly accuse the BJP and its *parivar* of embodying.

At the November 1 rally, the Congress leader framed the current establishment as an "exclusive club", with explicit references to the concentration of India's wealth and infrastructure in the hands of two or three corporate figures. And then juxtaposed this corporate exclusivity against *Shivji ki Baraat*, which refers to the highly unusual wedding procession of Lord Shiva as he travelled to marry Goddess Parvati and in which nobody is excluded because of status, wealth or background.

This imagery of reaching out to the last man in the row through religious symbolism is not new to the Congress or Indian politics. Mahatma Gandhi popularised the term *Daridra Narayana*, coined by Swami Vivekananda, which translates to 'God manifests in the poor and the afflicted'.

His INDIA bloc partner and Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav seems to share his penchant for cultural motifs and delivers it with a tinge of sarcasm.

'Loktantra ki Haldighati'

He referred to the traditional context of Ramlila Maidan as a metaphor for accountability and divine justice while coining the phrase "*Loktantra ki Haldighati* (Haldighati of Democracy)" to describe the venue and the Opposition's political struggle.

The historic battle was fought between the outnumbered forces of Maharana Pratap and the Mughal Empire. By invoking it, observers say, Mr. Yadav articulated the Opposition alliance's fight against the BJP as a principled stand against a massive, powerful establishment.

Opposition trying to destabilise TVK-led govt., says TNCC chief

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

TNCC president Manickam Tagore on Thursday alleged that Opposition parties were attempting to destabilise the TVK-led government by approaching its MLAs.

Supporting Minister C.T.R. Nirmal Kumar's allegation that the DMK and AIADMK were attempting to poach TVK MLAs with the BJP's support, he said those who had lost power were trying to disturb the government.

Speaking to mediapersons, Mr. Tagore said senior leaders of the DMK, AIADMK, and the BJP had repeatedly questioned the stability of the government. "An honest government has been installed, honest Ministers have been appointed, and the Chief Minister has been delivering a clean administration for the past four months," he said, adding that the Opposition was attempting to create uncertainty and undermine the State's development.

BJP denies allegations

BJP State unit president Nainar Nagenthran on Thursday rejected allegations made by Mr. Nirmal Kumar that the AIADMK and the BJP were conspiring to bring down the TVK-led government in Tamil Nadu. He further described the Minister's claim as baseless.

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KPSC chief, others named in FIR over exam fraud

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Crime Branch of the Keralam Police has registered an FIR against the Chairman and members of the Kerala Public Service Commission (KPSC) over alleged irregularities in the examination for recruitment to the post of Fisheries Extension Officer.

The latest FIR explicitly identifies three categories of accused: the PSC Chairman, members and officials. The alleged irregularities relate to the examination conducted for the Fisheries Extension Officer post at the Kerala University of Fisheries and Ocean Studies. It has also registered another FIR against PSC members over alleged irregularities in the exam for recruitment to the post of Assistant Motor Vehicle Inspector.

BJP leaders meet President over 'irregularities' in KPSC

They urge Murmu to act on former Kerala Governor's recommendation to remove PSC Chairman; despite securing ranks, youth have been denied jobs because of the maladministration, they say

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) delegation on Thursday met President Droupadi Murmu and requested her to act on the recommendation of former Keralam Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar for the removal of State Public Service Commission (KPSC) Chairman M.R. Baiju and its members over alleged irregularities.

The BJP delegation led by Rajya Sabha member (nominated) C. Sadanandan included State party president Rajeev Chandrasekhar and Rajya Sabha member P.T. Usha.

The former Governor had flagged alleged irregularities in the functioning of the organisation which is responsible for recruitment to government services in the State before demitting office.



Seeking action: President Droupadi Murmu with BJP leader Rajeev Chandrasekhar, and P.T. Usha and C. Sadanandan, MPs. PTI

At a press conference, Mr. Chandrasekhar accused the Congress and Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi of raising "manufactured issues" related to the youth, while not addressing their plight in Keralam.

"It reflects hypocrisy and double standards on the part of the Congress, much like the special intensive revision (SIR) issue, where they take one position in Delhi against the SIR but take another position in Keralam in favour of it," he said.

The senior BJP leader said: "This is an important issue that impacts the future of many Malayali youth who have been sitting in protest and on strike for the last several months. Despite appearing for examinations and securing ranks, they have been denied jobs because of the maladministration of the PSC and what we believe is its complete capture by vested interests such as the SFI, which is part of the CPI(M) ecosystem."

"PSC rank holders have been protesting outside the Secretariat for months, with the full knowledge of the Congress Chief Minister," he said.



A Coast Guard aircraft on a search and rescue mission at Kothapatnam coast near Ongole on Thursday. KOMMURI SRINIVAS

Bodies of four T.N. fishers found in A.P.

N.S. Chowdary
ONGOLE

The bodies of three fishermen from Tamil Nadu washed ashore at the Kothapatnam coast in Ongole on Thursday, while another fisherman's body was found in the sea by Indian Coast Guard (ICG) officials at Nizampatnam Port.

Using a Dornier aircraft, the ICG staff, in coordination with personnel of the Maritime Rescue Coordination Centre (MRCC), Chennai, were searching for five more fishermen, who had been sailing on the same boat that sank 2 km off the coast. According to sources, three boats had set sail from Chennai on October 29. Due to Cyclone Murasu, two boats had anchored for safety near Ramayapatnam Port on November 2, while the third boat had proceeded towards Nizampatnam Port.

The nine fishermen on the third boat had departed from Nizampatnam to meet the other two groups in Ramayapatnam on November 3. Due to the cyclone and strong winds, their boat drifted towards the coast off Adani Krishnapatnam Port and capsized. The nine fishermen were identified as Pakkirisamu Suriya (the driver), Kuppan, Mohan, Rajesh, Murugan, Kuppusamy, Vijayakanth, Aravindh, and Narayanan. While Narayanan was from Cuddalore, the others were from Chennai.

Prakasam Collector P. Raja Babu visited the place where the bodies washed ashore. He told the media that the bodies were yet to be identified. "The identification would take place after the family members and officials from Tamil Nadu arrive," he added.

"Further action on the transport of the bodies and bringing the capsized boat to the shore would be taken in consultation with the officials from Tamil Nadu," the Collector said.

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Thursday announced a solatium of ₹7 lakh each to the families of the fishermen whose bodies had washed ashore, and directed that ₹2 lakh each be disbursed immediately.

SC refuses to transfer ghee adulteration case out of A.P.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday refused a plea to transfer the trial in the multi-crore Tirupati laddu ghee adulteration case trial outside Andhra Pradesh.

Appearing before a Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, senior advocate Siddharth Dave, appearing for Machindra Shantaram Lanke, a Maharashtra-based dairy businessman and a prime accused, said the atmosphere inside the State was "politically charged".

Mr. Dave said even the Chief Minister and Deputy Chief Minister were publicly making pointed remarks derogatory to fair trial in the case.

'Probe is with CBI'

Justice Joymalya Bagchi said the probe into the case was with a Central agency, the Central Bureau of Investigation, which was not bothered by any commentary from the corridors of power and political functionaries within the State of Andhra Pradesh.

"We have silenced them all with our order. If something happens, you can come to us," Chief Justice Kant remarked.

Taking a firm stand, the court however dismissed the plea.

The CBI and ED investigations into the case had revealed a ₹250 crore scam involving the supply of 68 lakh kg of fake and synthetic ghee to the Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams between 2019 and 2024.

Cyclone losses put at ₹1,919 crore in A.P.

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

Senior officials informed Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu on Thursday that as per a preliminary assessment, Cyclone Murasu has caused a loss of ₹1,919 crore. The officials, in a review meeting, said that agricultural crops were damaged in 1,43,122 hectares, affecting 1,86,063 farmers.

Horticulture crops suffered damage in 6,749 hectares, impacting 12,586 farmers. A total of 983 houses, 346 boats and 220 fishing nets were also damaged.

Mr. Naidu stressed the need to prioritise the restoration of power supply and providing uninterrupted drinking water supply.

10 rescue personnel missing in flooded Telangana lake traced

P Sridhar
KHAMMAM

Ten personnel from Telangana's State Disaster Response Force (SDRF) and Fire Department, who went missing after two inflatable boats capsized in the swollen Bethupalli Peddacheruvu in Khammam district on Wednesday, were rescued by Thursday morning.

The 10 rescue personnel were swept away by gushing floodwaters when two boats capsized during an operation to rescue nine fishermen stranded in the lake on Wednesday. All the missing personnel and fishermen were rescued after a search operation that continued for more than 12 hours.

The rescuers wearing life jackets managed to stay afloat before grabbing tree branches along the lake's course, said a police official. Their training and perseverance helped them survive until rescue teams reached them, he added.

Officials suspected that a breach in a minor irrigation tank upstream might have contributed to the sudden surge in the water level in Bhupali Peddacheruvu.

INBRIEF



Kerala HC grants anticipatory bail to judge in car crash case

The Kerala High Court on Thursday granted anticipatory bail to an additional judge whose minor son was allegedly involved in a car crash resulting in the death of a 55-year-old motorist at Cheranalloor in Kochi on October 25. Justice Kauser Edappagath observed that the additional judge had cooperated with the probe. The judge had been arraigned as the second accused in the case as he was the registered owner of the car. Jayabalakrishnan, who ran a wayside eatery, died after the luxury car reportedly driven by the judge's 17-year-old son rammed his two-wheeler.

Tribal woman killed by tiger near Bandipur Tiger Reserve

A tribal woman was reportedly killed in a tiger attack near the forest fringe at Nanjadevarabetta Hill, close to the Doranakatte Tribal Colony in Mysuru district of Karnataka, on Wednesday. The deceased was identified as Machamma (45). She was grazing her goats and sheep near a village bordering the Bandipur Tiger Reserve when a tiger reportedly dragged her into the forest and mauled her to death. Following the incident, residents of the colony have been cautioned. About 85 tribal families live in the colony adjacent to the forest fringe.

Karnataka hikes DA for State govt. staff from 15.75% to 18%

Karnataka has announced a Deepavali bonanza for State government employees by increasing the Dearness Allowance by 2.25 percentage points with retrospective effect from July 2026. According to a notification issued on Thursday, the Dearness Allowance (DA) for Karnataka government employees would now be increased from the present 15.75% to 18% of their basic pay. The increase will come into effect from July 1, 2026. The increase in DA will also apply to the pensioners and family pensioners, it said.

Keeping the flame



Lighting up: Srikakulam Parades, 95, one of the last practising traditional potters in Visakhapatnam, carefully shapes a clay lamp on a traditional potter's wheel at his home in Kummari Veedhi (Potters' Street) in Andhra Pradesh ahead of Deepavali on Thursday. K.R. DEEPAK

INDIA bloc demands SIR scrapped, pre-SIR rolls for civic polls

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The INDIA bloc on Thursday adopted a five-point resolution at its "Save the Vote, Save the Nation" protest at Freedom Park in Bengaluru, demanding the scrapping of the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and the rejection of the revised electoral rolls in Karnataka.

The declaration also urged the State government to conduct the forthcoming local body, taluk and zilla panchayat elections using the pre-SIR 2025 electoral rolls.

The resolution alleged that the names of more than 14 crore voters had been removed from electoral rolls nationwide. In Karnataka, the electorate had declined from 5.54 crore to approximately 4.5 crore in the final list published on October 27. Of the 99.32 lakh names removed, approximately 23 lakh pertained to deceased and duplicate voters, while nearly 76 lakh were alleged to be eligible voters, including migrants and those who had shifted residence.

Addressing the gathering, Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar announced that the State government would initiate a police investigation into the alleged misuse of Form 7 applications.

'Private involvement in nuclear sector won't dilute safety'

Tiki Rajwi
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

A.K. Balasubrahmanian, Chairperson, Atomic Energy Regulatory Board (AERB), has sought to allay concerns regarding the entry of private players into the country's sensitive nuclear energy sector, asserting that there will be no compromise on safety aspects. The sector, he says, is being opened up at the right time, given the emerging power requirement of the country.

As a regulator, the AERB will provide an "enabling environment" for private players, but at the same time, the board will not dilute the regulatory and safety requirements he told *The Hindu* on the sidelines of symposium on the emerging frontiers in nuclear science and technology organised here this week by the Atomic Energy Retirees' Association.

The AERB chairperson's remarks gain significance in the context of the Sustainable Harnessing and Advancement of Nuclear Energy for Transforming India Act, 2025 (SHANTI Act). He says the sector is being opened up at the right time, as India is targeting 100 GW of nuclear power capacity by 2047.

Five arrested as inter-State marijuana trafficking racket busted in Telangana

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

A former security guard who built an inter-State marijuana trafficking network with 100 consumers at Cyberabad in Hyderabad was arrested after a 60-day hunt by the EAGLE Force of the Telangana Police.

Bhaskar Hazarika, 31, who once worked as a security guard and delivery executive, operated a network of couriers and distributors that moved large consignments of marijuana from Odisha to Hyderabad.

EAGLE Director Sandeep Shandilya said that Mr. Hazarika was arrested along with four other members of the Assam-based gang.



Bhaskar Hazarika and four of his associates with the 24.7 kg of marijuana seized from them. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The operation led to the seizure of 24.7 kg of marijuana and seven mobile phones. The five arrested persons were Mr. Hazarika; Babu Borah, 37; Nirmal Hazarika, 26; Pranajal Dutta, 25; and Akan Rajbanshi, 34. All five are from Assam and resided in Prem Nagar, New Hafeezpet.

"Bhaskar had been booked in three marijuana cases in Madhapur and Gachibowli in 2024," explained the officer.

An examination of inter-bank transactions showed that between February 2 and October 29, 2026, Mr. Bhaskar purchased marijuana worth ₹48 lakh from supplier Ashish Kumar in 88 transactions. The purchase price was between ₹12,000 and ₹15,000 per kg, while the gang sold it at around ₹50,000 per kg.

Investigators estimate that about 400 kg of marijuana was moved through this supply chain, generating sales of nearly ₹1.8 crore in 10 months. The police said he also had other sources of supply.

Activists move SC seeking bail in Delhi riots case

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Activists Umar Khalid and Sharjeel Imam have approached the Supreme Court challenging the Delhi High Court's September 30 order refusing them bail in the larger conspiracy case linked to the February 2020 Delhi riots.

In their petitions, the two have contended that their continued incarceration for over six years, with the trial yet to commence, violates the Constitutional guarantee of personal liberty under Article 21. They have also pointed out that the one-year restriction imposed by the Supreme Court on filing fresh bail applications is nearing its expiry.

On January 5, a Bench of Justices Aravind Kumar and N.V. Anjaria denied bail to Mr. Khalid and Mr. Imam, describing them as "ideological drivers" of the alleged larger conspiracy. The Bench held that the two stood "qualitatively on a different footing" from the other accused, observing that the material on record *prima facie* indicated their "formative roles" in the alleged conspiracy.

Visa mandatory for migrants from six non-Muslim communities: MHA

The amendment applies to people from Afghanistan, Bangladesh and Pakistan who, fearing 'religious persecution', entered India on or before December 31, 2024 without valid travel documents, or whose documents have since expired

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI



Sri Lankan Tamil refugees who came to India before 2015 will not be penalised if found without travel documents. FILE PHOTO

The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) has amended the Immigration and Foreigners (Exemption) Order, 2025, making it mandatory for members of six non-Muslim communities from Afghanistan, Bangladesh and Pakistan who, fearing "religious persecution", entered India on or before December 31, 2024, without valid travel documents, or whose documents have since expired, to obtain an "appropriate visa" for their continued stay in the country.

The amendment, notified on November 4 through the Immigration and Foreigners (Exemption) (Amendment) Order, 2026, retains the exemption granted through a September 2, 2025 notification to Hindus, Sikhs, Buddhists, Jains, Parsis and Christians from the three countries from the requirement of possessing valid passports or visas at the time of entry and stay in India. The 2025 exemption order had been issued under the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025, consolidating several earlier notifications that exempted members of these minority communities from prosecution under passport and foreigners laws.

Exempted categories

The latest amendment aligns the exempted categories with the Citizenship (Amendment) Act (CAA), 2019 which fast-tracked Indian citizenship for the six non-Muslim minorities from the three neighbouring countries who entered India before December 31, 2014.

The amendment also revises provisions governing travel by Indian, Nepali and Bhutanese citizens, and reorganises several categories of exemptions covering Tibetan refugees, registered Sri Lankan Tamil refugees and certain other foreign nationals.

The notification also introduced a formal definition of the "Visa Manual", describing it as the manual issued by the Central government containing instructions relating to visas, immigration and associated matters.

Indian citizens travelling to Nepal or Bhutan and Nepali and Bhutanese citizens entering or exiting India will now be required to produce identity documents specified in the Visa Manual before immigration authorities.

The amendment also reorganises several categories of exempted persons in other sections of the Order. The status of registered Sri Lankan Tamil refugees who took shelter in India up to January 9, 2015, exempting them from penal provisions if found to be without valid passports, travel documents or visa, remains the same.

The exemption now also includes members of India's armed forces travelling on duty and their accompanying family members on government transport, and foreign military personnel arriving on warships or government vessels undergoing repairs in India.

Tibetans who entered India after 1959 but before the May 30, 2003 on the Entry Permit issued by the Embassy of India in Kathmandu or who entered India after May, 30 2003 on the Special Entry Permit issued by the Embassy of India in Kathmandu through a designated immigration post on the Indo-Nepal border will continue to be exempted from visa and passport requirements but they should be registered with the Registration Officer concerned and obtain a Certificate of Registration in accordance with the rules.

Long-term residents

The notification further provides relief to certain categories of long-term residents who face difficulties in renewing foreign passports. These include some Pakistani nationals who entered India before December 31, 2009 with the intention of permanent settlement, certain Partition-era migrants who returned from Pakistan and settled in Kerala, and persons of Indian origin who later acquired Malaysian or Singaporean citizenship but are unable to renew their passports.

The amended order requires persons covered by these categories as well to obtain an appropriate visa for their continued stay in India.

Foreign Secretary sets stage for Nepal PM's upcoming visit

Kallol Bhattacherjee
NEW DELHI


Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri during a meet with Nepal Prime Minister Balendra Shah. PTI

Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri on Thursday met Nepal Prime Minister Balendra Shah in Kathmandu, with discussions focused on "possible outcomes and initiatives" from the upcoming visit of the Himalayan nation's leader to New Delhi.

Concluding his official engagements in Nepal that spanned Wednesday and Thursday, Mr. Misri also met Nepal Finance Minister Swarnim Wagle and Foreign Minister Sisir Khanal.

"The Foreign Secretary of India highlighted the wide-ranging engagement and overall progress in diverse areas of bilateral cooperation, and discussed possible outcomes and initiatives in the context of the upcoming visit of the Prime Minister of Nepal to India," stated a joint press release issued by the Ministry of External Affairs and Kathmandu's Ministry of Foreign Affairs.

Mr. Misri held detailed talks with his host, Nepali Foreign Secretary Amrit Bahadur Rai, on the "mutually beneficial partnership" between India and Nepal. Mr. Shah had earlier this year highlighted the border dispute with India in the Lipulekh-Kalapai-Limpiyadhura area that is part of India's Uttarakhand but claimed by Nepal as a sticking point in ties.

Mr. Shah had sought to involve other countries, such as the United Kingdom and China, in talks on the issue. India, though, wants the matter to be resolved bilaterally.

The Nepali leaders expressed "gratitude for India's swift and substantial humanitarian and technical assistance in the aftermath of the Bhotekoshi floods", the joint press release stated.

Naga groups urge Modi to secure a political solution to Manipur crisis

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI



The Naga groups urged the Centre to withdraw the Assam Rifles from the region. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Nagas took out rallies in conflict-scarred Manipur's Kamjong and Ukhrul districts on Thursday, urging Prime Minister Narendra Modi to help secure a permanent political solution that will end the violence wracking the State.

The protesters demanded that the Centre recognise the Manipur crisis as a historical problem rooted in "illegal" Kuki immigration, as well as disparity between the tribal hills and the largely non-tribal Imphal Valley that is the State's power centre.

Four Tangkhul Naga organisations, under the banner of the United Naga Council, Manipur's apex Naga body, organised the simultaneous rallies in the two Naga-majority districts.

The organisations said Manipur's conflict started between the Kukis and Meiteis in May 2023 and escalated into a Kuki-Naga clash after a Naga civilian was assaulted in Ukhrul district in February this year. They alleged that Kuki extremists subsequently opened a new front in the violence with a series of killings, abductions and arson attacks on Naga civilians.

"Till date, more than 32 Naga civilians have been killed. The most gruesome of all being the recovery of the mutilated bodies of six abducted Liangmai Nagas on 10th June, 2026... The latest being the brutal murder of Ajinbou Ringkangmai on 10th October, 2026. He was beheaded," the memorandum read.

Lamenting the government's failure to catch the main culprits, the Tangkhul organisations said conflict was not new to Manipur due to "historical demographic distortions caused by skewed Kuki refugee/immigration policy and the influx of illegal Kuki immigrants from Burma".

"From barely 73 villages as per the 1,881 census, the number of Kuki villages within the State of Manipur has mushroomed into as many as 1,878. Swathes of tribal land and tracts of village hills and mountains are being encroached upon by the Kuki militants," the organisations wrote, alleging that these were being used as poppy plantations by cartels.

The Naga groups urged the Centre to stop the "militarisation" of Naga areas and withdraw the paramilitary Assam Rifles from the region.

They also called for the identification of all Kuki refugees and illegal immigrants for repatriation and deportation to their countries of origin in a time-bound manner.

In addition, they asked the Centre to revoke the Suspension of Operations agreement signed with more than 20 Kuki extremist groups.

Three women killed in coal heap collapse in Jharkhand

Press Trust of India
BOKARO

At least three women were killed and three others injured after a heap of coal collapsed at Central Coalfield Limited's (CCL) Kathara colliery in Jharkhand's Bokaro district on Thursday, a senior official said.

The incident occurred under the jurisdiction of the Kathara police outpost in Bokaro around 5 a.m. "Six people were injured after a coal pile collapsed at Kathara. Three of them succumbed to their injuries," Bokaro Deputy Commissioner Ajay Nath Jha said. The deceased were identified as Kaushlya Devi, Pushpa Devi and Sohri Devi.

Bermo Sub-divisional Police Officer (SDPO) Ravindra Singh said some village women were collecting coal from a coal heap when it collapsed.

A CCL official said it was a case of coal theft.

Five bodies retrieved at Odisha landslide site; toll rises to seven

The Hindu Bureau
BHUBANESWAR

Six days of intensive search and rescue operations in a remote in Ganjam district of Odisha following Cyclone Arnab yielded results on Thursday, with disaster response teams recovering five bodies from the landslide debris, taking the death toll to seven.

Three bodies were recovered in the morning, while two more were retrieved in the afternoon at Gidipabali village under Bhanjanagar block. All five victims belonged to the same family – a couple and their three children, residents of Gidipabali. Their last rites were performed near the village.

"Teams retrieved five bodies from the landslide debris at Gidipabali. Their identities have been established. They belong to one family," said Kandhamal Collector Vedbhusan on Thursday.

Although Gidipabali falls under Ganjam district, its remote location and difficult terrain make it accessible only through neighbouring Kandhamal district.

For the past six days, disaster response personnel from the Odisha Disaster Rapid Action Force, National Disaster Response Force, Odisha Fire Service and Special Operations Group, along with Indian Railways engineers and local residents, had been engaged in the search and rescue operation.

Earlier, Fire Services Director General Sudhanshu Sarangi had described the task of clearing the massive volume of debris deposited over several houses in the village as a herculean challenge. Controlled explosions had to be carried out to break and remove huge boulders obstructing the operation. Sources said the rescue operation would continue.

DRDO carries out successful flight-test of Pralay missile

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) on Thursday successfully flight-tested the indigenously developed quasi-ballistic missile Pralay from Dr. APJ Abdul Kalam Island off the Odisha coast. The successful trial paved the way for its imminent induction into the armed forces.

According to Ministry of Defence, the missile was test-fired at around 11.10 a.m. as part of user evaluation trials. All test objectives were fully met, as confirmed by data captured through various range instruments deployed by the Integrated Test Range (ITR), Chandipur, the Defence Ministry said.

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh congratulated DRDO, the armed forces and industry partners on the successful test.

Two more bodies recovered from trek route in Uttarakhand

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Two more bodies were recovered on Thursday from the avalanche-hit Kedartal trekking route in Uttarkashi district of Uttarakhand, taking the death toll to six. While the rescue teams continued the search for the two other missing trekkers, families waiting for news began to lose hope.

According to the district administration, the two bodies recovered on Wednesday were identified as Rintu Mondol, 40, and Uday Ghosh, 30, both residents of Bankura, West Bengal. Six bodies, including the two from today, have been recovered for the site so far.

Eight people from an expedition of 13 went missing after heavy snowfall and multiple avalanches cut off the route.

Among the people who went missing were seven trekkers – Tapas Bauri, Ratan Ghosh, Mr. Mondal, Mr. Ghosh, Manoj Khawas, all from West Bengal; Vartika and Deepika Verma, sisters from Lucknow – and guide Siddharth Rana.

Vishwajeet, nephew of Mr. Bauri, who is among the missing trekkers, said his family was gradually coming to terms with the possibility that he might not return. "I don't think I will get to see my uncle alive," he said, adding that Mr. Bauri, who used to work at an iron goods manufacturing factory, had saved money for the trekking expedition.

Centre defends Agnipath changes, clarifies scheme is not rolled back

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI


After an initial term, 75% of the Agniveers who are not absorbed into the regular cadre will get two-year engagement. FILE PHOTO

A day after announcing a two-year extension of the Agniveer engagement period, the government on Thursday clarified that the Agnipath scheme has not been rolled back and that the revised arrangement creates a pathway for all Agniveers to eventually join the regular cadre of the armed forces.

According to Ministry of Defence sources, the scheme remains unchanged in its basic structure, with an additional engagement period of two years introduced for the 75% of Agniveers who are not absorbed into the regular cadre after their initial four-year tenure. At the end of the second engagement period, all those willing and meeting the prescribed eligibility will be absorbed as regular soldiers, officials said.

Addressing concerns over the seniority of the 75% Agniveers who will serve for six years before joining the regular cadre, a Defence Ministry official said their seniority would be protected. On absorption, they will be placed immediately after their respective batchmates who entered the regular cadre after completing the initial four-year engagement period. They will not be placed below personnel belonging to subsequent batches, the official clarified.

The official also confirmed that there would be no numerical cap on the absorption of the remaining 75% after the second engagement period. While the first 25% will continue to be absorbed after four years, the remaining Agniveers will be inducted into the regular cadre after six years, provided they are willing, physically fit and maintain the required standards of discipline.

The Cabinet decision has drawn mixed reactions from military veterans, with questions being raised over its implications for the original structure of the Agnipath scheme and the long-term personnel management of the armed forces.

Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh described the revised arrangement as a "win-win solution", saying the scheme had envisaged a reassessment after the initial four-year period.

SC asks Allahabad HC to hear Azam Khan's appeal on priority

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday advised senior Samajwadi Party leader Azam Khan to approach the Allahabad High Court against his arrest by the Directorate of Enforcement (ED) outside Rampur Jail on October 31 and his subsequent remand to judicial custody by a CBI judge on November 1.

A Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant requested the High Court to take up the case on a priority basis on November 16.

The Bench allowed Mr. Khan's counsel, senior advocate Kapil Sibal and advocate Nizam Pasha, liberty to amend the petition to include additional prayers for relief. The apex court clarified that it has not said anything on the merits of the case.

"The petitioner, Mohd. Azam Khan... is constrained to approach the Supreme Court... on account of blatant illegality of his arrest, including the manner and timing and the gross abuse of process and *mala fide* exercise of power whereby the machinery of criminal justice system is used for political ends," Mr. Khan's petition said.

The senior counsel said Mr. Khan was subjected to a "series of politically motivated cases foisted upon him, and he was taken into custody in these cases one after the other in a manner calculated to ensure his indefinite incarceration".

Rahul disrupting House, spreading anarchy, says Shah

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH


Amit Shah

Hitting out at Congress leader and the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday accused him of disrupting Parliament, and turning boycotts into a hallmark of the Congress party. Mr. Shah was addressing a gathering during the BJP's '*Loktantra Bachao, Arajakta Hatao*' (save democracy, remove anarchy) foot march in Haryana's Karnal.

"Rahul Gandhi*ji*... You have made boycott and noise in Parliament the culture of the Congress party. [You are] not letting Parliament run and gathering crowds on the road to spread anarchy," Mr. Shah said. The BJP's nationwide 'Save Democracy' campaign began on October 22, against the backdrop of Opposition parties protesting over allegations of electoral irregularities and the functioning of democratic institutions.

'Special session for SIR'

As the BJP's campaign drew to a close, Mr. Shah said that the party would give a fitting reply, with the government ready to convene a special session to discuss the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. "I want to challenge Rahul*ji*, if you want to discuss, then write a letter to Modi*ji*. We are ready to call a special session of Parliament to discuss EVM [electronic voting machines], etc," he said.

"The BJP will search for the intruders and remove them from the voter list... Our resolve is not going to weaken by your '*Ghuspetiya Bachao* (save infiltrators) rally' [INDIA bloc's November 1 rally]," he said.

Hitting back at Mr. Shah, Congress leader Pawan Khera, in a post on X, questioned the Union Minister's handling of internal security, citing the violence in Manipur, Pahalgam attack, blast near Red Fort and the recovery of 300 kg of RDX near the national capital.

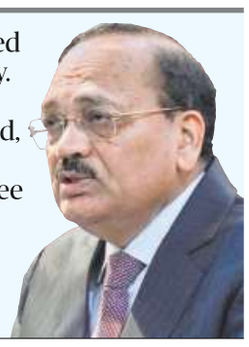
"*Mota bhai* (big brother), if the Home Ministry is beyond your control, why are you still clinging to that chair? In seven years, you have not been able to manage the nation's three crore *ghuspetiyas*," he said.

Got very few complaints on July 20 'police brutality': SC

Despite public notices assuring confidentiality, there was a lack of complaints, says SC-constituted panel; SC lets petitioners to forward material, including video clips, to the panel for consideration

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

> The Committee need not wait indefinitely. Whatever material comes, whosoever needs to respond, let them give responses. We would like the Committee to now start giving fact-finding reports
>
> **SURYA KANT**
> Chief Justice of India



The Supreme Court on Thursday said "very few complaints" were received directly on the online portal of the High Powered Enquiry Committee (HPEC) inquiring into allegations of police brutality and sexual abuse of women during the July 20 violence sparked by demonstrations against the NEET-UG 2026 question paper leaks, which culminated in the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as Education Minister.

A Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, after perusing an Action Taken Report (ATR) submitted by the HPEC on October 31, said that while the HPEC portal hardly saw any response, no complaints were received via email, post or through physical delivery to the HPEC offices.

The HPEC, chaired by former apex court judge, Justice R. Subhash Reddy, was constituted in August by the Supreme Court. It had launched its online portal three weeks ago in mid-October.

The ATR said the lack of complaints from the protesters was despite repeated public notices that the grievances would be maintained confidentially, and would only be accessible to the Chairperson and HPEC members.

The report said the complaints could also be filed anonymously, without disclosing names, phone numbers, addresses or Aadhaar details. The portal had separate windows for affected protesters and police personnel.

The Bench said that under such circumstances, and in light of the ATR, the petitioners before the apex court could forward whatever material, including video clips, they had of the violence to the HPEC for its consideration.

"The materials or information forwarded by the parties may be examined by the HPEC," the court ordered. The Bench said the committee could look into available complaints and progress as more trickle in.

'No info from police'

The direction came in response to a submission by advocate Vrinda Grover that the police authorities had not shared any information, evidence or material with the HPEC as yet.

"If pellet guns were fired, who authorised it... what is the order... where is the ammunition register... The HPEC report does not seem to show as if the authorities have provided any such material. Why have they not placed the records before the HPEC," Ms. Grover asked.

The Chief Justice said the petitions seeking such information should be considered by the HPEC and they must record responses to it from the authorities without any further delay.

"The Committee need not wait indefinitely. Whatever material comes, whosoever needs to respond, let them give responses. We would like the Committee to now start giving fact-finding reports," Justice Kant recorded in the order.

Senior advocate N. Hariharan said legal questions such as whether "monitoring or surveillance of protesters, if undertaken, was consistent with their constitutional rights to privacy and free assembly" should not be left to the Committee.

"The court itself has to look into these questions. The Committee cannot look into such substantial issues affecting fundamental rights," he said.

The court asked the HPEC to submit its first fact-finding report within a month. It said the relevant findings of the panel should ordinarily be shared with all the parties unless circumstances require confidentiality.

The matter would be taken up again in December.

On July 20, police cracked down on the protest called by the Cockroach Janta Party in Delhi, leaving several people injured.

Puri wins RS seat unopposed amid Congress criticism

The Hindu Bureau
BHOPAL


Hardeep Singh Puri

Union Minister for Petroleum and Natural Gas Hardeep Singh Puri was on Thursday elected for the Rajya Sabha unopposed from Madhya Pradesh in the byelection for a seat that fell vacant after the resignation of former Union Minister L. Murugan.

While the byelection was scheduled for Thursday, Mr. Puri's election was declared on Thursday two days after the nomination papers of two independent candidates, one of them backed by the Congress, were rejected. November 5 was the last date to withdraw nominations.

Mr. Puri's election certificate was received by Madhya Pradesh Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) president Hemant Khandelwal and Deputy Chief Minister Jagdish Devda at the State Legislative Assembly.

Alleged Epstein links

Mr. Puri was announced the BJP candidate for the byelection on October 28, weeks after Mr. Murugan, whose term was to end in 2030, gave up his membership of the Upper House.

His nomination received criticism from the Opposition Congress over Mr. Puri's alleged links with the convicted U.S. sex offender and trafficker Jeffrey Epstein, as referenced in the files released in that country. The party also claimed that Mr. Murugan had been "forced to" resign to make way for Mr. Puri.

It had also challenged Mr. Puri's nomination with the Returning Officer Umesh Sharma, alleging that his affidavit was "invalid" due to legal discrepancies.

His election to the Rajya Sabha, however, ends months of speculation over his exit from the Union Cabinet amid the Epstein Files controversy.

Mr. Puri is the only Sikh Minister in the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance government and his continuation in the Cabinet holds significance ahead of the Assembly elections in Punjab in early 2027, especially when BJP leader Ravneet Singh Bittu was dropped as a Minister in July 2026, after he did not secure a re-nomination for the Rajya Sabha.

Trump's failed redistricting gamble offers BJP a lesson in delimitation ambitions

NEWS ANALYSIS

Varghese K. George
NEW DELHI


Ballot lessons: After collapse of Donald Trump's hypernationalist politics, the BJP could reflect on its approach to delimitation. AFP

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has lessons to draw from the Republican Party in the United States (U.S.) in its attempts to undertake a hurried, hushed and partisan redrawing of the country's electoral map.

The BJP has been planning for an out-of-cycle Census and a delimitation exercise by delaying the 2021 Census until 2026.

The Republican Party redrew Congressional district boundaries across eight States under the direction of President Donald J. Trump in the hope of flipping seats currently held by Democrats. But they lost most of them and, in addition, faced setbacks in its strongholds.

Gerrymandering, the practice of redrawing electoral boundaries by packing or cracking particular social groups, assumes voting preferences remain unchanged between election cycles. But when the traditional supporters of a party turn against it, constituency maps matter little.

The Bankipur byelection in Bihar in August had proved the same point. The constituency is perfectly tailored for a BJP victory, going by its demographic composition. But when the upper-caste supporters of the party changed their minds, the BJP was decimated.

Gerrymandering works in many cases, as it did for the BJP in Assam, and Jammu and Kashmir, where constituency boundaries were drastically redrawn in a manner that suited the BJP. While the party may have made gains in polls in Jammu and Kashmir, and Assam that are attributable to delimitation, Bankipur was a demonstration of what happens when supporters desert the party.

Among the many things the BJP could learn from the collapse of Mr. Trump's hypernationalist politics is in its approach to delimitation. Realising the 2026 elections were going to be tough, Mr. Trump prodded Republican-run States into undertaking out-of-turn redistricting. The plan was to win five additional seats in Texas, four in Florida, two in Ohio, and one each in Alabama, Louisiana, North Carolina, and Tennessee.

Historic political shift

Analysts found that the Democrats held on to nearly all of these seats and picked up seats held by Republicans. In other words, gerrymandering was undertaken, but it did not help stop the tide of public opinion turning against the Republicans.

Constituency boundaries become irrelevant when an entire State or region, across communities, changes its political preferences. This is reflected in the outcome of the Texas Senate race. In a historic political shift, Democrat James Talarico defeated Republican Ken Paxton.

The victory broke the Republican Party's three-decade monopoly on statewide office. It is akin to Gujaratis, who have voted for the BJP regardless of constituency boundaries, suddenly shifting their loyalty to another party.

The gerrymandering undertaken by Republican States followed the voting pattern of the 2024 election won by Mr. Trump, and district boundaries were redrawn to contain more than 50% of his voters in most cases. But voters had other plans two years later. Republicans were hoping for a 30-8 split in the Congressional contingent, but ended up with 24-14. Texas Republicans have one less than they had at the start of the current Congress.

Though the redistricting did not rescue the Republicans from the deluge, it triggered another strand of partisanship in the already fractious politics of the U.S.

Democrats in California responded with their own gerrymandering, which may have at least partially helped them flip at least three Republican-held seats. Now, with more States under Democratic control, the party is planning its own out-of-turn redistricting ahead of the 2028 polls.

Elections are meant to measure public opinion; when they are turned into instruments for manipulating the expression of public opinion, the cost can be high for a nation.

The world's oldest democracy is facing that challenge. The world's largest should take note.

States to track Census data collection in real time

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI


Around the corner: Door-to-door enumeration for second phase of the Census is set to begin on December 1 in the poll-bound States of Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Punjab, and Goa. C. VENKATACHALAPATHY

The Registrar-General and Census Commissioner of India (RG&CCI) has asked all States to track the progress of data collection during the population enumeration (PE) phase of Census 2027 in real time, enabling authorities to identify "data quality concerns" and initiate corrective measures in a "timely" manner.

Such interventions were not possible during past Census exercises as they were done on paper schedules. The 2027 Census is the first to use digital data collection.

In a letter sent to Chief Secretaries and Directors of Census Operations (DCO) of all States on October 30, RG&CCI Mritunjay Kumar Narayan said the Census Management and Monitoring System (CMMS) will serve as the primary platform for planning, monitoring, supervision, training, management, and deployment of field functionaries, as well as issue resolution and the overall conduct of the PE phase.

"The information available through CMMS shall be regularly reviewed to identify lagging areas, operational bottlenecks, coverage gaps, deployment issues, training deficiencies, data quality concerns and other factors that may adversely affect the conduct of PE," he said in the letter.

The reports and monitoring tools available in CMMS will facilitate timely corrective action, targeted supervisory intervention, and effective coordination among different administrative levels, he added.

First digital Census

Door-to-door enumeration for this second phase of the Census is all set to begin on December 1 in the poll-bound States of Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Punjab, and Goa. It already concluded on September 30 in Ladakh and the snow-bound areas of Jammu and Kashmir, Uttarakhand, and Himachal Pradesh. The rest of the country will begin the exercise only on January 25, 2027.

Enumerators will ask a set of 40 questions in this phase, including 13 new questions that will be asked for the first time ever; caste (other than Scheduled Tribe/Scheduled Caste); religion, place and date of birth of both parents; number of bank accounts; spouse's name; nationality; digital literacy; permanent residential address; place of Covid-19 vaccination; passport number; driving licence availability; and mobile, Aadhaar, and voter ID numbers, if available.

On June 4, *The Hindu* had reported that during the first houselisting operations phase of the Census, enumerators in Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan were asked to revisit households and correct data "discrepancies", particularly on issues such as open defecation and household access to electricity or cooking gas connections.

Around 34 lakh enumerators, most of them government school teachers, will be deployed across the country and assigned enumeration blocks (EBs), each comprising approximately 700 to 800 people.

This is the first digital Census and enumerators will record the data collected through an app on their personal phones.

"Monitor progress of PE on a continuous basis during field operations, including coverage of households and population, quality indicators, supervisory checks and completion status of Enumeration Blocks... The Supervisor shall monitor coverage, ensure data quality, verify completeness, and facilitate timely completion of field operations," the RG&CCI said in his letter.

Cong. says SIR move would cut off several welfare beneficiaries

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Linking the special intensive revision (SIR) of the electoral rolls with a Union Minister's recent remarks that voter IDs will replace Aadhaar for identifying beneficiaries for social welfare programmes, the Congress on Thursday criticised the Centre stating that this move will exclude people on a "massive scale".

Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh said 'vote *chori* (theft)' is just the trailer and the full picture is '*haq-huqooq* (rights) *chori*'.

Union Panchayati Raj Minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh, alias Lallan Singh, last week said that access to financial benefits and welfare payments under the Ministry's schemes will now require an Elector's Photo Identity Card (EPIC) number along with mandatory biometric authentication.

Mr. Ramesh said: "Over the past few days, the Union Minister of Panchayati Raj has said not once but twice that voter ID will replace Aadhaar for identifying beneficiaries for social welfare programmes. Is this now the official Modi govt. policy?"

If indeed it is, then it means that Aadhaar will not be used for the primary purpose for which it was conceived and intended, he said.

Jantar Mantar trespassing: CJP leaders appear before police

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI


Youth leaders: Ashutosh Ranka and Saurav Das speak to media while leaving Crime Branch office in New Delhi on Thursday. ANI

Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) co-conveners Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka appeared before the Delhi Police Crime Branch in Rajouri Garden on Thursday after being summoned for questioning in connection with cases linked to trespassing into the denotified Jantar Mantar protest site in October.

After appearing before the investigators, Mr. Ranka said the two leaders will cooperate with the probe. "Today's questioning was part of a routine investigation into the events of October 13. We will fully cooperate with any probe being conducted by any agency. Unfurling the National Flag at Jantar Mantar or on any public road should not be considered a crime. We are confident the investigation will be conducted in good faith," he told media.

Responding to allegations of foreign funding against the CJP, Mr. Das dismissed them as baseless and accused groups associated with the right wing of running a campaign to discredit the movement.

The two leaders had earlier been arrested and sent to judicial custody after entering the denotified protest site and waving the National Flag with 12 other persons on October 13.

The police had also said that their actions violated a peace bond they had signed on October 11.

INBRIEF



INS Sahyadri reaches Japan for MALABAR naval exercise

The Indian Navy's indigenous stealth frigate *INS Sahyadri* arrived at Yokosuka Naval Base in Japan on Wednesday to participate in the multilateral naval exercise MALABAR 2026, which brings together the navies of India, Japan, the United States, and Australia. According to the Indian Navy, the warship, part of the Eastern Fleet, was accorded a warm welcome by the Japan Maritime Self-Defense Force (JMSDF). The exercise will provide an opportunity to the participating navies to enhance operational coordination, strengthen interoperability and exchange professional expertise through a series of engagements during the harbour and sea phases.

4 killed, 2 missing as SUV falls into river near Gangotri

Four people were killed and two remain missing after an SUV carrying seven passengers plunged into the raging Bhagirathi river near Gangnani in Uttarkashi district on Thursday. The passengers, reportedly from Gujarat, were travelling to the Gangotri temple. According to police, the accident took place on the Gangotri National Highway when the vehicle reportedly went out of control and plunged into the river. Rescue teams recovered four bodies from the riverbank during an operation involving the local police, State Disaster Response Force (SDRF) and emergency medical services. A 17-year-old passenger was rescued, while two persons remain missing.

At least 2 bodies found after building collapse in Old Delhi

At least two bodies have been identified and several others are feared trapped after a three-storey building under construction collapsed near Chawri Bazaar Metro station in Old Delhi on Thursday morning. Four persons were already rescued by locals and shifted to hospital before fire personnel arrived, they said. According to DCP (Central) Rohit Rajbir Singh, around 15 construction workers were present at the site when the building collapsed. Six to seven workers have been accounted for so far, of whom four escaped unhurt. Three workers were pulled out of the debris; two were declared dead, while the third is out of danger.

10 Gulf carriers denied airport slots at Mumbai

At least 10 smaller Gulf carriers have had their requests for slots at Mumbai airport rejected, with the Adani-operated airport requiring airlines to shift to Navi Mumbai, according to airline sources. The airlines include Oman Air, Bahrain's Gulf Air, Sharjah-based Air Arabia, Kuwait Airways and Jazeera Airways from Kuwait, Doha-based Qatar Airways, and four carriers from Saudi Arabia – Flyadeal, Flynas, Riyadh Air and Saudia – it is reliably learnt. This comes as Mumbai airport plans to suspend flights to 14 international destinations, which will be served from Navi Mumbai. The destinations include Bahrain, Dammam, Dhaka and Doha.

Merchant charge has been imposed to save UPI ecosystem, NPCI tells SC

'Zero Merchant Discount Rate' for all UPI transactions is no longer sustainable as functional costs would burn into the public exchequer, says payments body in affidavit; the fee will apply to only about 4% of merchant transactions, it adds

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI



UPI processed 24.51 billion transactions, cumulatively worth about ₹29.82 lakh crore, in the month of August 2026 alone. REUTERS

The National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) has said in the Supreme Court that "zero Merchant Discount Rate (MDR)" for all Unified Payments Interface (UPI) transactions was no longer sustainable, as functional costs for the phenomenally expanding digital payment industry in India would burn into the public exchequer.

UPI processed as many as 24.51 billion transactions, cumulatively worth approximately ₹29.82 lakh crore, in the month of August 2026 alone, marking its highest-ever monthly volume. An average of approximately 791 million transactions were processed every single day in that month. In Financial Year 2025-26, UPI processed approximately 241.62 billion transactions worth approximately ₹314 lakh crore, the NPCI said.

"The figures illustrate not merely growth, but growth of a magnitude that places correspondingly greater demands on the security, resilience, and infrastructural capacity of the system," the NPCI, represented by Additional Solicitor-General N. Venkataraman, submitted in court.

Legal challenge

The NPCI was responding to a challenge in court to the government's decision to introduce an MDR of 0.4% on Person-to-Merchant (P2M) UPI transactions above ₹2,000.

Person-to-person (P2P) transactions, which account for 70% of total UPI transaction value, would remain completely free irrespective of amount, the NCPI said. There would be no transaction or platform fee or other charge permissible for individuals for sending or receiving money through UPI, it added.

It said person-to-merchant (P2M) payments up to ₹2,000 would also remain "entirely free of MDR". "This threshold is calibrated to shield the overwhelming majority of everyday, low-value merchant payments of the kind made by ordinary consumers and small merchants alike," the NPCI said.

The affidavit said that the amended MDR framework targeted only higher value commerce without disturbing low-value transactions that drive the mass adoption of UPI. The MDR charge, which did not exceed 0.4%, would apply to P2M transactions above ₹2,000. "Effectively, MDR will apply to only about 4% of merchant transactions, and approximately 96% of all P2M will remain unaffected," the NPCI said.

'MDR is not a tax'

The NPCI countered the petitioners' contention that an amended MDR framework should have been introduced only through a new legislation and not just through a notification in September. It argued that MDR was not a tax, cess, fee, duty or any other statutory levy imposed by or under a legislative enactment. It was plainly a 'charge' collected to recover the huge costs associated with the functioning of the payment system, and was in turn, distributed entirely amongst the participants in the UPI ecosystem. "MDR is a charge collected by the system participants to recover the costs incurred in running the payment system, and not an imposition pursuant to any delegation of legislative or fiscal power by Parliament, the Central Government or RBI," the NPCI submitted.

In a 100-page affidavit, the NPCI said that, as a system provider, it had the liberty to determine the MDR applicable to transactions processed through the payment system operated by it. The NPCI recalled how the government's efforts to cover the costs of zero MDR from 2021-2022 through incentive schemes had been a huge financial strain on the public exchequer.

Further, the UPI Steering Committee, which includes third party application providers, had endorsed the MDR framework, the NCPI said.

Centre to set up panel to review UGC equity norms

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Union government is "contemplating" having a special committee review the University Grants Commission (Promotion of Equity in Higher Education Institutions) Regulations, 2026, it said in a submission in the Supreme Court on Thursday. The Regulations were intended to fight discrimination within educational campuses, but had triggered protests by upper caste students claiming that the rules were one-sided.

In a brief hearing before a Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, for the government, sought more time to come back with a comprehensive response, but added that the Centre was examining criticism about the 2026 Regulations.

In January 2026, the top court had stayed the Regulations, finding them "too sweeping" and vague. It had ordered that the University Grants Commission Regulations, 2012 would continue to be in force.

CERT-In lays out security norms for Agentic AI systems

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In) has set out specific security and auditing requirements for artificial intelligence (AI) systems that can independently plan and carry out tasks, use external tools, and delegate work to other AI systems.

The Artificial Intelligence (AI) Security Auditing Guidelines: Framework for Secure, Ethical, and Auditable Artificial Intelligence Systems issued by the country's top cybersecurity agency identify features such as autonomous task execution, persistent memory, and the ability to delegate work as factors that can increase the risks associated with these systems.

Unlike conventional AI tools that primarily respond to user instructions, agentic AI systems can take multiple steps to complete a task. They may access information, use software tools, execute code, or communicate with external systems.

The guidelines identify such capabilities as factors requiring closer security scrutiny.

The framework calls for testing whether an AI agent can exceed its authorised permissions, use tools without approval, bypass approval mechanisms, or misuse credentials. It also identifies unsafe delegation of tasks and the effectiveness of emergency-stop mechanisms as areas that auditors should examine.

The guidelines also address the risks associated with an agent's memory and the information it retains from earlier interactions or tasks.

Hacking group behind bank attacks identified

Reuters
BENGALURU/MUMBAI

India's cybersecurity agency has named the hacking group behind a wave of AI-driven attacks on financial firms and identified the tools it used, at least two of them linked to China.

The group, which the Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In) calls "Crafty Falcon", has breached non-bank lenders, fintech firms and cryptocurrency exchanges, according to an advisory issued on Wednesday.

CERT-In said the attackers use publicly available AI tools to automate break-ins "at machine speed". It named four tools: ARTEX, PentAGI, Cairn and CyberStrikeAI.

Navigation satellite NVS-03 is fully healthy: ISRO Chairman

Aloysius Xavier Lopez
CHENNAI

ISRO's next-generation navigation satellite NVS-03, launched on October 30 to strengthen India's NavIC regional satellite navigation system, is "fully healthy", ISRO Chairman V. Narayanan said on Thursday.

Speaking at the inauguration of the statue of legendary astronaut Yuri Gagarin at the Periyar Science and Technology Centre, Mr. Narayanan said, "NVS-03, successfully launched on October 30 midnight, was perfectly placed in the elliptical orbit. From there, we operated the engine of the satellite for 6,400 seconds to the circular orbit. Right now, the satellite is fully healthy. We have to do a lot of in-orbit testing for the satellite payload."



ISRO Chairman V. Narayanan inaugurates Yuri Gagarin's statue at Periyar Science and Technology Center, Chennai on Thursday. RAGU R.

'Saved lives on Axiom-4'

Mr. Narayanan recounted ISRO's role in ensuring the success of the Axiom-4 mission this summer, which was piloted by Group Captain Shubhanshu Shukla, the first Indian in space in the last 40 years. Indian scientists had saved the lives of all the astronauts aboard by insisting on scrubbing the initially scheduled launch due to a liquid oxygen leak.

"One day ahead of the scheduled launch on June 11, the countdown had started, and there was a news item about a minor leak. We went ahead with a discussion. I was not satisfied. We insisted on correcting it. Later, we found it was a line crack, not a minor leak," the ISRO chief explained. "We proved to the world that Indians are second to none, the Indian education system is second to none, Indian training is second to none, to ensure the safety of *Gaganyatris* [astronauts], including Shubhanshu Shukla," he added.

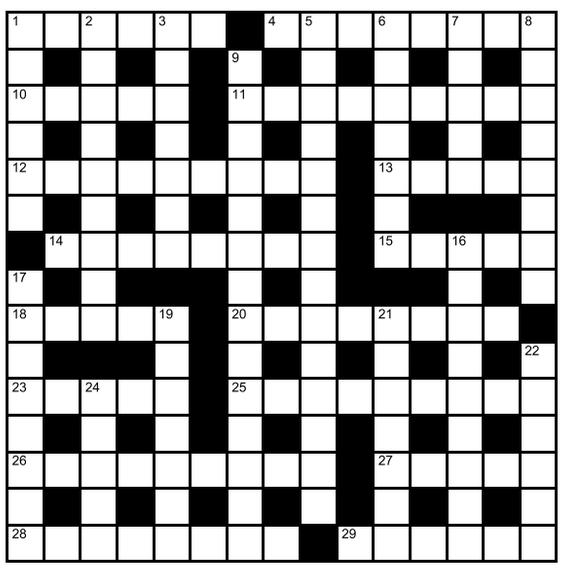
Mr. Narayanan stressed the need to strengthen space technology for better services for citizens. "The work on the fourth launch complex in Kulasekarapattinam in Tamil Nadu is under way," he said.

TH CROSSWORD + 14942

(set by Karaoke)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



Across

1 Tries vigorously at school, writes exam again (6)
4 Enjoy yourself, fix one base, in retreat? (4,2,2)
10 Small drink accepted in theatre (5)
11 Healthy and smart figure secures record (2,3,4)
12 Fair share for an exhibit on display (9)
13 Confidential assistants' words spoken in undertone carry no substance mainly (5)
14 Destructive tide engulfed people with advanced mental illness (8)
15 Greek letter of death, maybe time to say goodbye to dead (5)
18 Like in support for badger (5)
20 Air strike — It produces sound (5,3)
23 Eight kill people belonging to the family for food! (5)
25 Reviewed in theory about climax of sex hormone produced within body (9)
26 Childless woman ran up a hill leaving husband in distress (9)
27 Ultimately yoghurt, cucumber, chilli, masala, pudina mixed in Indian dish (5)
28 It's a mockery to wear a waistcoat to go outside (8)
29 Charm a rring? (6)

Down

1 This vegetable is in hard shape (6)
2 Father after taking drug boards plane with associate to watch series of episodes (4,5)
3 Stamp of artist inscribed in place of worship erasing signature at the end (7)
5 Expecting to lose pool regularly, what if I play foolishly with money? (2,3,6,3)
6 Stylish English cricket side gets tan unfortunately (7)
7 Trustworthy group of three killed associate for espionage primarily (5)
8 Country that takes pains criminally to release extremists on borders (8)
9 Passage from a periodical, one to examine by rule and law (9,5)
16 Coteries used to induce independent and arouse invitingly (9)
17 Hurry up. Break set point (4,2,2)
19 Vague and almost bad budget rejected (7)
21 Some tapir to get around seeking attention (3-4)
22 Release knight from lock up on bail finally in particular (6)
24 As long as possible, perform dance to this music (5)

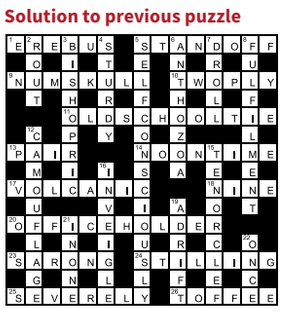
SUDOKU

	6							
7	4	3	1		8			6
1			3		7			4
	8	7				3		
			5		2			
		6				7	1	
8			4		1			7
3			7		6	2	8	9
							3	

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★☆☆

No.SS7053 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

3	2	6	5	9	1	8	4	7
7	9	1	2	8	4	3	5	6
8	5	4	7	6	3	9	1	2
2	3	8	4	1	9	6	7	5
1	6	5	3	7	8	2	9	4
4	7	9	6	2	5	1	3	8
6	8	3	9	5	7	4	2	1
9	1	7	8	4	2	5	6	3
5	4	2	1	3	6	7	8	9

FAITH

Perfect understanding

The Pandavas are in the forest, and Draupadi, addressing Yudhishthira, says a good man cannot bear to see others suffer. But a wicked man takes pleasure in tormenting others. Duryodhana's heart must be as hard as iron, for he did not shed a tear when the Pandavas left for the forest although they were his cousins. Karna, Dushasana and Sakuni also had felt no pity for the Pandavas, while all the other Kaurvavas had shed tears. Draupadi recalls Yudhishthira's days in his palace as the king, said Kidambi Narayanan in a discourse. He would apply sandal paste on his body, and wear the best silk clothes. Draupadi always shared the joys and sorrows of the Pandavas.

In Bhavabhuti's Uttara Rama Charita, Rama tells Sita that for peace of mind, there must be perfect understanding between husband and wife. Their mutual affection must continue into old age. In old age the skin shrinks. But the mind must not. It must be open to ideas and must continue to be capable of analysing things. Anyone who has all these will have a happy life. Rama tells his sons Lava and Kusa that two people bond not because of external reasons. The blooming of a lotus when the Sun rises is not preplanned by either the lotus or the Sun. It just happens. Such is the love that binds a husband and wife too. Something undefinable draws two people together. Draupadi was just the sort of wife anyone could have wished for. She was unable to bear the state the Pandavas had been reduced to. She talks of Yudhishthira's generosity, even in times of distress. Just before leaving for the forest, he gave away thousands of things that were in his palace. And now the five brothers were in a forest dressed in tree bark.

What a new global study reveals about women and how they experience pain

The study's findings about women having a higher prevalence of pain across anatomical sites, resonate with observations from India, say experts, noting that even so, women's pain has historically been under-recognised, misunderstood, or inadequately treated

Afshan Yasmeen



Understanding suffering: It found that women had 83% higher relative prevalence of facial pain, 74% higher prevalence of headaches and 60% higher prevalence of abdominal pain than men. GETTY IMAGES

Women are more likely than men to report pain across every one of the 11 anatomical sites examined in a global study involving more than 6.1 million people across 118 countries. The study found that differences were particularly pronounced for facial pain, headaches and abdominal pain.

Published in *Nature Medicine*, the study found that women had 83% higher relative prevalence of facial pain, 74% higher prevalence of headaches and 60% higher prevalence of stomach or abdominal pain than men. Women were also more likely to report high-intensity and widespread pain, highlighting a disparity that extends beyond the occurrence of pain to its severity and distribution.

The findings resonate with observations from India, where community-based studies and population surveys have consistently reported a higher prevalence of chronic and musculoskeletal pain among women than men. However, the reasons for the difference are complex and cannot be attributed to biological factors alone, say pain specialists.

'Not fully understood'

Sadasivan S. Iyer, consultant and lead, pain medicine, Manipal Hospital, Old Airport Road, and vice-president of the Karnataka chapter of the Indian Society for the Study of Pain (ISSP), said Indian studies had also found that women were more likely to report pain and pain-related functional limitations. "In my clinical practice as a pain physician, women constitute an important proportion of patients seeking care for chronic pain," he said.

The difference between men and women when it comes to pain, likely involves several factors, including biological influences, hormonal changes, the prevalence of particular pain conditions, and social and occupational demands. However, the relative contribution of these factors in the Indian context remains insufficiently understood, Dr. Iyer said.

The global study analysed individual-level data from 6,125,459 participants drawn from 902 population-based data sources collected between 1990 and 2025. Women were more likely than men to report pain at all 11 sites examined, with relative risks ranging from 1.08 to 1.83.

The sites included the head, face, neck or shoulder, back, chest, abdomen, hip, knee, hand or wrist, elbow, and foot or ankle. Back pain was the most commonly reported, affecting about 40% of the study population, while facial pain was reported by about 2%. The analysis also found that women had a relative risk of 1.52 for high-intensity pain and 1.50 for generalised pain compared with men.

Satish Kumar M.N., associate professor in the department of anaesthesia and pain medicine at the State-run Bangalore Medical College and Research Institute (BMCRI), and treasurer of the Karnataka chapter of ISSP, said women experienced a higher prevalence of several chronic pain conditions, including migraine, fibromyalgia, myofascial pain syndrome, arthritis, chronic pelvic pain and certain neuropathic pain conditions. "Despite this, women's pain has historically been under-recognised, misunderstood, or inadequately treated. In some cases, their symptoms have been attributed primarily to psychological factors without sufficient clinical evaluation or appropriate investigations," he said.

> Despite this, women's pain has historically been under-recognised, misunderstood, or inadequately treated. In some cases, their symptoms have been attributed primarily to psychological factors without sufficient clinical evaluation or appropriate investigations
>
> **SATISH KUMAR M.N.**
> associate professor in the department of anaesthesia and pain medicine, BMCRI

An Indian epidemiological study published in 2018 reported that women accounted for 70.6% of identified chronic pain cases. Dr. Kumar cautioned that this figure represented the proportion of identified chronic pain cases who were women, and not the percentage of all Indian women living with chronic pain.

Hormonal, social factors

Hormonal influences may contribute to differences in pain patterns as well. Oestrogen and progesterone affect physiological processes involved in pain perception, inflammation and nervous system function. Changes in hormone levels around menstruation, for instance, can trigger migraine attacks in susceptible women.

However, the relationship between hormones and pain is complex, with effects varying according to the condition, hormonal concentration, timing and individual characteristics. Hormones alone cannot explain the higher burden of chronic pain among women, Dr. Kumar said.

Social and occupational demands also influence how pain is experienced and managed. Women often balance paid employment with household work, childcare and care giving responsibilities, which may continue even when they experience persistent pain or physical limitations.

In some communities, menstrual discomfort and musculoskeletal pain are treated as conditions women are expected to endure. Such expectations can discourage them from seeking medical advice or prioritising their own health.

Poor nutrition and iron-deficiency anaemia, where present, can add to fatigue and reduce functional capacity, further affecting daily life.

High prevalence

The global study found that pain prevalence generally rose sharply before the age of 55. Musculoskeletal pain, including back, hip and knee pain, increased through adulthood and continued to rise into older age, while headache and abdominal pain tended to peak earlier and decline later in life.

Average pain intensity among those reporting pain peaked at around 48 years, at approximately five on a 10-point scale for women and 4.6 for men.

The researchers also identified substantial differences across countries at different levels of human development. Among people aged 80 and above, the prevalence of any bodily pain was 30.6 percentage points higher in countries with low Human Development Index scores than in countries with high scores.

The takeaways

The study does not establish why women report more pain than men. Its authors noted that self-reported pain offers an important complement to estimates based on clinically diagnosed conditions, particularly in settings where access to healthcare is limited.

Dr. Iyer stressed that the differences should not be interpreted as evidence that women have a lower tolerance for pain or are inherently more sensitive to it. "Pain is a genuine, individual experience," he said, emphasising the need to recognise and assess each patient's symptoms rather than make assumptions based on gender.

The findings underscore the need for greater attention to pain across the lifespan and for further research into the biological, social and healthcare-related factors contributing to the disparity.

(yasmeen.afshan@thehindu.co.in)



Safety measures: To avoid injuries, doctors say it is important to maintain an appropriate distance from the crackers — a minimum of three feet distance for explosive crackers and one to two feet distance for others. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Ahead of Deepavali, doctors sound caution about eye injuries

Serena Josephine M.

The sound of firecrackers filling the air is not far away as Deepavali draws closer. But the excitement of bursting firecrackers comes with a word of caution from ophthalmologists as they warn that a moment of carelessness can cause eye injuries ranging from minor abrasions to severe ocular trauma.

How injuries occur

M. Elangovan, director, Regional Institute of Ophthalmology and Government Ophthalmic Hospital (RIO-GOH), Chennai, said that there are different types of crackers. "Bursting types (explosive crackers) will produce irregular, small and forcible particles in all directions and are the most dangerous. These particles can travel at such a velocity that they could hit or penetrate any soft surface. Then, there is direct heat injury caused by crackers such as sparklers that can cause scar formations in the cornea or conjunctiva due to the heat generated. Sudden and close exposure to bright light-emitting crackers can also cause bleaching or temporary blackout due to the impact on the rod and cone cells in the retina," he explained. While these are the direct eye injuries that firecrackers can cause, there are chemical injuries as well, he added.

G. Suguneswari, senior vitreo retina consultant, Sankara Nethralaya, Chennai, said, "Cracker-related eye injuries can include chemical burns, thermal injuries and injuries caused by foreign bodies, with the damage ranging from superficial injuries to deeper involvement of most vital structures of the eye. Any structure of the eye starting from the eyelids to the conjunctiva, cornea, lens, retina and optic nerve is prone to injuries with firecrackers. There could be open wounds that need immediate attention. These injuries have a prolonged course of recovery and can be potentially blinding too."

The most important thing is that children must burst firecrackers only under parental guidance, she said. "Young persons who wear contact lenses should remove them prior to bursting both explosive and non-explosive crackers and wear their spectacles. Fumes from these crackers can cause irritation to the eyes. It is important to maintain a safe distance," she added.

First aid

If a person comes in contact with irritant fumes, clean and lukewarm water should be immediately used to wash the eyes for 15 minutes, she said, adding: "If a particle has entered the eye, it could cause abrasion to the structure. In such circumstances, do not wash the eyes but use a clean paper cup to cover the injured eye using tape or plaster and approach an eye hospital immediately. Do not resort to any kind of home remedy."

To avoid injuries, Dr. Elangovan said it is important to maintain an appropriate distance from the crackers – a minimum of three feet distance for explosive crackers and one to two feet distance for others.

According to Mohan Rajan, chairman and medical director, Rajan Eye Care Hospital, there has been an increased incidence of cracker injuries of the eye over the past few years, mainly because of the negligence of parents and failure to follow protocols while bursting crackers.

Dr. Suguneswari said that patients who have undergone any intraocular procedures/surgeries should refrain from going outside as they are vulnerable to injuries. Similarly, those with pre-existing dry eyes should also take precautions.

(serena.m@thehindu.co.in)

THE HEALTH QUIZ

Please send in your answers to health@thehindu.co.in

November has a significant day: the world observes Prematurity Day on November 15. How much do you know about the prematurity

Zubeda Hamid

QUESTION 1
A birth is classified as preterm when it takes place before which week of pregnancy? a) 40th b) 36th c)37th d) 42nd

QUESTION 2
Premature babies are often born with fine, downy hair covering their body because they may arrive before the natural shedding window of this hair in the womb. What is this soft hair called?

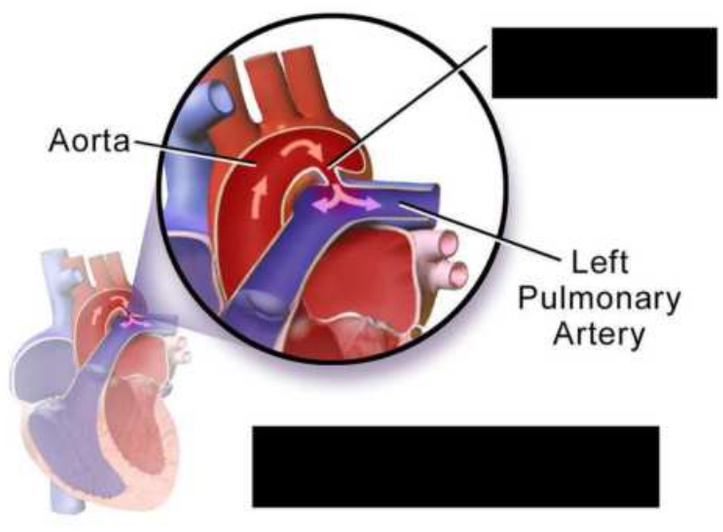
QUESTION 3
The last major organ to fully develop in a foetus is the _____

QUESTION 4
Many preterm babies are born with newborn jaundice, a condition in which there are high levels of bilirubin in the blood. What is the medical term for this condition

QUESTION 5
True or False: Smoking can increase the risk of a preterm pregnancy

QUESTION 6
Premature babies can lose body heat quickly. This is because they do not have enough stored _____ compared to infants born at full term.

QUESTION 7
The recommended time to wait between pregnancies to avoid the risk of a preterm delivery is how many months?



Visual question: A common health condition that can affect premature babies has to do with the heart, where there is an opening between the aorta and the pulmonary artery. What is this condition called?

Answers to previous edition's quiz:
1. How often should a healthy adult get an eye check-up? **Ans:** At least every 2 years 2. What is the new technique, which in certain cases, obviates the need for corneal transplantation? **Ans:** Pinhole Pupilloplasty 3. What is the earlier, milder stage of diabetic retinopathy where tiny blood vessels weaken, swell and leak fluid into the retina? **Ans:** Nonproliferative Diabetic Retinopathy 4. Will the cornea of people who used to wear spectacles or contact lenses be viable for transplant? **Ans:** Yes 5. What does the "20-20-20 rule"? **Ans:** Every 20 minutes, look at something 20 feet away for 20 seconds 6. How soon after death should the cornea be removed for transplantation? **Ans:** 4-6 hours Visual: What is the scientific name for squint eye? **Ans:** Strabismus
Winners: Pulkit Aggarwal | Suraj Basnett | Viswanathan Neelakantan | Tamal Biswas

Trump debacle

Democrats must use their win to influence policy and improve lives

President Donald Trump faced the worst political setback of his current term in office after the Republican Party lost control of both the Senate and the House of Representatives in the mid-term election. Democrats not only won resoundingly in their traditional stronghold States, such as Colorado, Oregon and Illinois, and held onto important swing States, such as Georgia, Michigan and Virginia, but they also made historic inroads into "red states" such as Texas, Kansas and Iowa. While Mr. Trump fumed that Republicans would have performed better had his name been on the ballot, he also appeared to be resigned to the imminent reality of working with Democratic lawmakers over the remaining two years of his administration. Beyond the immediate impact on the future functioning of the federal government, this week's "bluenami" has also brought sweeping changes at the State level: Democrats won a Senate seat in Texas for the first time in 37 years; Democrat Abdul El-Sayed won in Michigan, making him the first Muslim Senator in history; Chris Pappas of New Hampshire became the first openly gay man to be elected to the Senate; and Senate Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries will soon be the first African-American Speaker of the House.

It is ironic that Mr. Trump alluded to his name not being on the ballot as the cause for the Republican collapse because, for many voters, the mid-term election was indeed a referendum on the second Trump administration's performance in office. The result has been an unambiguous thumbs-down from voters so far as top policy areas of the Trump administration are concerned, including cost of living and jobs, immigration enforcement, the war in Iran. The writing was on the wall, as were the approval ratings, especially in the case of oil prices and the Iran war, given that the price of gas in the U.S. has soared since the conflict around the Strait of Hormuz escalated. Similarly, the widespread raids by ICE and accelerated deportation processes for undocumented migrants led to protests across States and galvanised progressives around immigration reform. While Democrats may be justified in celebrating their victory after two years of harsh Trumpism, they would do well to remember that the President still retains a veto vote for policies passed by Congress. The temptation to launch a series of investigations and interrogate the functioning of the Trump White House may be strong, yet congressional Democrats may wish to avoid any posturing that yields no palpable policy impact, including kicking off impeachment proceedings against Mr. Trump. A more productive way forward for Democratic lawmakers would be to engage with the White House and, through negotiation and compromise, mitigate the real impact of deleterious policies in critical areas such as health-care insurance and tariffs.

Danger in the sewer

India must eliminate situations that lead to sewer cleaning deaths

Despite legislation, Supreme Court orders, government programmes, the availability of mechanised cleaning technologies, and exhortations from politicians, India continues to lose sanitation workers to foreseeable, and largely preventable, circumstances. In a recent incident, four workers lost their lives in Ujjain, Madhya Pradesh, cleaning a hotel's food-waste chamber. According to Parliament and the National Commission for Safai Karamcharis data, the number of workers who died on jobs involving sewer and septic tanks was 859 between 2014 and 2025, 498 from 2019 to mid-2026, 332 across 18 States and Union Territories in 2021-26, and 1,350 between 1993 and 2025. The figures have never tended towards zero even as the Safai Karamchari Andolan has repeatedly alleged severe under-reporting. Further, the government has maintained since at least 2021 that the practice of manually cleaning excreta from insanitary latrines has been eliminated, effectively signalling that it believes it has addressed the root of the problem when it has not, and freeing administrative bodies of the urgency of inspecting municipalities and private establishments. Members of historically marginalised castes are also overrepresented in these jobs. The law has distinguished hazardous cleaning of sewers and septic tanks from manual scavenging since 2013. Even so, persons entering them are still vulnerable to noxious gases. In *Dr. Balram Singh* (2023), the Court strengthened the requirements under *Safai Karamchari Andolan* (2014) to, among other measures, ensure outsourced sewer-cleaning contracts did not entail workers entering sewers and raise the compensation for deaths to ₹30 lakh per worker. In 2025, there was an order to end manual sewer cleaning in four metropolitan cities, Bengaluru, and Hyderabad followed a year later with notices to 15 Chief Secretaries for disobeying the 2023 order, including on the compensation.

Private contractors and municipal bodies are known to violate the restrictions on manual cleaning specified in the Prohibition of Employment as Manual Scavengers and their Rehabilitation Act 2013 and Rules, and evade liability by hiring undocumented daily-wage workers. The scourge of such worker deaths thus cannot be eliminated without also formalising their employment and improving social security across caste lines. A significant gap between aims and outcomes has also persisted under the National Action for Mechanised Sanitation Ecosystem scheme. And while it is centred on urban local bodies, its difficulties speak to the state's fundamental error: to maximise administrative assistance, such as by distributing kits, rather than minimising the number of situations that could lead to worker deaths.

A middle power moment in a fragmenting world



Shashi Tharoor

A fourth-term member of Parliament (Lok Sabha) from Thiruvananthapuram (Congress party), is chairman of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs, and the author of 'Pax Indica: India and the World of the Twenty-first Century', which has just been reissued with a new Introduction

When, early in October, this writer found himself in Berlin, addressing the question of whether this is a "Middle Power moment", just a day after External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar had made a speech in Delhi on the same topic, it led to a realisation why this theme has gained renewed salience this year. It began with Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney calling, in Davos in January, for the middle powers to collectively address the challenges facing the international system, and persisted with the global recognition that the world is no longer defined solely by the gravitational pull of superpowers, nor by the binary alignments of the Cold War, but by a wider constellation of states. These states neither command the international system nor submit passively to it. Instead, their influence derives from strategic positioning, economic weight, diplomatic agility, and normative ambition.

The middle power profile

Middle powers are not easy to define. They are typically characterised by a combination of attributes: significant regional presence and influence, desire for greater relevance, growing economic capabilities, credible diplomatic networks, and the political will to act beyond their immediate neighbourhoods. They are not "great" powers in the traditional sense, but they possess enough weight to matter in global governance, and enough autonomy to pursue independent strategies. Their influence is exercised less through coercion than through coalition-building, agenda-setting, and the ability to act as bridges between different parts of the international system.

There are many middle powers, and they are not a monolith: India, Brazil, Canada, Egypt, South Africa, Japan, Indonesia, Türkiye, Mexico, and Germany, all exemplify this category, though in different registers. Nor are they the only ones: in different circumstances or in specific areas, South Korea, the Netherlands, the United Arab Emirates, Nigeria, even Qatar, might fit the term too. And what about France and the United Kingdom, which sometimes seem to have faded from great powers of the past to middle powers today? Clearly, the definition must remain a loose one. But what binds them all is not uniformity of size or interests but a shared sense that the existing global order neither fully reflects their aspirations nor adequately accommodates their agency. They navigate, negotiate, and increasingly seek to shape a changing world order.

Yet, the institutions created to govern the world have changed far less than the world itself. The United Nations Security Council still looks remarkably like a photograph from 1945, despite the end of empires, the emergence and growth of newly independent nations and profound shifts in economic power. Its legitimacy is weakened both by inadequate representation and by inconsistent adherence to international law. Countries asked to defend a rules-based order are entitled to ask which rules apply to all, and whether the powerful are equally bound by them. Countries excluded from meaningful influence cannot indefinitely accept the existing distribution of authority as sacrosanct. But dismantling institutions would destroy protections they themselves need. The middle powers' task is to make the international order more representative and more credible while preserving its capacity to restrain power and sustain cooperation.

A weakening global order creates opportunities for middle powers to act as stabilisers and sustain international cooperation

The label "Middle Power" therefore captures both capability and intent. It describes countries that are no longer content to be rule-takers but are not yet rule-makers in the classical sense. While middle powers share a desire for a multipolar world, they are increasingly norm-shapers for their own specific camps rather than a unified bloc. They seek a more equitable distribution of voice and influence in global institutions, advocate for reforms in multilateral governance, and often champion issues such as development, climate justice, equitable trade, and technology access that resonate across the Global South. Their diplomacy tends to be pragmatic rather than ideological, multi-vector rather than aligned, and oriented toward preserving strategic autonomy in a world of intensifying great-power rivalry.

Room to act

In today's geopolitical turbulence, with the repositioning of the United States and assertiveness of China and Russia, the possibilities for effective action by middle powers are both expanding and constrained. On the one hand, the erosion of great power consensus, the paralysis of multilateral institutions, and the fragmentation of global supply chains create uncertainty and limit the scope for collective action. On the other, at a moment when the assumptions underpinning post-war international cooperation are being questioned, institutions face growing scepticism, and great-power rivalry turns shared challenges into occasions for competition, space has opened for middle powers to exercise initiative. They view themselves as stakeholders of the global architecture and would surely seek to act, ideally in concert, should there be a further deterioration. They can convene issue-based coalitions, mediate in conflicts where great powers are distrusted, and shape global norms in areas such as digital governance, climate finance, health security, and development cooperation. Their ability to speak simultaneously to the West and the Global South gives them diplomatic leverage that neither superpowers nor smaller states possess.

The last few years have shown that the middle powers are increasingly willing to use this space. India's leadership of the G-20 in 2023, Brazil's stewardship of climate diplomacy, South Africa's activism on global health and vaccine equity, and Germany's efforts to stabilise the European order while engaging the Indo-Pacific, all illustrate the diverse ways in which these states are asserting themselves. They do not always agree with one another, but they share a conviction that the international system must evolve to reflect contemporary realities rather than the power structures of 1945.

The weakening of the post-war international order has created an opening for countries that possess considerable diplomatic, economic or technological influence, but cannot determine the international environment on their own. They have a substantial stake in cooperation and a growing capacity to help shape the world together. Whether that capacity becomes consequential will depend on the partnerships they are prepared to build.

The demand for cooperation

What, then, makes this a "middle power moment"? Certainly more than the desire of several countries to be more important. What is distinctive is the convergence of a weakening institutional order, an unpredictable superpower whose commitment to the international system it itself had created is now in question, the dispersal of economic and technological capabilities, and global rivalries that increasingly prevent the strongest states from leading common endeavours.

The demand for cooperation has grown precisely as the supply of uncontested leadership has diminished. That gap creates an opening for countries with the capacity to act and the ability to bring others with them. This need not exclude the great powers: in fact, the Quad, BRICS, the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC) initiative, the Belt and Road Initiative, and the International North-South Transport Corridor, all include co-operation between middle powers and established great ones. Of course this varies: India's preference for multi-alignment, pursuing advantageous relationships with multiple partners, clearly reflects the turbulence of the past year or two in its international relations. While Brazil or Indonesia might view China primarily as an economic engine, India's pessimism about Beijing is rooted in tensions over their undefined border that makes relations with the U.S. and Russia a pragmatic necessity. And now the midterm election results in the U.S. have introduced new uncertainties over Washington's posture in world affairs.

Of course, middle powers are more vulnerable than superpowers to economic shocks, which can limit their influence. Their role will not be to replace great powers but to moderate, mediate and innovate – to act as stabilisers in a world where stability is increasingly scarce.

The ecological fallout of Israel's war in Gaza



Abdullah Nasir

Associate Professor at the Centre for International Legal Studies, Jawaharlal Nehru University

On November 5, 2001, the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) designated November 6 each year as the International Day for Preventing the Exploitation of the Environment in War and Armed Conflict. This recognition underscores the far-reaching impacts of environmental damage caused by armed conflict, including degradation of ecosystems and resource depletion well after the conflict period. This impact often extends beyond the limits of national territories and affects future generations.

Considering the importance of the issue, the International Law Commission (ILC), in its report titled 'Protection of the Environment in Relation to Armed Conflicts' (PERAC), adopted 27 draft principles in 2022, which were formally noted by the UNGA on December 7, 2022. The overarching purpose of these principles is to enhance the protection of the environment in relation to armed conflicts. The first principle of the PERAC provides that the principles apply to the protection of the environment before, during and after an armed conflict, including in situations of occupation. In this context, Israel's responsibility for internationally wrongful acts causing environmental harm arises not only from its ongoing genocide in Gaza but also from its continuing role as an occupying power.

The devastation in Gaza

In its report released on September 23, 2025, titled the 'Environmental Impact of the Conflict in the Gaza Strip', the United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP) documented that two years of escalating hostilities have resulted in unprecedented environmental devastation in Gaza, severely affecting its soils, freshwater resources, and coastline. It says that since 2023, Gaza has lost 97% of its tree crops, 95% of its shrubland, and 82% of its annual crops, leaving its population on the brink of famine.

Freshwater resources are critically scarce, and much of the remaining supply is contaminated.

The destruction of Gaza's ecosystems underscores the need for accountability under international law

The destruction of sewage treatment facilities, piped water systems, and the increasing reliance on cesspits have likely worsened pollution of the aquifer that provides most of Gaza's water. The UNEP further notes that marine and coastal environments are also likely contaminated.

Approximately 78% of Gaza's estimated 2,50,000 buildings have been damaged or destroyed, resulting in around 61 million tonnes of debris. The loss of vegetation cover and soil compaction from military activity have further degraded soil quality, reducing its capacity to absorb water, heightening flood risks, and limiting groundwater recharge. The UNEP report does not capture the full extent of the environmental devastation in Gaza, as the situation continues to deteriorate and statistics are rapidly rendered obsolete amid Israel's ongoing genocidal assault.

Violations of environmental obligations

As an occupying power, Israel is obligated under the PERAC principles to administer and use the natural resources in an Occupied Palestinian Territory (OTP), for the benefit of the protected population of the occupied territory, while ensuring respect for and protection of the environment. It must integrate environmental considerations into the administration of the OTP.

Nevertheless, Israel has engaged in the systematic extraction of natural resources from the OPT and transferred them to itself, resulting in significant environmental degradation; this has been acknowledged by the International Court of Justice in its advisory opinion of July 19, 2024, 'Legal Consequences Arising from the Policies And Practices of Israel in the Occupied Palestinian Territory, Including East Jerusalem'.

Such practices not only contravene environmental protection obligations but also infringe upon the Palestinian people's collective rights, including their permanent sovereignty over natural resources and their right to self-determination. International law affirms that all peoples, including those under occupation, have permanent sovereignty over natural resources, imposing strict limitations on the actions of occupying powers regarding these natural resources. Yet, Israel's prolonged occupation – characterised by territorial expansion, settlement construction, and systematic resource appropriation – has consistently undermined these foundational principles of international law.

Principle 9 of the PERAC stipulates that a state that commits an internationally wrongful act in relation to an armed conflict, resulting in environmental damage, bears international responsibility and is obligated to provide full reparation for such damage, including damage to the environment itself. Accordingly, Israel bears an obligation under international law to provide full reparation for the environmental destruction it has caused in Gaza – an obligation reaffirmed by the International Court of Justice in its advisory opinion of July 19, 2024, 'Legal Consequences Arising from the Policies And Practices of Israel in the Occupied Palestinian Territory, Including East Jerusalem'.

The overall picture of occupation

On this International Day for Preventing the Exploitation of the Environment in War and Armed Conflict, it is critical to acknowledge that the devastation inflicted on Palestine, beginning with the formation of the state of Israel and its ongoing settler-colonial project, constitutes a serious breach of international law. This has become more pronounced since October 7, 2023 when Hamas-led attacks on Israel were followed by Israel's genocidal attack on Gaza.

As Swedish climate activist Andreas Malm aptly observes, the destruction of Palestine is the destruction of the earth. The international community must recognise that climate justice is impossible without dismantling Israel's settler-colonial structure and ensuring the liberation of Palestine.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Peace, not conflict

The electoral outcomes in Israel and now the United States carry a message that political leaders cannot afford to ignore. The setbacks faced by Benjamin Netanyahu's political camp and Donald Trump's Republicans should prompt reflection on a fundamental public sentiment: people want security, economic stability and peaceful lives. While foreign policy is rarely the sole determinant of an electoral verdict, the human and economic costs of conflict inevitably influence public opinion. Democracy offers a timely reminder that peace and prosperity matter more than political posturing.

Gopalaswamy J.,
Chennai

Service extension

The Union Cabinet's decision to offer an additional two-year engagement to the 75% of Agniveers not selected for regular service after four years, with enhanced benefits, is a welcome course correction. Together with a further opportunity for regular enrolment after six years, subject to willingness and selection criteria, it addresses some of the career insecurity that fuelled resentment among aspirants since the scheme's launch in 2022. The government's assessment reported positive feedback and the extension builds on these strengths. Its success, however, will depend on how transparent and consistent the criteria for regular enrolment prove to be.

P.A. Chary,
Visakhapatnam

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Are lower MRPs on cancer drugs translating into affordable care?



Indu Bhushan

Bureaucrat, Economist and the first CEO of Ayushman Bharat



K.M. Gopakumar

Legal Adviser, Senior Researcher and Public Health Expert

PARLEY

In a move to make cancer treatment more affordable, the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) has capped trade margins at 30% for 137 non-scheduled anti-cancer drugs, reducing the price of nearly 900 cancer medicine brands by up to 70%-93%. However, for comprehensive cancer care in India, price regulation might not be enough. Are lower MRPs on cancer drugs translating into affordable care? Indu Bhushan and K.M. Gopakumar discuss the question in a conversation moderated by **Bindu Shajan Perappadan**.

After the NPPA's move, the price of one of the drugs has fallen from ₹40,000 to ₹2,720. Does this mean that Indians have been paying inflated prices for these medicines?

Indu Bhushan: The answer is yes, but that would be a simplistic way of looking at the problem. There is certainly considerable scope to rationalise medicine prices. However, we must also understand who benefits from the difference between the supply price and the price paid by the patient. There must be adequate incentives for pharmaceutical companies to invest in Research and Development (R&D), particularly in India, where investment in this area remains low. At the same time, a disproportionate share of the value cannot be captured by traders, intermediaries and, in some cases, hospitals. The savings should either support R&D or reach patients.

K.M. Gopakumar: The price reductions announced by the NPPA are impressive, but the numbers need to be examined carefully. Of the 1,024 brands in the list we analysed, nearly 45.4% recorded price reductions of more than 50%. Around 19.6% saw reductions exceeding 70%, while 0.8% registered cuts of more than 90%. However, these percentages can be misleading. The absolute value of the reduction matters. Only 16.5% of the brands recorded reductions of more than ₹10,000. The frequently cited example of Palbociclib, the price of which fell from approximately ₹40,000 to ₹2,720, relates to just one brand. There were already 767 other brands available in the market in the price range of ₹2,800 to ₹9,000. Similarly, in the case of Enzalutamide, one company's price fell from ₹3.14 lakh to ₹1.17 lakh, although several other companies were already supplying the medicine at substantially lower prices.

This points to the exploitation of patients over the years. Hospitals have considerable bargaining power because of bulk purchases. However, instead of negotiating lower procurement prices, they benefit from medicines being sold at high MRPs, allowing them to capture substantial margins. India regulates sectors such as telecommunications and electricity, but there is no comparable mechanism to regulate healthcare charges.



GETTY IMAGES

Several patented cancer drugs and immunotherapies still remain prohibitively expensive. Is India addressing the real problem of affordability or merely correcting excessive margins?

KMG: The limitations become evident when we examine the medicines whose prices have not changed. Of 1,024 brands, nearly 194 brands recorded no price reduction. Their prices range from over ₹1 lakh to as much as ₹10 lakh. Ribociclib, a breast cancer medicine, is an example. It was subject to trade margin rationalisation in 2019, yet its MRP has not changed under the present exercise. Pembrolizumab, an important medicine used in cancer treatment and designated an essential medicine by the World Health Organization, is another example where the intervention has not delivered a price reduction. The exercise therefore exposes the limitations of trade margin rationalisation. It has not ensured affordable access to newer treatments.

There is also a danger that uniform trade margins could discourage hospitals from stocking cheaper generic brands. A 30% margin on a medicine priced at ₹8,000 gives a hospital a greater return than a 30% margin on one priced at ₹2,000. This could undermine the generic medicine business model, where affordability and higher volumes are central to competition.

IB: We should avoid a blanket approach towards patented medicines. Developing new medicines requires substantial resources, and pharmaceutical companies must have an opportunity to recover their investments for future R&D. But patients must also be protected from overcharging. Regulators, including the Union Health Ministry and State health departments, must ensure that patients receive the most appropriate and affordable treatment without compromising on quality. Before prescribing a branded medicine, the first question should be whether an effective and quality-assured generic alternative is available.

> Developing new medicines requires substantial resources, and pharmaceutical companies must have an opportunity to recover their investments for future R&D. But patients must also be protected from overcharging
>
> **INDU BHUSHAN**

What independent mechanism should be put in place to verify prices across stockists, manufacturers, hospitals and pharmacies?

IB: The government has a legitimate role in addressing this because healthcare is a market with several failures, particularly the asymmetry of information between providers and patients. A cancer patient often has very little choice. The treatment is largely determined by doctors and healthcare providers, and patients are not necessarily in a position to question the medicines prescribed or their prices. The government must act as an honest broker and obtain reliable information from the industry.

KMG: Every actor in the healthcare supply chain must be accountable, from pharmaceutical manufacturers to stockists, retailers and hospitals. The NPPA has powers under the Essential Commodities Act and can use notifications to require companies to disclose prices and regulate margins across the supply chain. We do not necessarily need a new law to initiate these measures. The government must also develop its own independent pharmaceutical pricing database rather than depending on private agencies for information.

Cancer treatment also involves diagnostics, surgery, travel and follow-up care. Are existing health insurance schemes adequate?

IB: The cost of treatment varies depending on the type and stage of cancer, the treatment protocol, the location and whether the patient goes to a public or private hospital. One study estimates the median expenditure on cancer treatment at approximately ₹4.1 lakh. Of this, around ₹3.3 lakh, or nearly 80%, is paid out of pocket by patients.

Schemes such as Ayushman Bharat and State government health insurance programmes are therefore important. The ₹5 lakh coverage under Ayushman Bharat is a significant starting point, although it may not be sufficient for every cancer patient. Some States have extended financial support through Chief Minister's relief funds and other assistance mechanisms. We must strengthen public-sector cancer treatment capacity. Most advanced cancer services are currently concentrated in the private sector.

KMG: A Parliamentary Standing Committee on Health report in 2022 noted that nearly 40% of cancer patients borrow money or pledge assets to finance treatment. The tools to extend lives are available, but they remain unaffordable for many. In high-income countries, around 90% of women diagnosed with breast cancer survive for at least five years. In India, the corresponding figure is approximately 65.5%. Insurance coverage also remains fragmented. Existing schemes frequently cover only parts of the treatment rather than guaranteeing comprehensive care.

What should India's next policy intervention be to address the cancer burden?

IB: India needs a dedicated national mission for cancer prevention, treatment and care. A cancer mission should strengthen public healthcare facilities, establish standard treatment protocols for different cancers and create systems for second opinions. Drug price regulation must also be expanded intelligently. Strategic pooled procurement by government institutions and health schemes could help negotiate lower prices. Different government agencies currently procure medicines separately.

KMG: The government should introduce cost-based caps on cancer treatment, linked to standard treatment protocols. India has the manufacturing capacity to produce generic medicines at competitive prices. Public procurement can further reduce costs. There must also be greater transparency about the actual cost of pharmaceutical R&D and the revenues companies earn from their products. The ultimate objective must be to ensure that a cancer diagnosis does not push an Indian family into poverty. Reducing the price of medicines is only one part of that responsibility.

To listen to the full interview
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www.thehindu.com

NOTEBOOK

How AI is perfecting the art of government obfuscation

Press releases are becoming more and more vague

Sobhana K. Nair

Jonathan Lynn and Antony Jay created the memorable fictional politician, The Right Hon. James Hacker. The two-part *Yes Minister* and *Yes Prime Minister* diaries of Hacker dealing with bureaucrats never gets old. I recently turned to them after frustrated encounters with government press notes packed with buzzwords that spoke a lot but said very little.

In the editor's note to the first volume, Hacker's political training is blamed for him using "twenty words where one would do, to dictate millions of words where mere thousands would suffice, and to use language to blur and fudge issues and events so that they became incomprehensible to others." These lines are a fitting description of government press notes that use various tools of evasion, serving to deliver two contradictory objectives: publicising the government's achievements while concealing any information on shortcomings. This is an age-old trick that many governments have deployed. But today a new era of obfuscation is upon us, thanks to AI.

A random "perusal" (another lovely piece of bureaucratese) of press notes over the last few months has thrown up a few trends. Channelling the bureaucratese, let me categorise them into two broad subheads: "generic misdirection" and, borrowing from the Harry Potter book of spells, the "concealment charm."

Generic misdirection mainly involves lofty "vision language". Nearly every other press note speaks of the unknown golden future under 'Viksit Bharat 2047'. Phrases such as "digitally empowered society" and "knowledge economy" are liberally thrown around, along with the typical governance-speak: "holistic", "convergence", "capacity building", "citizen-centric", "grassroots" and so on. All this is harmless so far.

The heavy lifting is done by phrases under the "concealment charm". The modus operandi here is simple: provide no baseline, make no comparisons with the past, and use unquantified qualifiers, non-specific timelines and give no context at all. For instance, a recent press note on the Narcotics Control Bureau's 'Operation Trident' used phrases such as "intelligence fusion", "surgical precision", "360-degree probe" and so on, steering clear of specifics. No narcotics seizure figures were given, with its shift from "seizure-centric to network-centric" conveniently pre-empting the question. Similarly, take the example of a press release issued after the Cabinet approved the continuation of the National Social Assistance Programme and enhanced disability pension. The release said the pension for those aged 0-79 years would be ₹375 and for those aged 80 years and above ₹625, never bothering to state the old rates. All hikes are good hikes if we do not know the quantum of the hike.

Vague promises have always been part of this form of communication wherein specific deadlines and measurable outputs are removed. Another press note on the Cabinet approving the Container Manufacturing Promotion Scheme spoke of increasing annual domestic container manufacturing capacity tenfold to 7.5 lakh TEUs (Twenty-foot Equivalent Units). There was no mention of a deadline to achieve this goal. It also spoke of generating "an estimated 3,000 direct jobs" and "over 50,000 indirect jobs". Again, the deadline was missing.

But what got me writing this was a press release announcing Cabinet approval for the Pradhan Mantri Viksit Gram Swaraj Yojana. Even if one is to ignore phrases such as "a next-generation governance transformation initiative", the press note's silence on a predecessor scheme, the Rashtriya Gram Swaraj Abhiyan, was noteworthy. Listed under the subhead of beneficiaries were 32 lakh elected representatives. These representatives are going to be trained to assist the government in planning, for which they will receive no remuneration. So how are they beneficiaries?

In this season of festivals, this is like distributing empty *mithai* boxes. Lovely packaging, but bereft of sweetness.

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PICTURE OF THE WEEK

In a puff of smoke



Up in flames: People sit amid debris after an overnight fire gutted more than a dozen shanties on the outskirts of Srinagar, J&K on November 4, 2026. IMRAN NISSAR

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO NOVEMBER 6, 1976

Good scope for Indo-British ventures

Bombay, November 5: Britain and India could collaborate in many industrial fields particularly off-shore oil drilling and electronics, Sir Ralph Bateman, leader of the British industrial co-operation mission, told pressmen here on Wednesday.

Britain's expert management and sound technology would match well with Indian administrative and technical skill. The two countries could help each other by matching their high level attainments in various fields of industrial activity in the interests of both the countries. Sir Ralph said just because British's financial conditions were not rosy, one should not jump to the conclusion that it would not be in a position to help others. All the developed countries tried to co-operate with each other in the advancement of industrial progress. Sir Ralph said in reply to a question that troubles in U.K. were mainly political and not industrial. He wanted the public expenditure in his country to be cut. They were spending too much on many heads and this should be stopped. Asked whether he was satisfied with the Indian Government's policy on repatriation of dividends etc. he said they had no complaints to make.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO NOVEMBER 6, 1926

Buddhism in Kerala

Cochin, November 3: Mr. K.S. Nilakantan Unni, Mahopadhyaya brings to the notice of the public through the columns of the "Malayala Manorama" that there is an interesting image of Buddha in Pallikkal in the Mavelikkara Taluk in central Travancore. It is a stone image exactly similar in appearance to that of the well-known *Karumandi Kuttan* with which people who have travelled along the backwater route between Alleppey and Quilon, are very familiar. The image is worshipped by the villagers who believe that it is a deity presiding over their destinies.

Text&Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

New Delhi's average Air Quality Index on Thursday

369 The 24-hour average Air Quality Index (AQI) stood at 369 at 4 p.m. on Thursday, according to the Central Pollution Control Board. Forecasts indicate that the contribution of stubble burning to the city's pollution is expected to decline sharply on November 7. PTI

Students to be engaged in Nagaland's education initiative

1,000 Nagaland has set a target to engage 1,000 students under the 'One Million Voices' initiative, part of a nationwide education movement aimed at collecting the aspirations of one million young people aged 12 to 25 on education reforms. PTI

Funding for India's newly launched energy storage plan

1.5 in $ billion. India launched a $1.5-billion scheme to develop 92 gigawatt-hours of energy storage capacity as it seeks to accelerate its shift towards renewable energy, the government said on Wednesday. India is the third-biggest emitter of greenhouse gases. AFP

West Bengal offers investment assistance for industrial growth

120 in per cent. Chief Minister unveiled West Bengal Investment Promotion Policy, putting employment generation at the centre of industrial incentives, offering assistance up to 120% for investments in plant and machinery and promising fixed timelines for approvals and payments. PTI

Share of survey respondents planning a job change in 2027

68 in per cent. According to foundit's Career Reset Survey 2027, career growth emerged as the biggest motivation for switching jobs, cited by 40.3% of respondents, followed by higher salary (29.7%) and better work-life balance (20.3%). PTI

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A new political balance in Washington

The Democrats' midterm victory gives them an opportunity to check Trump's unilateral policies through congressional oversight and legislative powers; a weakened Trump Administration could also give India greater leverage in bilateral trade negotiations

WORLD INSIGHT

Biswajit Dhar

On November 4, the Democrats won the most decisive victory in the midterm elections since 1976, with *The New York Times* projections showing that the Democrats could win the national popular vote for the House of Representatives by almost 13%. This spectacular shift in the mood of the American electorate within two years could have consequential implications in Washington, as President Donald Trump faces the grim reality of spending the rest of his term as a lame-duck President. A day before the polls opened, Mr. Trump released his own report card, claiming that he had kept all 127 campaign promises he had made before he was elected. Not only was he unable to convince the American electorate of his "achievements", the midterm election results are also being interpreted as a repudiation of his policies.



Democratic supporters in Texas react as the party secured major victories in the midterm polls. AFP

Imposition of 'America First'

Mr. Trump received a mandate to govern the U.S. for a second time in 2024 as a faltering Joe Biden Administration struggled to put the world's largest economy back on track after the pandemic-induced crisis. Mr. Trump read this mandate as a vindication of the aggressive unilateral policies he had adopted in his first term, as he adopted the 'America First' trade policy, giving his administration sweeping powers to act against any country perceived to be pursuing unfair trade practices against the U.S. Mr. Trump used his trade policy to impose reciprocal tariffs on 157 countries in July 2025. Several countries faced significantly higher tariffs and Indian exports faced punishing tariffs of 50% for importing Russian oil, even when it was negotiating a bilateral free trade agreement with the U.S.

Higher tariffs caused significant disruptions in the U.S. through elevated levels of inflation and slowing growth due to higher import bills.

A significant ruling by the U.S. Supreme Court that the reciprocal tariff was illegal spared the economy from an impending catastrophe. But within days of this ruling, Mr. Trump launched his damaging war on Iran. The direct consequences of the war were felt in the supplies of oil and gas, and its indirect impact on the downstream industries and supply chains adversely affected the global economy. U.S. households bore the brunt of Mr. Trump's Iran war, with costs increasing to $2,000 per household, absorbing about half the average American household's income gain, according to one estimate. After remaining in denial about the impact his decision to attack Iran would have on his political future, Mr. Trump finally admitted, as the midterm election results were coming in, that the war had contributed to Republican losses in the midterms but insisted he would launch the military campaign again.

The U.S. electorate has given the Democrats massive control over the U.S. Congress, hoping that they can prevent Mr. Trump from further damaging the country's economy and polity. But questions have already arisen about whether they can do so, as he has threatened to use his veto against any decision that the Congress may take. What, then, are the Democrats' options?

Democrats could now exercise their dominant presence in the Congress to control Mr. Trump primarily through the constitutional "power of the purse". The U.S. Constitution states, "No Money shall be drawn from the Treasury, but in Consequence of Appropriations made by Law", and the U.S. Supreme Court clarified that the rule of law directs "that no money can be paid out of the Treasury unless it has been appropriated by an act of Congress".

Further, a "regular Statement and Account of the Receipts and Expenditures of all public Money shall be published from time to time"; in other words, the Congress must mandatorily perform "oversight" functions. The ability of the Democratic Congress to perform its "oversight" functions would hold the key to ensuring that Mr. Trump and his administration are prevented from continuing to cause chaos and disorder, the adverse implications of which have been felt globally.

A major task before the Democrats would be to restrain President Trump's penchant for across-the-board use of tariffs to address his concerns not just regarding the U.S. economy but those in the realm of geopolitics as well. The Congress would have to use its constitutional powers to impose tariffs and regulate trade with foreign nations. Periodically, the Congress has "legislated authorities and procedures to signal to trading partners that trade agreements negotiated by the President will be implemented or voted upon".

Commonly known as the Trade Promotion Authority (TPA), these laws virtually dictate the agreements the President can negotiate and the tariffs he can impose. The last TPA was enacted in 2015 and it expired in 2021. One of the first tasks for the Democratic Congress would, therefore, be to enact a TPA to rein in Mr. Trump.

What the shift means for India

What could be the likely implications of this seismic shift in Washington on India? One would expect that New Delhi would find it easier to engage with a weakened Trump administration, especially in its ongoing engagements to finalise the bilateral free trade agreement. The Indian government has insisted on a balanced agreement, but two unreasonable sets of demands from the U.S. have been constant sources of consternation. One, the Trump Administration has pushed for opening India's markets for major cereals and dairy products, and two, the country's generic pharmaceutical companies have been threatened with higher tariffs unless they invest in the U.S. In other words, India's food and health security are both under the hammer. Indian stakeholders would hope the Government of India would be able to utilise the political change ushered in by the U.S. electorate to ensure a better deal for them.

(Biswajit Dhar is former professor, Jawaharlal Nehru University)

THE GIST

- The Republican losses reflect voter discontent with Trump's tariff policies, the economic fallout of the Iran war and its impact on American households
- Democrats can use their control of Congress to scrutinise government expenditure and seek to restore congressional authority over trade agreements and tariffs
- India hopes the political shift in Washington will help it resist U.S. demands to open its markets to cereals and dairy products and pressure on generic pharmaceutical companies to invest in the U.S.

Removing the odds between safety and freedom

Children's internet access must be protected as a fundamental right, with age-appropriate safeguards and shared responsibility to ensure online safety without imposing blanket restrictions

LETTER & SPIRIT

C.B.P. Srivastava

Access to the Internet is essential for ensuring a bright digital future for children and building an inclusive and informed society. However, striking a balance between freedom and safety is the need of the hour. In this regard, the Supreme Court recently, in *Just Rights for Children Alliance v. S. Harish* (2026), has recognised internet access as a fundamental right, emphasising that, particularly for children, the internet serves as a gateway to knowledge, creativity, and self-expression. In the digital era, access to the Internet is a human right and an essential component of the right to freedom of speech and expression guaranteed under Article 19(1)(a) of the Constitution.

The court has observed that the general perception that safety and freedom are at odds with each other is a false notion. Protecting children does not necessarily mean restricting their freedom. The court's observations reinforce democratic principles. However, it is equally important to create an environment in which people in general, and children in particular, can explore the digital world safely while protecting, respecting, and fulfilling their fundamental rights.

'Authority-liberty coordination'

Reasonable restrictions on the exercise of freedoms are important to strike a balance between individual and social interests. This ensures that a constitutionalist approach is followed, whereby the Constitution sets limits on the exercise of State authority as well as citizens' liberty. When the State oversteps these limits, dictatorial tendencies may emerge; when citizens seek to exercise their rights without restraint, an anarchic mindset may prevail. Therefore, it is pertinent to ensure the "authority-liberty coordination" for the smooth functioning of India's democratic governance.

A tool for learning

Digital technologies have been transforming almost all sectors, pushing the world to a faster growth trajectory and contributing greatly to enhancing capabilities by widening choices. While Amartya Sen propounded that capability enhancement would lead to development, Joseph Stiglitz said that transformation, in addition to capabilities, is key to development. These theoretical justifications establish that Internet access can open the golden gate of knowledge for children, provided adequate regulations are in place to govern the content available online. It also enables children to develop technological skills, express their opinions, and connect with people across geographical boundaries. It should therefore be recognised not as a privilege granted to children, but as a matter of right

Some of the countries like Australia, Brazil, China, Indonesia, Malaysia and UAE have restricted the use of social media by children by setting screen time limits and in Brazil particularly the children require to link their social media accounts to a legal guardian. In India, States like Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka have plans to impose screen-time curbs for children. The idea behind such plans is to ensure that access to the internet is subject to responsibility. On many occasions, obscene material is posted as content that needs to be effectively restricted. In the recent ruling, the court has rightly said that we should not imitate the international approach while putting curbs; the balance should be consciously decided.

Earlier, in *Anuradha Bhasin v. Union of India* (2020), the Supreme Court held that freedom of speech and expression, and the freedom to carry on trade or business, through the internet, are protected under Articles 19(1)(a) and 19(1)(g). In another ruling, in *Pragya Prasun v. Union of India* (2025), the court held that excluding persons with disabilities from digital KYC violated Article 21 and that the right to digital access is an intrinsic component of the right to life. It also cited Cricket Association of Bengal (1995), saying that Article 19(1)(a) includes the right to know and to receive and impart information and ideas.

Balancing freedom and safety

Freedom cannot go unrestricted, as it would make society uncivilised. Hence, safety measures need to be blended with it.

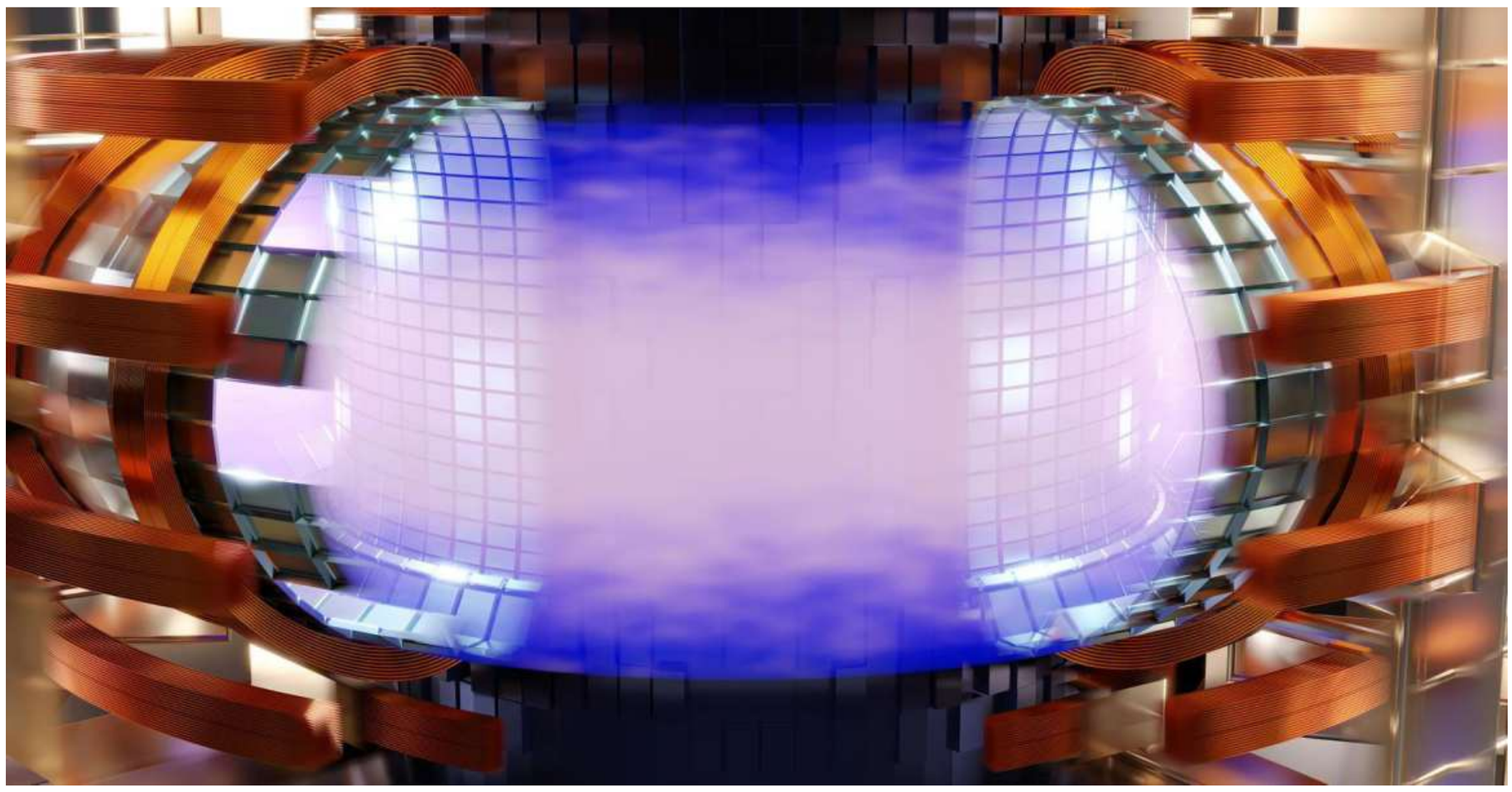
Though Internet access offers numerous benefits to children, it also exposes them to serious risks, which *inter alia* include cyberbullying, online harassment, violations of privacy, and frauds of various kinds. Ignoring such dangers would prove detrimental to the fast-changing domestic and global social and cultural milieu. It might also lead to the widening of civilisational advancements and cultural traits. A convergent approach is therefore needed, bringing together parents, the government, educational institutions and the service providers. Age-appropriate boundaries must be set, and awareness of online risks must be raised so that children can make informed decisions without getting into an unsafe environment.

Blanket curbs will ultimately prevent children from getting information across sectors. Instead of curbing children's rights, it would be better to revisit existing systems.

All stakeholders must take steps to restrict harmful content and act more responsibly. Preventive measures are always preferable to curtailing children's right to Internet access as a corrective measure.

(C.B.P. Srivastava is President, Centre for Applied Research in Governance)

BUILDING BLOCKS



GETTY IMAGES

How do tokamaks work to make nuclear fusion possible?

A tokamak uses magnetic fields to confine superhot plasma to enable nuclear fusion; despite advances in research, engineering challenges remain, and no tokamak has generated net energy for commercial power

Jacob Koshy

A tokamak is a device that uses magnetic fields to trap very hot plasma inside a ring-shaped vacuum chamber. Plasma, a fourth state of matter, is a gas whose atoms have been stripped of their electrons, leaving free electrons and charged nuclei. The word comes from a Russian acronym describing a toroidal (ring-shaped) chamber with magnetic coils. The best-known fusion energy project in the world, the International Thermonuclear Experimental Reactor (ITER), uses this design.

What problem does tokamak solve?
Nuclear energy today comes almost entirely from fission, the controlled chain reaction of uranium atoms, but fusion has always been theoretically possible and a subject of consistent long-term investigation by scientists. When light atomic nuclei such as deuterium and tritium, two isotopes of hydrogen and the best-studied candidates, join, they form helium and a fast neutron. But even this simple merger requires temperatures hotter than the sun's core, which no earthly material can contain. In physics, this is called the problem of containment. Contact with a wall would also cool the plasma and contaminate it with impurities. Plasma, being made of charged particles, can be steered by magnetic fields, and a tokamak uses that property to hold it away from the walls long enough for fusion to occur.

Who first conceived it?
The concept was developed in the Soviet Union in the early 1950s, largely credited to physicists Igor Tamm and Andrei Sakharov.

Experimental work followed at the Kurchatov Institute in Moscow, where the first machines operated in the late 1950s and, once word of its potential spread, it was adopted in research programmes in several universities.

Why is it shaped the way it is?
Charged particles in a magnetic field spiral around the field lines. In a straight tube, they would simply travel along the lines and escape through the ends, but bending the tube into a closed ring removes the ends, making the field lines loop back on themselves.

A ring alone does not work, however. The field from coils around a ring is stronger on the inner side than on the outer, which makes ions and electrons drift in opposite directions, up and down. This creates an electric field that pushes the whole plasma outwards into the wall.

The tokamak gets around this by driving a large electric current through the plasma itself, typically induced by a central magnet acting like a transformer. This current produces a second magnetic field that twists the field lines into a helix around the ring. Particles following a twisted line spend time at both the top and the bottom, which cancels the drift. A tokamak therefore combines two fields: one running around the ring, from external coils, and a twisting one from the plasma current. Additional coils shape and position the plasma.

How does all this create useful energy?
The plasma is kept away from the walls, but the energy it releases is not. In fact, the design depends on that energy reaching them. In a deuterium-tritium reaction, about 80% of the 17.6 MeV (million electron-volts) released goes to the neutron and about 20% to the helium nucleus (alpha particle). A kilogram of this fuel would release about 3.4×10^{14} J if fully fused, roughly 10 million times the energy in the same quantity of coal.

In a power plant design, the inner wall is backed by a thick layer called a blanket. The neutrons slow down in it and deposit their energy as heat, much as in a fission reactor's core. A coolant, such as water or helium, carries the heat out to make steam and spin a turbine, as in a conventional power plant. The blanket also contains lithium. Neutrons striking lithium produce tritium, which is rare and radioactive, so a plant would breed its own fuel this way.

Why haven't tokamaks so far produced the energy?
The principles are well understood, but the engineering challenges are formidable. ITER is funded and run by seven members – China, the European Union, India, Japan, South Korea, Russia and the United States - representing more than 30 countries. It has been plagued by delays over funding, and its projected costs, which were €5 billion in 2005, have increased at least fourfold.

ITER has not been switched on. It is still being assembled at Cadarache in France, so it has had no chance to succeed or fail. It is designed to produce about ten times the heating power fed into its plasma, but only once it begins deuterium-tritium operation. Deadlines are constantly shifting. In 2024, the project moved the start of research operations to 2034 and deuterium-tritium operation to 2039, adding about €5 billion in costs. Officials attributed this to the Covid-19 pandemic, supply-chain and quality problems, and "over-optimistic planning" for a first-of-a-kind machine. Even when it runs, ITER is a physics experiment and will not convert heat into electricity.

What about China?
China's EAST tokamak in Hefei sustained a high-confinement plasma for 1,066 seconds in January 2025, a record for duration, with electron temperatures of about 100 million degrees. In January 2026, it reported running at plasma densities well above a long-standing empirical limit. EAST is a physics machine, though, and has not generated net energy.

How many tokamaks does India have?
The two main machines are at the Institute for Plasma Research (IPR) in Gandhinagar. ADITYA, India's first tokamak, began operating in 1989 and was rebuilt as ADITYA-U, which resumed operations in 2017. SST-1, the Steady State Superconducting Tokamak, produced its first plasma in 2013 and uses superconducting magnets. India is also a member of ITER and manufactures components for it. Bengaluru-based Pranos Fusion has unveiled PRAGYA, which it describes as India's first privately developed compact tokamak. The experimental machine is intended to develop capabilities in plasma control and magnetic confinement, rather than generate commercial electricity.

Are there alternatives?
Fusion research broadly follows two approaches: magnetic confinement, which includes tokamaks, and inertial confinement.

Stellarators also use a ring, but create the twisted field entirely with complex external coils rather than a plasma current. This allows steadier operation and avoids some instabilities, but the coils are harder to design and build. Germany's Wendelstein 7-X is the best-known example.

Inertial confinement, which doesn't use tokamaks at all, compresses a tiny fuel pellet with lasers or other beams so quickly that fusion occurs before the fuel can fly apart. The U.S. National Ignition Facility used this approach in 2022 to claim the production of "net energy." Other magnetic designs include mirror machines, which use open-ended fields, and compact configurations such as field-reversed configurations that have no central hole.

THE DAILY QUIZ

Please send in your answers to dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

A four-way contest, a deeply divided nation and the election of Abraham Lincoln set the United States on a course towards one of the most consequential periods in its history

Prathmesh Kher

QUESTION 1
Which political party nominated Abraham Lincoln for the presidency, and in which city was its national convention held?

QUESTION 2
Who was Abraham Lincoln's running mate in the 1860 presidential election?

QUESTION 3
Which issue was primarily responsible for the split within the Democratic Party ahead of the 1860 election?

QUESTION 4
Who was the presidential candidate of the Southern Democratic faction, which advocated federal protection for slavery in the territories?

QUESTION 5
How many Southern states had seceded from the Union by the time Lincoln assumed office in March 1861?

QUESTION 6
Which presidential election, held in 1864 during the American Civil War, did Abraham Lincoln contest and win for a second term, defeating the Democratic nominee George B. McClellan?



Visual Question:
Identify this gentleman, who became the central figure in a landmark 1857 U.S. Supreme Court case that intensified the national debate over slavery. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1. Since 1845, Americans have been voting on this day of the week in November. Which day of the week is this? **Ans: Tuesday**
2. What is the last session of Congress called before new members are appointed? **Ans: A lame-duck session**
3. Dorothy, from The Wizard of Oz, lives in this landlocked State, which is named after a river. Which State is this? **Ans: Kansas**
4. The first Black Governor has been elected in this State. It is known for its casinos and gambling. **Ans: Nevada**
5. Historically, the party of the sitting president loses ground in midterm elections. More than two decades ago, the Republicans defied this electoral trend. Which President led the party's campaign, and which major incident was a reason for this? **Ans: George W. Bush; 9/11 terror attacks**
Visual: He is an epidemiologist and a Rhodes scholar from the University of Oxford. Name this man, who created history in the 2026 midterm elections. **Ans: Abdul El-Sayed**
Early Birds: K.N. Viswanathan | Tamal Biswas | Dil Bahadur Airee | Tariqa Bali | Sukdev Shet



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the difference between "introvert" and "taciturn"? (Ankan Ghosh, Kolkata)
"Introvert" is a neutral term. When you say that someone is an "introvert" or is "introverted," what you are implying is that the individual doesn't really say much. Perhaps he is a very shy person and as a result finds it difficult to open his mouth in the presence of others. He may be a person who would like to talk to other people, but is afraid to.

Some of the students in my class are extremely introverted.

By the way, the "o" in the second syllable is pronounced like the "a" in "china". The stress is on the first syllable, "in". In the case of "taciturn", the "a" in the first syllable is like the "a" in "cat", "bat", and "act". The "i" in the second syllable sounds like the "i" in "bit", "lit", and "hit," and the final "turn" is pronounced like the word "turn". The stress once again is on the first syllable.

Unlike the word "introvert", "taciturn" is not a neutral term. It has a negative meaning associated with it. When you refer to an individual as being "taciturn," what you are implying is that he is uncommunicative. He doesn't like to talk, and when he does, he speaks very grudgingly. The word suggests that the individual is not very friendly. Here are a few examples.

Priya's responses were taciturn. She answered mostly in monosyllables.

The taciturn man responded coldly.

We will invite you to join us provided you don't bring your taciturn boyfriend.

How is the word "dais" pronounced? (S. Praneeth, Warangal)
The "a" in the first syllable is like the "ay" in "say", "day", and "bay", while the following "i" is like the "i" in "ink", "pink", and "sink". The final "s" sounds like the "s" in "sink", "see", and "sit". The stress is on the first syllable. A dais is a raised platform behind which a speaker stands when he is giving a talk.

When the shooting started, the man took cover behind the dais.

What is the meaning and origin of the expression "let's get down to brass tacks"? (K. Umapati, Mysore)
When you tell someone that you want to get down to brass tacks what you are saying is that you would like to talk about the basic facts of a particular situation. In other words, you would like to talk about the essentials.

Let's get down to brass tacks. Who is going to pay for the broken window?

Several explanations have been provided by scholars as to the origin of this expression. Some say that in Cockney, a dialect that is spoken in London, "brass tacks" is rhyming slang for "facts". So what you are actually saying when you say "let's get down to brass tacks" is "let's get down to the facts". Another explanation is that during the old days, shopkeepers used brass tacks to measure the length of a piece of cloth. I understand that people who used to sell cloth often had two brass tacks nailed on top of the shop counter. The distance between the two tacks used to be precisely one yard. So when a customer wanted to know how long a piece of cloth that he/she was interested in was, the shopkeeper "got down to brass tacks". He used the tacks to determine the length of the cloth.

Published in The Hindu on June 25, 2002

Word of the day

Effrontery:
audacious (even arrogant) behaviour that you have no right to

Synonyms: nerve, audacity, temerity, brazenness

Usage: *He had the effrontery to blame his colleague for his own mistake.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/effrontery

International Phonetic Alphabet: /ɪfrʌntəri/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

OpenAI pledges complete transparency

Amid growing U.S. opposition to data-centre expansion, company commits to bearing electricity and grid infrastructure costs, publishing water and power consumption, and working with unions on local hiring and training; proposes measures to make data-centre developers more accountable

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI

OpenAI has announced a set of commitments for communities hosting its future AI data-centre campuses in the United States, pledging to bear the full cost of electricity and grid infrastructure, disclose environmental impacts and not use non-disclosure agreements (NDAs) with public officials, subject to limited exceptions.

In an announcement on November 5, the company published its National Community Compact, setting out commitments for future computing campuses it owns and operates in the U.S., and a separate Compute Campus Policy Blueprint proposing measures for governments to make data-centre developers more accountable to local communities.

The electricity commitment builds on assurances the company had made for individual projects, including its Stargate initiative.

The latest announcement seeks to establish a common set of commitments for future campuses it owns and operates in the U.S. OpenAI also committed to developing a water plan for each campus, prioritising closed-loop or low-water cooling systems,



Key concern: OpenAI committed to developing a water plan for each campus, prioritising closed-loop cooling systems. REUTERS

and publishing site-level water and electricity consumption. On employment, OpenAI said it would publish expected job creation, work with unions and training providers to prepare local residents for employment opportunities, and report annually on hiring and apprenticeships. It also pledged to make sustained investments in priorities identified by local communities.

Alongside these commitments, OpenAI released a Compute Campus Policy Blueprint proposing measures for federal, state and local governments to make data-centre developers more accountable.

The issue is also becoming relevant in India, which is attracting large investments in AI infrastructure.

Here, OpenAI has partnered with Tata Group and TCS to develop AI infrastructure in India through TCS's HyperVault business, with an initial capacity of 100 MW and the potential to scale to 1 GW.

OpenAI will be the first customer. Meta has agreed to lease capacity at a 168 MW AI-enabled data centre that Reliance Industries is developing in Jamnagar, Gujarat. Google is also developing a gigawatt-scale AI hub in Visakhapatnam in Andhra Pradesh, as part of a planned $15-billion investment in India.

These projects have also begun facing local opposition. According to reports *by The Hindu,* civil society groups in Visakhapatnam are demanding a moratorium on new hyperscale data-centre approvals, citing concerns over environmental and social impact.

Residents have also opposed the proposed AI data centre in the Balkum Pada area of Thane.

Mistry questions Noel Tata's citizenship, tax residency status

Aneesh Phadnis
MUMBAI


Mehli Mistry

Mehli Mistry has questioned Tata Trusts Chairman Noel Tata's Irish citizenship and tax residency status amid an ongoing legal dispute over his removal from three trusts. Mr. Mistry raised these issues in a submission filed before the Charity Commissioner of Maharashtra (CCM) on Thursday, while defending his right to object to change reports filed by Tata Trusts regarding the cessation of his trusteeship.

Tata Trusts had, last month, referred to Mr. Mistry's U.K. citizenship and UAE tax residency status while challenging his locus standi to file objections to change reports submitted by the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust (SDTT) and the Bai Hirabai Jamsetji Tata Navsari Charitable Institution.

Mr. Mistry has now hit back. In a rejoinder to Tata Trusts' response, he said Noel Tata is an Irish citizen and a holder of a UAE Golden Visa, and has sought directions from the CCM requiring Tata to file an affidavit clarifying these facts. "If foreign citizenship and overseas residence are to be treated as relevant considerations, they must be examined in relation to the trustee [Tata] with equal rigour. The Trust cannot demand scrutiny of the objector [Mistry] while claiming exemption from the same scrutiny for its own trustee," said Mr. Mistry.

Questions over religion and residency have emerged as Mr. Mistry and Tata Trusts differ on the eligibility criteria for trusteeship of the Bai Hirabai Trust. While Mr. Mistry has emphasised the trust deed, which restricts trusteeship to Parsi Zoroastrians, Tata Trusts has argued that these conditions conflict with the original will and codicil governing the trust and should therefore not be relied upon. Tata Trusts did not immediately respond to Mr. Mistry's latest filing. The matter is now scheduled to be heard by the CCM on December 3.

Mr. Mistry stepped down as a trustee after board members voted against his reappointment to three trusts, including the Sir Ratan Tata Trust. Subsequently, Tata Trusts filed change reports informing the CCM of the end of Mr. Mistry's tenure. In June, Mistry filed objections to the reports, alleging issues of misgovernance within the trusts.

(The writer is with The Hindu businessline)

LIC Q2 profit rises 20% to ₹12,115 crore

Gowri Lakshmi
MUMBAI

Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) reported a 20% year-on-year (YoY) rise in net profit to ₹12,115 crore for the quarter ended September (Q2FY27), driven by strong premium growth and improved business margins.

Net premium income rose 16.2% to ₹1.47 lakh crore. Single premium income led the growth, increasing 34.5% to ₹68,425 crore. Annualised premium equivalent (APE) grew 5.72% to ₹30,696 crore, while expenses declined 1.13% to ₹15,061.5 crore.

The insurer's value of new business (VNB) jumped 33.95% to ₹6,846 crore. Consequently, the VNB margin expanded 470 basis points to 22.3%. Assets under management (AUM) increased 4.16% to ₹59.61 lakh crore. LIC expects further improvement in VNB margins, supported by a favourable product mix and growth in high-margin segments, particularly non-participating savings and term assurance.

ONGC Q2 net jumps 57% on higher crude, gas realisations

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

State-owned Oil and Natural Gas Corporation (ONGC) reported a 57.3% year-on-year (YoY) surge in standalone net profit to ₹15,489 crore for the quarter ended September, on higher realisations from crude oil and natural gas.

The company also declared an interim dividend of ₹8 per equity share. Revenue for the quarter grew 32.8% YoY to ₹43,875 crore.

Adani Ports to acquire Europe's Evos for €2.56 bn enterprise value

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone Ltd. (APSEZ) will acquire 100% stake in Netherlands-based Evos B.V. from Igneo Infrastructure Partners for an enterprise value of €2.56 billion in an all-cash transaction, marking its entry into Europe's liquid storage market.

The acquisition values Evos at an equity value of €1.18 billion, implying an enterprise value-to-EBITDA multiple of 11.7 times CY25 earnings. The transaction will be funded via debt and is subject to regulatory and other approvals, besides works council consultation, APSEZ said in an exchange filing.


The transaction marks APSEZ's entry into Europe's liquid storage market.

Evos is Europe's second-largest independent liquid storage operator, with a capacity of 6.3 million cubic metres across eight port-based terminals in the Netherlands, Germany, Spain, Belgium and Malta.

It handled 37 MMT of throughput in CY25, generating a revenue of €392 million and EBITDA of €219 million.

"Evos marks an important milestone in APSEZ's trajectory towards handling 1 billion tonne of cargo and building a truly global, integrated transport platform," said Karan Adani, MD, APSEZ.

INBRIEF



Bharti net profit rises 24% to ₹10,710 crore in Sept. quarter

Telecom operator Bharti Airtel reported a 24% increase in consolidated profit to ₹10,710 crore in the second quarter ended September 2026, as per a regulatory filing. Consolidated revenue from operations grew by 16.7% to ₹60,877.5 crore during the reported quarter from ₹52,145.4 crore in the quarter of the last year. India revenue rose 9.4% to ₹42,308 crore. India mobile service revenue climbed 10.1% on strong customer additions and improved realisation with Average Revenue Per User expanding to ₹271 in Q2 FY27 from ₹256 in Q2 FY26, the company said. PTI

Oil rises as investors weigh risk of Iran war escalation

Brent crude futures rose on Thursday as investors weighed the risk of a further escalation of the U.S.-Israeli war with Iran after the losses suffered by U.S. President Donald Trump's Republican Party in Congressional elections this week. Brent futures were up 34 cents, or 0.36%, at $94.96 a barrel as of 0825 GMT, while U.S. West Texas Intermediate crude futures were down 27 cents, or 0.31%, at $87.85 in choppy trade. Both benchmarks tumbled by more than 8% in the previous session to settle at their lowest since August 31. REUTERS

Apollo Hospitals' Q2 net rises 32% on broad-based growth

Apollo Hospitals Enterprise Ltd. reported a 32% year-on-year rise in consolidated net profit to ₹630 crore in Q2 of FY27 on higher patient volume and growth across hospital, pharmacy and digital healthcare units. Consolidated revenue rose 23% to ₹7,615 crore while EBITDA grew 29% to ₹1,191 crore. Hospital business reported a revenue of ₹3,900 crore, up 23%. Its EBITDA grew 20% to ₹937 crore. Inpatient volume rose 14% to 1.86 lakh while occupancy improved to 73% from 69%. Average revenue per inpatient rose 8% to ₹1,86,880.

Taken for a ride?



Stir for livelihood: A protester dressed as Deadpool superhero, rides a toy unicorn during a demonstration demanding higher wages and supporting high school protest movement, in Lyon, France, Thursday. AP

CBG blending at 1.7% in H1; pipeline connectivity key to achieving 3% target

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

India achieved 1.7% blending of compressed biogas (CBG) with domestic piped natural gas (D-PNG) and vehicular compressed natural gas (CNG) in the first half of the current fiscal, but will need an acceleration in sales during the second half to meet the mandated 3% target, according to the Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board (PNGRB).

The country has set a blending target of 4% for 2027-28, rising to 5% in the subsequent fiscal.

CBG sales stood at 115.9 million standard cubic metres (MMSCM) during the April-September period, against combined CNG and D-PNG sales of 6,800 MMSCM. With the combined consumption of the two fuels projected at 13,600 MMSCM for the full fiscal, CBG sales will have to rise to 408 MMSCM to achieve the 3% blending target, requiring an additional 292.1 MMSCM over the first-half volume.


A view of Kochi Corporation's CBG plant at Brahmapuram

Flagging infrastructure gaps, PNGRB stressed the need to connect CBG plants to gas pipelines to ensure assured offtake and better utilisation of installed capacity.

Of the 210 functional CBG plants in the country, capacity utilisation averages just 44%. More significantly, 247 of the 308 plants under construction currently have no plans for pipeline connectivity.

"A reliable pipeline connection gives CBG plant a buyer every day of the year. Plants with a pipeline, or one being built, use 65-69% of their designed capacity. Better pipeline access means better gas offtake and overall use of every plant," it said.

Mineral block auctions: ninth tranche offers 20 blocks

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Ministry of Mines on Thursday launched the ninth tranche of mineral block auctions, featuring 20 critical and strategic mineral blocks, alongside the third tranche of exploration licence auctions covering 11 blocks.

The latest mineral block auction includes deposits of graphite, glauconite, vanadium, gallium, titanium, rare earth elements (REE), tungsten, potash and halite, among other minerals.

The third round of exploration licence auctions, which grants concessions through competitive bidding, covers blocks containing copper, potash, halite, and vanadium.

Centre eyes advanced EVs in major push for green mobility

S. Ronendra Singh
NEW DELHI


The proposed category will bring together EVs, REEVs and plug-in hybrid electric vehicles

The government is considering a new umbrella category – advanced electrified vehicles (AEVs) – for passenger cars with large batteries, as it moves towards a multi-powertrain approach to green mobility that goes beyond pure electric vehicles (EVs).

The proposed category will bring together EVs, range-extended electric vehicles (REEVs) and plug-in hybrid electric vehicles (PHEVs). The idea emerged after the notification of the third phase of the Corporate Average Fuel Economy (CAFE-III) norms on September 29.

Government sources told *businessline* that an inter-ministerial exercise to discuss the proposal will follow after consultations with the industry.

At the heart of the exercise is a mismatch. CAFE-III recognises REEVs and PHEVs, but the Central Motor Vehicles Rules (CMVR), 1989, do not define them clearly. "Only EVs have a clear definition in the CMVR. There is no clear definition of REEVs and PHEVs. REEVs are defined within the definition of PHEVs, which is an anomaly that needs correction. PHEVs are also clubbed with the strong hybrids category, even though the latter run on a small battery pack (less than 2kWh)," said sources.

A REEV is driven by an electric motor powered by a large battery, with a small petrol engine that only recharges it. A PHEV has both an engine and a sizeable battery that can be charged from a socket, so it can run on electricity for a stretch before switching to petrol. A strong hybrid, by contrast, has a small battery that cannot be plugged in and simply helps the engine save fuel.

Battery power

Rather than classifying cars by the type of engine, the proposal aims to label them based on how much they rely on the battery.

Under the proposal being considered, AEVs would be vehicles with a battery of at least 15 kWh that can run meaningfully on electric power in large cities and chargable from outside the vehicle. "These are vehicles with battery sizes upwards of 15 kWh and offer sufficient run on electric mode in large cities and metros, while also having a provision for off-board charging," said an official. The revised definitions will be aligned with CAFE-III, said sources.

CAFE-III norms

The CAFE-III norms nudge carmakers towards cleaner fleets or face penalties. Under the norms, EVs and REEVs have been placed under the same volume derogation factor of 3, the highest in the category. PHEVs follow at 2.5.

(The writer is with The Hindu businessline)

AI shopping agents could threaten Amazon and Walmart's ad business



AI challenge: A worker assembles a box for delivery at the Amazon fulfillment center in Baltimore, U.S. REUTERS

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters

The rise of AI-led shopping is posing a conundrum for retailers like Walmart and Amazon: how to enable AI agents to shop on their websites,without threatening their lucrative advertising revenue and the customer data that fuels it.

Retail powerhouses Walmart and Amazon are also the world's two largest retail media businesses, dominating the estimated $74.4 billion in U.S. retail media spending with a combined 88% share of that market, according to projections from data firm Emarketer. But digital assistants could soon disrupt that business.

Erode profitable business

AI-powered agents that can research and purchase products on consumers' behalf – like Meta's recently released Muse– could erode the highly profitable business of brands paying retailers to promote products on their websites and apps. Morgan Stanley researchers said in July these agents could account for 10% to 20% of U.S. e-commerce spending by 2030.

Amazon and Walmart are taking different approaches to agentic AI shopping. Amazon has blocked Muse, while Walmart is officially partnering with Meta's agentic tool.

So far, there is no meaningful effect yet on Amazon ads from third-party agents, Amazon CEO Andy Jassy said last week. However, the company's 11% year-on-year growth in advertising revenue for the third quarter was its slowest pace of growth in nearly four years, LSEG data show. The segment consistently accounts for about 10% of total net sales.

Different approaches

Amazon banned Muse from its website in September, saying it appeared to have accessed its online store without authorisation, capturing and storing customer credentials. Meta declined to comment.

The e-commerce leader told *Reuters* this week that third-party agents should operate openly and respect service providers' decisions about whether or not to participate. Amazon also won a court order blocking Perplexity's shopping agent Comet in March, though the 9th U.S. Circuit Court of Appeals overturned the ban in August, a decision Amazon said it disagreed with. The case is ongoing.

Walmart, conversely, rolled out infrastructure on October 21 to enable third-party agentic commerce. When a shopper uses an agent to browse, Walmart will create a profile for that agent that links to the shopper's Walmart account. Consumers can approve purchases or set spending limits.

Walmart CFO John David Rainey told analysts and investors in August that advertising, which includes the Walmart Connect retail media business, along with its membership and marketplace operations, accounted for 45% of quarterly operating income growth. Walmart does not separately break out Walmart Connect's figures in its earnings release.

Dan Marc, CEO of retail media platform Footprints AI, said he expects companies like Amazon and Walmart to start signing their largest advertisers to multiyear ad deals to secure those revenues and also expects more discounts on digital retail media ads as shoppers turn to large language models and agentic tools. Walmart declined to comment.

Shifting marketing landscape

Morningstar analyst Brett Husslein said the moment presents "an evolution rather than an existential threat" for retail media. Brands are expected to spend 22.6% more on retail media in 2026 than last year's $60.7 billion, Emarketer forecasts show.

This year, Walmart started testing ads within Sparky, its AI shopping chatbot, just as Amazon has embedded them in its AI shopping assistant, Alexa for Shopping.

Advertising for bots may rely less on visual flair or emotional resonance and more on specific product data that matches customer queries using AI chatbots, industry practitioners and consultants say.

Trump's poll humbling signifies short term gain, long-term pain for Beijing

Republicans' midterm loss may hand China leverage in trade talks, analysts say; Beijing may use respite to diversify trade ties, bolster economic resilience; Democrats may push Trump harder to unfreeze $14 bn in Taiwan arms; post-Trump WH could prove less accommodating to China

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
BEIJING

The midterm drubbing of Donald Trump's Republicans may strengthen China's hand in trade talks with Washington, but Beijing is unlikely to revel in the misfortunes of a U.S. president whose successor could prove less accommodating.

U.S. voters angered by rising living costs, exacerbated by Trump's trade wars with China and other countries, turned on his party in Tuesday's vote, handing Democrats control of Congress.

That political humbling should make Trump more wary of unsettling a fragile trade truce with Beijing, some political analysts said, giving China a potential advantage in negotiations set to resume later this month.

Washington's divided political landscape also gives Beijing space to fortify itself and diversify trade ties before a potentially less China-friendly U.S. administration takes power, some Chinese and Western analysts added.

"The Chinese are very realistic that a new president might be very different (from Trump)," said Shen Weizhong, a former Chinese Foreign Ministry official.



Reset in ties: Donald Trump with Xi Jinping Washington, D.C. U.S. REUTERS FILE

"But if we can have two more years of stability, that's already a good thing for China ... The more time we have, the better prepared we might be towards a final showdown on Taiwan or maybe another trade war," added Shen, who now works for Beijing-based think tank Global Governance Institution.

Unlikely to be smooth

The next two years, however, may not be smooth sailing for Beijing, other analysts said.

The risk is that Trump, constrained at home, becomes more aggressive in seeking foreign policy wins, while a Democratic-controlled Congress may push him harder to unfreeze arms sales to Taiwan, a red line for Beijing.

> After years of dealing primarily with Trump, Beijing now faces a Congress far more intent on pressing human rights issues, scrutinising Chinese investments

"There are more foreign policy actions that Trump can take that are unconventional and untold," said senior China analyst Chim Lee at the Economist Intelligence Unit.

"The broad direction of U.S.-China policy isn't necessarily going to change, but I think that the concern is around less conventional foreign policy issues that would have unexpected ramifications for China," he said.

Top among the concerns is an escalation of the Iran war into a wider regional conflict. That could trigger a sustained spike in global oil prices, threaten China's energy security and disrupt Beijing's ties in the Middle East.

Sensing weakness

In the short term, attention turns to imminent trade talks, with Trump set to meet Chinese President Xi Jinping on the sidelines of the APEC summit in Shenzhen later this month and then in Miami in December for the G20.

At stake is a truce in a trade war - expiring in January -that averted a major shock to the global economy last year.

Beijing could conclude that Trump's political problems mean he needs a deal more than China, encouraging Chinese negotiators to press harder for tariff reductions and other U.S. concessions, said Craig Singleton, senior fellow at the Foundation for Defense of Democracies, a U.S. think tank.

However, that also risks a "miscalculation that unsettles the very stability Xi is trying to preserve," he added. Trump has repeatedly railed against what he sees as China's unfair trade with Washington, slapping triple-digit tariffs on Chinese goods shortly after he returned to office last year to address a trade imbalance he said was "killing" the United States.

However, he has since significantly softened his tone, feting Xi at two grand summits in Beijing and Washington that delivered few tangible economic wins. Trump's bonhomie with Xi stands in contrast to his Democratic predecessor, Joe Biden, who repeatedly angered China with comments over human rights issues and a pledge that the U.S. would defend Taiwan if Beijing attacked. Some of Trump's potential Republican successors, such as Secretary of State Marco Rubio, are also seen by analysts as more hawkish on China.

After the midterms, Trump could be even less willing to upset the stable relationship he has developed with China, said Wu Xinbo, a professor at Shanghai's Fudan University who advises China's Foreign Ministry.

Beyond trade, Trump may also seek to enlist Beijing's help to secure other foreign policy wins as the clock ticks on his presidency - such as ending the war between Russia and Ukraine or arranging another summit with North Korea's Kim Jong Un.

Beijing, which maintains deep trade ties with Russia and North Korea, could use that leverage in exchange for concessions from Trump, analysts said.

But after years of dealing primarily with Trump, Beijing now faces a Congress far more intent on pressing human rights issues, scrutinising Chinese investments and delivering a $14 billion package of arms to Taiwan that Trump has said he is withholding as a "negotiating chip" with Xi. China claims democratically governed Taiwan and has asked for the arms sales to stop.

"The Chinese will definitely react strongly against that,"said Shen, the former Chinese Foreign Ministry official, calling it "risk number one" after the midterms.

Canva's restructuring shows how AI is reshaping the creative industry and transforming business

EXPLAINER

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is upending the rules of the game. It is rewriting them across industries, businesses, and geographies, touching almost every aspect of the economy.

The creative industry is no exception. Generative AI is changing how visual content is designed, produced and sold, forcing firms to rethink products and business models.

Canva is among those navigating this shift. The design platform just announced that it is reorganising its workforce amid slowing growth and rapid technological change. Its move comes as other companies in the creative industry grapple with the opportunities and challenges posed by generative AI.

In a note to employees published on its website, Canva co-founder and CEO Melanie Perkins said that 1,271 employees, or 22% of the company's workforce, would be affected by the changes.

The figure includes employees whose roles will change, those who will relocate to centralised hubs, and those who will leave the company. Canva has not disclosed how many of the 1,271 employees will be asked to leave.

Ms. Perkins described it as "the hardest moment in our 13-year history". She said the company had experienced its hardest year yet, with growth slowing for the first time in a decade. She also pointed to the pace of technological change and how it was transforming what people create, how they create it and what they expect from products.



New template: Generative AI is changing the economics of businesses. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

The firm is combining its Product, Growth, and Platform teams into a single product organisation. It plans to reduce layers of management, consolidate overlapping responsibilities and give employees broader roles. Sydney will become the primary base for more product teams.

The announcement does not establish that AI prompted the restructuring. However, it comes at a time when generative AI is changing the economics and competitive landscape of businesses that make creative software and sell visual content. The impact is not uniform. For established software firms like Adobe AI is becoming a capability embedded in existing products. For Figma, it is expanding the platform beyond professional designers while adding infrastructure costs. For Getty Images, it presents a more fundamental challenge: AI-generated images could substitute for photographs and illustrations that underpin its licensing business.

Part of creative toolkit

Adobe's strategy is to integrate AI into its existing software portfolio rather than position it as a separate business. Its Firefly platform combines the company's own generative AI models with models from other developers.

In its 2025 stockholder letter, Adobe said that AI-influenced annual recurring revenue (ARR) accounted for more than a third of its overall business at the end of the financial year. ARR is the annualised value of recurring subscriptions, not the revenue the company earned from AI alone. Adobe's definition of AI-influenced ARR includes subscriptions to products and plans enhanced by AI features; it does not measure the additional revenue generated exclusively by AI.

Adobe reported revenue of $23.77 billion in fiscal 2025, a rise of 11% from the previous year. Its total ARR stood at $25.20 billion at the end of the year.

The firm is also positioning Firefly as a platform that gives clients access to different AI models. Adobe says Firefly combines own models, which it describes as commercially safe, with more than 25 models from partners including Google and OpenAI.

It has also introduced customised AI models for businesses, trained on their own branded content. The strategy is to give customers a choice of models while keeping content creation integrated with Adobe's existing software and marketing tools.

Expand the audience

Figma, best known for its collaborative interface-design software, is extending its reach beyond professional designers into the broader product-development process.

Its tools are increasingly used by developers, product managers, researchers, marketers and writers. In its 2025 annual report, the firm said people who were not designers accounted for about two-thirds of its monthly active users in the three months ended December 31, 2025.

Its AI product, Figma Make, allows users to turn prompts or existing designs into working prototypes and web applications. The firm said weekly active users of Figma Make grew by more than 70% quarter-on-quarter in the fourth quarter of 2025. More than half of its paid clients with an ARR above $100,000 used the product every week during that quarter.

But expanding AI capabilities also brings costs. According to the annual report, it identified higher technical infrastructure and hosting expenses associated with AI and increased platform usage.

The company said $49.1 million of the increase in its cost of revenue was attributable to higher infrastructure and hosting costs, including costs related to AI and increased usage by paid users. The entire amount cannot be attributed to AI alone.

Figma also warned that customers may expect AI features to be included in their existing subscriptions. This could make it harder for the company to charge separately for those features and recover the additional costs.

It expects investments in AI and the use of AI technology to put pressure on its gross and operating margins in the short term.

Licensing model at risk

Getty Images faces a different kind of challenge. Its business traditionally depended on licensing photographs, illustrations and videos to clients. Generative AI could allow customers to create similar visuals without buying licences for existing content.

In its 2025 annual report, Getty identified two risks from the technology. The unauthorised use of its content to train AI models and the possibility that AI-generated images and videos could compete with or substitute for its licensed material. The company warned that customers may increasingly choose generated visuals, potentially affecting revenue from traditional licensing.

Getty is also trying to participate in this market. It launched Generative AI by Getty Images in 2023 and Generative AI by iStock in early 2024.

Both tools allow users to generate images from text prompts or existing images, using models trained on Getty's creative content. The firm says the tools are designed for commercial use and creators compensated for the use of their work in its AI models.

Its legal dispute with AI developer Stability AI illustrates the conflict over training data. In its U.S. lawsuit, Getty alleges Stability AI reproduced about 12 million images from its websites, along with captions and metadata, for use in connection with its Stable Diffusion model.

Different AI pressures

The three firms show different pressures created by generative AI. Adobe is integrating AI into its existing software portfolio. Figma is extending its platform beyond professional designers into the wider software-development process, while managing the costs of AI infrastructure. Getty Images is trying to turn a potential substitute for its licensed content into a new revenue stream.

Canva's restructuring comes against this wider industry shift, but its move does not establish AI prompted the changes. Ms. Perkins cited slowing growth and changing technology without explaining what influenced the decision. She is due to address employees at a company meeting on November 10.

DHAKA

Hasina says she will return from exile in December 'at any cost'



AP

Former Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina, ousted in a mass uprising and left to India in 2024, has told *The Associated Press* that she remains committed to returning to Bangladesh from exile in India next month, despite being sentenced to death over her government's deadly crackdown on protesters. AP

HONG KONG

Hong Kong activist Joshua Wong sentenced to 10 more years in jail



AFP

A Hong Kong court sentenced prominent activist Joshua Wong to 10 more years in prison on Thursday under a Beijing-imposed national security law, in a case that critics say underscores the crackdown on the city's pro-democracy movement. Mr. Wong, 30, was already serving a four-year, eight-month prison term. AP

TEHRAN

Iranians burn giant poster of Trump and allies, demand revenge



AFP

Following the drubbing of U.S. President Donald Trump's Republican Party in the midterm elections, Iranians set fire to a giant poster featuring the American leader and his allies — J.D. Vance, Steve Witkoff and Benjamin Netanyahu — at a rally in Tehran, while demanding revenge for Khamenei's death. AFP

WASHINGTON

Amish Shah wins in Arizona, 6th Indian-American in the U.S. House



REUTERS

Indian-American physician Amish Shah has made history after becoming the first from the community to represent Arizona in Congress. Mr. Shah, a three-term member of the Arizona House of Representatives, defeated Republican Jay Feely, a former National Football League player, who was endorsed by President Trump. PTI

Eisenkot closer to forming govt. in Israel with backing of Arab lists

Joint List bagged 11 seats and Ra'am won 8 seats in election; in October 27 polls, neither Netanyahu nor Eisenkot secured enough votes for majority; once President gives mandate to a lawmaker, the person will have 28 days to form government

Agence France-Presse
JERUSALEM

Israel's largest Arab list on Thursday said it would back Gadi Eisenkot to form the next government, bolstering his chances of being picked over Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, who lost the support of an allied religious party.

President Isaac Herzog was holding a second day of consultations with political parties after the October 27 election, in which neither Mr. Netanyahu – a polarising right-winger who has led Israel through three years of war – nor Mr. Eisenkot – a former military chief promising to restore national unity – secured enough votes for a majority.



Differing voices: Protesters in Jerusalem call for the formation of a Netanyahu-Eisenkot unity government, on Thursday. AP

Mr. Herzog will choose by himself whom to ask to form a new government, but traditionally the mandate is given to the person recommended by more parties, which would be Mr. Eisenkot.

Arab-majority lists won an unprecedented 19 seats in the election, making them potential kingmakers if Mr. Eisenkot's Opposition chooses to work with them – something which remains unclear.

Both Arab lists on Thursday said they were backing Mr. Eisenkot.

The Joint List, which bagged 11 seats, said in a statement that "it will inform the President of the State, Isaac Herzog, this evening of its decision to recommend that Gadi Eisenkot be tasked with forming the government".

Ra'am, which won eight seats, also endorsed Mr. Eisenkot.

Meanwhile, United Torah Judaism, which backed Mr. Netanyahu after the previous five elections, in its meeting with Mr. Herzog declined to recommend Mr. Netanyahu again as Prime Minister, although it also did not side with Mr. Eisenkot.

Observers say United Torah Judaism's tactic is likely aimed mostly at punishing Mr. Netanyahu and showing that their votes cannot be taken for granted.

Once Mr. Herzog gives his mandate to a lawmaker, the person will have 28 days to form a government, with a potential 14-day extension.

V-P Vance eyes own trail in 'America First' politics

NEWS ANALYSIS

Varghese K. George



J.D. Vance speaks during a rally at Koury Convention Centre in Greensboro, North Carolina, on September 21. REUTERS

It is the Trump administration, not the people, that abandoned America First politics, according to U.S. Vice-President J.D. Vance. He said the Republican rout in the midterm elections was a direct outcome of the administration's policies, particularly the war on Iran. Many see Mr. Vance's position as a rebellion against President Donald J. Trump.

Mr. Vance's measured but pointed disavowal of the direction of his own administration keeps him in pole position as the frontrunner for the Republican presidential nomination in 2028. The election debacle strengthens, not in the least weakens, Mr. Vance's position, and further diminishes the prospects of Secretary of State Marco Rubio, a conventional Christian conservative who boarded the America First movement largely out of political expediency.

The Republicans were swept away in the U.S. midterm elections, which flipped both the House and the Senate to the Democrats, not necessarily because voters abandoned America First politics, but because the Trump administration did so, according to Mr. Vance. The Vice-President, by virtue of his upbringing and intellectual formation, is different from his boss, who is a salesman-politician, and from Mr. Rubio, who stands out as an opportunist in the America First world.

"You are going to enjoy this ride," Mr. Trump told Mr. Vance in his closing speech at the Republican National Convention in 2024. Mr. Vance seems to be doing so. Mr. Vance has consistently remained critical of deviations from America First politics within the administration, particularly the war on Iran and its deference to Israel. The midterms were the occasion for Mr. Vance to tell his boss, and his colleagues: I told you so.

Core reasons

In a statement that was viewed 51 million times on X in the first 12 hours alone, Mr. Vance identified the war as the most important factor among the four reasons he cited. "The reason we lost is the war," Mr. Vance said. Trump voters of 2024 abandoned the Republican Party in droves not because they changed their politics, but because the Trump administration did. According to an unnamed pollster whom Mr. Vance trusts, these voters wanted four things: (1) end the war, (2) focus on the cost of living and inflation, (3) put America First, and (4) change the U.S. relationship with Israel. It is important to note that many Democratic voters would not disagree with this assessment.

Mr. Vance has made immigration law enforcement a central feature of his politics. While many analysts see the heavy-handed enforcement of immigration laws as one of the reasons for the Republican setback, Mr. Vance is not willing to go that far. He has, in fact, vowed that enforcement must continue, though he has expressed a willingness to shift the focus towards those who hire undocumented immigrants.

He emphatically ruled out amnesty as an option to resolve the immigration crisis in the U.S. "I'm open to the idea that we should change enforcement, by focusing more on businesses that hire illegal labour, for instance. But anyone pushing amnesty is lying to you," Mr. Vance said.

What continues to work for Mr. Vance is that he manages to challenge and critique Mr. Trump without triggering a meltdown from the latter. Whether he can continue in that manner all the way to the 2028 election remains to be seen. But Mr. Vance would be perfectly capable of carrying forward his own version of America First without Mr. Trump. The President has lost some of his bite, and he is no longer the sole arbiter of America First politics. Republicans can be America First and non-Trumpist at the same time. Mr. Vance is exploring the boundaries of that possibility, and he seems poised to lead his leader along. Mr. Trump has expressed a willingness to work even with Democrats on contentious issues, including immigration. Mr. Vance is taking a shot at being both the insider and the outsider at once.

Saudi Arabia issues alerts, warns of 'danger' in Yanbu

Reuters
RIYADH

Saudi Arabia issued alerts on Thursday warning of potential danger in Yanbu, the kingdom's Red Sea oil export hub, as Yemen's Houthis (Ansar Allah) continue attacks on the kingdom that have opened another front in the U.S.-Israeli war on Iran.

The Saudi-led coalition fighting the Houthis in Yemen said it destroyed a missile launched by the group towards Islam's holy city of Medina.

"Air defence intercepted and destroyed a ballistic missile launched by the terrorist Houthi militia toward the Medina region," coalition spokesperson Turki al-Malki said in a post on X.



Fighters from the Saudi-led coalition hold a position during clashes with Houthis in Yemen's northwestern Jawf province. AFP

The Houthis rejected any suggestion they were targeting the city, saying such accusations were a "blatant and grave falsehood". "Our operations target only its oil facilities and military bases."

The kingdom's civil defence also issued emergency alerts for the southeastern area of Sharurah that borders Yemen.

Houthis said on Wednesday they had attacked Riyadh's international airport while Syria's President Ahmed al-Sharaa visited the kingdom.

Saudi Arabia, the world's biggest oil exporter and a key U.S. ally, has been requesting assistance from countries for support in its renewed war against the Yemeni militia.

Iran says two tankers and tugboat caught fire in Hormuz Strait

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

Fars news agency says IRGC Navy 'took control' of two LUCAS drones, a U.S.-developed model

Two oil tankers and a tugboat caught fire in the Strait of Hormuz, Iran's Revolutionary Guards said, according to local media on Thursday.

"Last night, in two separate incidents, a large oil tanker attempting to pass through the illegal passageway south of the Strait of Hormuz suffered a fire after striking a mine and was brought to a halt," the Guards told the *Fars* news agency.

"Another supertanker was halted by a massive fire while exiting the eastern Strait of Hormuz. A tugboat that had approached the supertanker to extinguish the fire also caught fire."

There has been no confirmation of either incident from maritime officials.

British monitor UKMTO reported a tanker being struck by "two unidentified projectiles" around 50 nautical miles off the north coast of Qatar.

Fars also reported that the IRGC Navy's electronic warfare unit had taken control of two LUCAS drones, a U.S.-developed model.

Midterm election results place U.S.-Israel relations under further strain

NEWS ANALYSIS

Stanly Johny

The political implications were visible even before the election results. On election day, President Donald Trump announced that the U.S. would stop providing about $4 billion in annual military aid to Israel, America's closest ally in West Asia, by the end of the year. Mr. Trump cited the political cost of the issue for Republicans, specifically referring to Abdul El-Sayed, the Democratic Senate candidate from Michigan, who has made opposition to U.S. military assistance to Israel a central campaign plank. Mr. El-Sayed beat Mike Rogers of the Republican Party to become the first Muslim Senator of the U.S.

Mr. Trump's announcement showed that even the Republican President, who moved the American embassy to Jerusalem in his first term, cracked down on pro-Palestine protests at home and launched a war, along with Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, against Iran, recognised the growing electoral liability of unconditional support for Israel.

The midterm results could accelerate this political churn. The Democrats have secured control of both the House and the Senate. The election was fought largely on domestic issues, particularly the economy and the cost of living, but the war on Iran and its impact on the economy, particularly fuel prices, also figured in the Republican setback. Mr. Trump himself acknowledged that the war had hurt his party. Vice-President J.D. Vance, in a lengthy social media post, blamed the war for the defeat, and one of the four suggestions made to gain back the ground was to "change our relationship to Israel".



Donald Trump shakes hands with Benjamin Netanyahu after meeting at Mar-a-Lago club in Palm Beach, Florida. REUTERS

Opposition to Israel

The opposition to Israel, which was until recently largely confined to the margins of American politics, is entering the mainstream. Politicians such as New York Mayor Zohran Mamdani, Mr. El-Sayed and Democratic Representative Ro Khanna have been openly critical of Israel, and Washington's support for its policies. On the Republican side, sections of the MAGA movement have questioned why the U.S. should continue to commit its resources to Israel, particularly when Americans are facing economic pressures at home.

On the left, Israel's conduct in Gaza, including allegations of war crimes and genocide, has eroded support among Democratic voters. House Democrats have split almost evenly on Israel-related votes. On the right, the 'America First' wing has grown uneasy about open-ended commitments abroad. Mr. Trump campaigned on ending Gaza's war. He managed to get a ceasefire in October 2025, but Israel continues to bomb the enclave.

The war on Iran sharpened the mood. The U.S.-Israeli military campaign, launched on February 28, has kept gas prices high in the U.S. and deepened the cost of living crisis. Critics on both sides argue that Mr. Netanyahu pulled Mr. Trump into a war he could not win. Now when even the Vice-President is blaming the war for the electoral defeat, the real target is the 'special relationship' with Israel.

Eroding support

For Israel, the challenge is more immediate. Its leadership has long operated on the assumption that bipartisan support in Washington is a strategic constant. That assumption is becoming increasingly difficult to sustain as critics are gaining ground and Israel increasingly becoming a campaign issue. Mr. Netanyahu's close political alignment with the Republican Party and his personal relationship with Mr. Trump have also made the relationship vulnerable to changes in American domestic politics.

Now that Mr. Netanyahu himself lost governing majority in Israel and Mr. Trump has been rendered a lame duck by the midterm results, Israel will have to make a greater effort to rebuild its eroding support.

The U.S.-Israel relationship, rooted in intelligence, military and technological cooperation, is unlikely to fall apart. But future administrations could revisit America's presence in and policy towards West Asia, strategically deprioritising the whole region and Israel in particular.

At home, the political terms of the relationship are changing. The midterm elections have exposed the costs of treating support for Israel as an unquestioned feature of American politics.

Both parties will face growing pressure to reassess that position, while Israel will have to recognise that its actions in West Asia can no longer be insulated from the political consequences at home and abroad.



Disputed publication: The book contains chapters on Thailand's monarchy in the 21st century. GETTY IMAGES

Thailand bans book on national security grounds

Agence France-Presse
BANGKOK, THAILAND

Thailand has banned a textbook about the country on national security grounds, with the book's exiled editor saying on Thursday that it was outlawed over its content on the Thai monarchy.

The royal family holds revered status in Thai society and is shielded from criticism by a strict defamation law that critics say is used to muzzle dissent.

The book, a second edition of the *Routledge Handbook of Contemporary Thailand* published in English in August, was edited by Pavin Chachavalpongpun, a prominent academic and critic of the Thai monarchy who is based in Japan.

It contains chapters on Thailand's monarchy in the 21st century and the government's use of the lese-majeste law.

The book's first edition, released in 2019, was not banned, Mr. Pavin told *AFP*. He said it was updated to "reflect changes in Thai politics" since 2020 youth-led pro-democracy protests, which featured unprecedented calls to reform the monarchy and the military. The demonstrations were followed by a progressive party's election victory three years later that ended with its candidate being blocked from becoming Prime Minister by military-appointed senators and court challenges.

"Topics like this are why they decided to ban it," Mr. Pavin said in a telephone interview.

An order signed by National Police Chief Samran Nualma released on Wednesday said the book includes articles that "adversely affect national security and might cause unrest in the country". Police have the authority to seize and destroy the book, the order said.

Iranian college students face pressure as authorities crack down on dissent

Scores of university students face hearings for joining protests, say Iranian student unions; those brought before panels risk expulsion or ban on further study; some have lost their jobs or faced death threats; a top cleric warned that campus dissent threatened Iran's rulers and must be ended

Associated Press
CAIRO

After participating in an anti-government protest on campus, the social sciences student was called into a disciplinary hearing at his university and faced an intimidating panel. It included a cleric representing Iran's Supreme Leader and an official who refused to identify himself.

The questioning he faced underscored Iranian officials' determination to root out dissent at universities after crushing massive demonstrations in January and after the outbreak of war with the United States. The cleric and the official asked: When former Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei was killed in air strikes at the beginning of the war on February 28, "what did you feel?"

Scores of university students around Iran are facing similar hearings for joining protests, according to Iranian student unions and outside rights monitors. It is another side of a campaign by the authorities to silence dissent as the war and a months-long U.S. naval blockade worsen Iran's economic crisis.

The *Associated Press* spoke by phone and through messaging apps with half a dozen student protesters in Iran who are facing disciplinary procedures; all spoke on condition of anonymity out of fear of retribution.

Severe repercussions

Students brought before panels face potential expulsion or even a ban from further study at any university. The repercussions can extend beyond campus walls. Some have been fired from their jobs or have faced death threats or other harassment when details of their cases became public.

The disciplinary measures followed college protests that sprouted up parallel to the wave of demonstrations that began in late December, triggered by a currency crash. Those demonstrations quickly grew into the largest nationwide protests since the 1979 Iranian revolution. Security forces crushed them by opening fire, killing thousands and arresting thousands more.

Even after that, smaller campus protests persisted, up to the eve of the February 28 U.S.-Israeli attack on Iran that triggered the war.

In February, Gholamhossein Mohseni Ejei, Iran's hard-line judiciary chief, said that judicial authorities would get involved in prosecuting crimes on campuses if educational authorities were unable to control them.

Weeks of heavy U.S. and Israeli bombardment of Iran put university measures against students on hold. But since the summer, students began being called into hearings.



Tense scene: Iranians attend an anti-government protest in Tehran on January 9, 2026. AP

As universities reopened last month, a top cleric warned that campus dissent was a threat to Iran's rulers that must be ended. "The enemy wants to start internal pressure from the university environment and follow it throughout the country," said Ahmad Alamolhoda, who is the Friday prayer leader in the eastern shrine city of Mashhad and the Supreme Leader's representative in the province.

Iranian authorities are still arresting and prosecuting protesters tied to the January protests, with some facing the death penalty.

The number of expulsions and suspensions remain unclear. But the "severity of action" has risen compared with past crackdowns, explained Ali Taghipour, an exiled Iranian activist who tracks student protests. The process can take several months, with several levels of hearings before the Ministry overseeing universities signs off on any punishments.

Shargh, a reformist newspaper, reported last month a growing tally of expulsions at half a dozen universities in the capital. At least 10 students have been expelled at the University of Tehran, another 10 at Amir Kabir University, and others have been handed suspensions. *AP* has been unable to independently verify these particular cases.

The procedures appear geared toward intimidating the students into silence.

The social sciences student and another student both said that administrators forced them to write out their defences even before being told the charges against them – leaving them guessing about what to put down.

The charges against the social sciences student included participating in an "illegal gathering." His personal contact details were also published on pro-government social media channels, and he now fears being attacked by government supporters.

Students describe pressure from university officials to recant anti-government stances in order to avoid punishment.

At Sharif University, one of Iran's most elite schools, administrators have reviewed action against some 250 students, its student union president Farzad Rahmani told the reformist media outlet *Ensaf*. At least 40 of them have faced hearings so far, and 10 have been expelled, he said.

Disciplinary hearings usually involve university administrators, faculty members, a representative of the Supreme Leader and the campus security agency, known as Harasat, which operates under the Intelligence Ministry and monitors political loyalty to Iran's theocracy. Members of the feared Basij volunteer militia, which maintains a presence on university campuses, also often participate.

"The role of the Basij and the Harasat is very strong," Taghipour said, explaining that they typically identify suspect students and gather cases against them.

Iran's college students have frequently propelled anti-government protests. Campus unrest played a key role in sustaining the 2022-23 protests against the mandatory headscarf, which also turned into calls for the overthrow of the theocracy.

UN peacekeeping mission prepares to exit Western Sahara after 35 years

Associated Press
LAAYOUNE

The UN peacekeeping mission in the disputed territory of Western Sahara will start repatriating personnel, closing a dozen facilities and disposing of equipment as part of a "liquidation phase" following a U.S.-Russia standoff at the Security Council last week.

The mission's abrupt end after 35 years raises questions about security and stability in the region. Western Sahara is a vast desert nearly the size of Colorado and rich in fisheries and minerals. The contested resource corridor once ruled by Spain is now claimed by both Morocco and the pro-independence Polisario Front.



Disputed land: Western Sahara is a vast desert nearly the size of Colorado and rich in fisheries and minerals. AFP

UN peacekeeping chief Jean-Pierre Lacroix said late Wednesday that the department dealing with operational issues of the UN's far-flung peacekeeping missions wants to ensure an "orderly" retreat. "And we count, of course, on the full cooperation of all the parties."

The UN mission, known as MINURSO, was established in 1991 to monitor a ceasefire between Morocco and the Polisario Front and organise a referendum on self-determination.

But the vote never materialised, as the two sides failed to agree on who would be eligible to participate. The ceasefire collapsed in 2020, and the UN says the region remains marked by tensions and low-intensity hostilities.

During the mission, 20 UN personnel lost their lives. The UN force was authorised to have 534 personnel, and its 2026-2027 budget was more than $62 million. The top military contributors to the force were Egypt, Ghana and Pakistan.

Morocco's royal palace, which oversees the country's foreign policy, welcomed the mission's end, saying it had failed to monitor the ceasefire. The Polisario Front and Algeria, meanwhile, regretted the decision not to renew its mandate.

Flaring protests



Up in arms: Protesters hold red flares as they stand on a bus stop during a demonstration called by French labour unions over wages, cost of living and public services, and joined by students demanding better school conditions, in Paris on Thursday. REUTERS

Trump's lawyers to argue against hush money conviction in appeals court

Associated Press
NEW YORK

United States President Donald Trump's lawyers will try to persuade a New York appeals court on Thursday to throw out his hush money conviction, two years after it made history.

The conviction, on 34 felony counts of falsifying business records to obscure a $130,000 payment to adult film performer Stormy Daniels, continues to nettle Trump enough that he denounced it on social media as recently as September. The President denies any wrongdoing, and he has turned to state and federal courts in hopes of unwinding the verdict.

He is not expected to attend Thursday's court session.

The appeal turns on complex legal disputes, but political overtones aren't hard to find. The very first paragraph of one of the Trump team's court filings contends that the case was the flimsy product of "immense political pressure" on a Democratic prosecutor to go after Mr. Trump – a rhetoric that echoes the Republican President's own often-repeated claims in the court of public opinion.

'House of cards'

In court papers, Mr. Trump's attorneys have assailed the prosecutors' legal theory as "a house of cards" built on a shaky combination of alleged state and federal offenses, with "clearly insufficient" evidence and problematic jury instructions.

The appeal also concerns whether jurors should have been allowed to hear testimony about supposed White House conversations, workflow and even Mr. Trump's social media posts during his first term. His lawyers cite presidential immunity for official acts, and they argue that his official conduct included responding to the Daniels drama once it became public in 2018.

"When a President addresses the nation to defend himself from allegations of personal misconduct (as all Presidents do), or discusses such communications with his aides, he is carrying out his constitutional duties and is protected by immunity," lawyer Robert Giuffra Jr. wrote in a filing this October.



Donald Trump was convicted of falsifying records to obscure a $130,000 payment to adult film performer Stormy Daniels. AP

'Mountain' of evidence

Manhattan District Attorney Alvin Bragg's office counters that the legal theory and jury instructions were legitimate and that the White House-related evidence was fair game. Some was public record, some was a general description of office practices, and the conversations were "unofficial conduct," prosecutors say.

"A President's discussions about a purely private matter, even with a White House advisor, do not constitute official acts for which the President is immune," Mr. Bragg's appeals chief, Steven Wu, wrote in a filing in July. Besides, he said, there was "a mountain" of other evidence against Mr. Trump.

The May 2024 verdict made Mr. Trump the first former – and now current – U.S. President with a criminal conviction. While historic, it did not impede his return to the White House or subject him to any punishment.

The trial involved $130,000 that Ms. Daniels got from Mr. Trump's then-fixer and lawyer, Michael Cohen, weeks before the 2016 election. The money bought, for a time, her silence about an alleged sexual encounter with the married Mr. Trump a decade earlier. He says that nothing sexual happened between them.

Mr. Trump's company reimbursed Mr. Cohen in 2017, logging those payments as legal expenses.

Saying that all the transactions were meant to keep unflattering information about Mr. Trump away from the electorate, prosecutors argue that he "orchestrated a conspiracy" that violated federal campaign finance laws, among others.

Mr. Trump's lawyers argue that there is only "weak" evidence that he even knew about Mr. Cohen's dealings at the time. His trial attorneys also said that payments to Mr. Cohen were indeed legal expenses, and that any hush money expended on Mr. Trump's behalf was not hidden campaign spending, just an effort to avoid embarrassing his family.

The distinction matters because, under New York law, falsifying business records is not a felony unless it is done with an intent to commit or conceal a separate crime.

While pursuing his state appeal, Mr. Trump has also been trying to shift the case to federal court and have it dismissed on immunity grounds.

A federal judge said no – for the third time – in August. Mr. Trump's attorneys are appealing that decision, and arguments on that appeal are set for November 16.

TRULY INSPIRATIONAL

‘Ronaldo was the ultimate symbol of the spirit of our national team’



FILE PHOTO

The Portuguese Football Federation thanked Cristiano Ronaldo for his services to the national team. “The Portuguese Football Federation expresses its eternal gratitude to its perennial captain. Our captain was an inspirational leader, and the ultimate symbol of the spirit of our national team,” the statement said.

FULSOME PRAISE

Infantino highlights Ronaldo’s impact and extraordinary talent



FILE PHOTO

Few players have ever touched the heart of fans quite like Cristiano. A career defined by extraordinary talent, relentless determination and an unwavering desire to push the boundaries. He has achieved milestones that may never be matched but his greatest legacy goes far beyond that — FIFA president Gianni Infantino.

A PRIVILEGE

Legend, Forever No. 1, Inspiration... tributes pour in for Ronaldo



REUTERS

Brazilian stars Neymar Jr. and Vinicius Jr. reacted to Ronaldo’s retirement, the former calling him a “legend” and the latter “Forever No. 1”. Portugal teammate Bruno Fernandes said it was a “privilege” to share moments with his childhood idol while representing the country. “Thank you for the inspiration,” he said.

NATION’S PRIDE

Portugal soccer federation plans special farewell for Ronaldo



GETTY IMAGES

The Portuguese Football Federation said it would organise a proper tribute for Cristiano Ronaldo. “It is our firm and earnest intention to organise, plan, participate in, and actively contribute to a tribute worthy of Ronaldo’s immense career, an occasion for the fans and the entire country to applaud and celebrate,” the federation said.

Ronaldo bids adieu to the international stage

The Portuguese icon leaves as the highest scorer ever with 146 goals but his prowess has been on the wane of late; the 41-year-old has had a fall-out with national coach Jesus recently

FOOTBALL

Agence France-Presse
LISBON

Portuguese football legend Cristiano Ronaldo announced on Thursday that he was retiring from international football at the age of 41. Ronaldo played 234 times for Portugal and scored 146 goals – a world record.

But the forward’s powers have been waning in recent years and he fell out with national coach Jorge Jesus last month after he refused to play him in a Nations League match.

Ronaldo left the team camp and was handed a 30-day suspension.

Although it was rumoured that he intended to return to the international fold, on Thursday the five-time winner of the Ballon d’Or released a video on his Instagram account in which he said he was ending his international career.

“To the Portuguese people, the day has come for me to hand back the number seven shirt of our national team,” Ronaldo said, as images of his career were played. “I never felt it belonged to me alone, but for 23 years I had the privilege and the responsibility of wearing it, defending it and carrying it with me into stadiums all around the world,” he continued.

“Today the time has come to pass it on to the future. It was not an easy decision, because some decisions are not made with the mind alone – they are also made with the heart.”

In the highlight of his international career, Ronaldo won the 2016 European Championship with Portugal in France, although he had to leave the field during the final with an injury.

Ronaldo's journey in numbers

234 appearances | **146** goals | **46** assists

1 Ronaldo is the only player to score at **six World Cups** (2006, 2010, 2014, 2018, 2022, 2026)

1 **His first Portugal goal came in his eighth appearance when he headed home in the 93rd minute in the 1-2 loss to Greece in the group stage at Euro 2004**

1 He is the first to score 100 goals for a national team in European international competitions

1 **His only red card came 22 years into his career when he was booked for elbowing Dara O'Shea in a 0-2 World Cup qualifying defeat to Ireland in Dublin in November 2025**

5 Ronaldo is the only player to score at five different European championships

14 He has netted the most goals at the European championship and is also the leading scorer in qualifying (55)

6 **He played in six World Cups, Messi the other to do so**

23 Ronaldo has scored at least one goal in 23 consecutive years

6 Ronaldo holds the record for most appearances at European championships (2004, 2008, 2012, 2016, 2020 and 2024)

124 His goals in competitive matches, a strike-rate of 84.9%. Messi’s is 56.8%

146 Number of international goals, a men’s world record. The next highest for Portugal is Pauleta, with 47 goals in 88 appearances.

10 **He is the first man to perform 10 hat-tricks in international football**

200 Ronaldo is the first man to reach 200 international caps.

11 Ronaldo is Portugal’s all-time leading World Cup scorer.

234 His appearances, a men’s world record

2003 Ronaldo made his international debut at the age of 18 in a friendly against Kazakhstan on August 20, 2003. He replaced Luis Figo at half-time

2019 His most productive year for Portugal as he found the target 14 times in 10 matches

Compiled by Anirudh Velamuri

CR7 — the epitome of sheer drive, relentlessness and athleticism

P.K. Ajith Kumar

First Lionel Messi. Now Cristiano Ronaldo. Within a space of three months, two of the all-time greats have called time on their international careers.

International football will never be quite the same again. How could it be without the genius of Messi that creates something out of nothing and the force, pace and brutal elegance of Ronaldo?

We have been fortunate that their extraordinary careers blossomed right in front of our eyes, that we could watch them score all those incredible goals over the last couple of decades, at the World Cups, in European leagues. True, everyone loves to love Messi. Ronaldo may not be universally cherished like the way the Argentine is, but his fan-following is no less committed.

Modesty may not be his best quality, he may have been accused of diving, he may have been theatrical, but make no mistake, few have played the beautiful game with as much passion, with as much hunger.

In fact, when it comes to the sheer drive and the relentless pursuit in the perfection of their art and athleticism, you would not too find many like Ronaldo in all sports, not just football. Closer home, he reminds you of one sporting great, though.



One of a kind: Ronaldo had many critics but few can doubt his passion for the game. AP

That man, Virat Kohli, like Ronaldo, has defied age. Not surprising really that the Indian superstar admires the Portuguese superstar.

If football was more of an individual game within a team game, like cricket, Portugal would have won more tournaments. A Kapil Dev could defeat Zimbabwe. A Glenn Maxwell could beat Afghanistan.

Football is as much a team game as any. Just the other day, Borussia Dortmund great Marcel Schmelzer had told this correspondent during an interview, that he was not a fan of the Ballon d’Or, as he believed football was a team game, it was not about individuals.

Still, the individual brilliance of Ronaldo made Portugal a formidable force. He led Portugal all the way to the Euro title in 2016.

He sadly had to leave the field after just 25 minutes in the final against France, but he cheered his teammates from beyond the boundary. It was Portugal’s finest hour.

With Ronaldo, the Portuguese played in every World Cup between 2006 and 2026 (before him they featured in only three).

And he provided some unforgettable moments at the world’s greatest spectacle.

Remember that hat-trick against Spain in 2018? You would not have forgotten that insane free-kick in the 88th minute that made the score 3-3.

It was genius. It was magic. It was Ronaldo.

India retains crown with a late surge

ACT

Uthra Ganesan
MOHALI

There is a reason most teams are wary of placing their bets on the Indian hockey team.

For almost three quarters in the final against Japan on Thursday, the host was like a headless chicken, running all across the field, dominating possession, passing the ball around and repeatedly entering the opposition circle, only to mess up. By the time the hooter went at full time, India had won 4-1, defended its Asian Champions Trophy title and the spectators who packed the Olympian Balbir Singh international stadium in the middle of a weekday got their money’s worth.

The crowd had to wait till the 42nd minute to find its voice after Japan took lead in the third minute through Kazumasa Matsumoto, then dished out a defensive masterclass and a lesson in how important getting the basics and discipline were in international hockey. It was also the scrappiest performance by India in the tournament, clearly under pressure, erratic and messy.



Delighted bunch: Jugraj is the toast of his teammates after putting India 3-1 ahead. R.V. MOORTHY

Japan was expected to stay defensive and wait for counters and control but it flipped the playbook, going on the attack from the beginning and playing positively. Left unmarked just outside the circle and India still only warming up, Matsumoto got the ball, took three steps inside the circle and unleashed a stunner through the smallest of gaps between the near post and Suraj Karkera’s gloves in the top corner.

Stunned, the Indians went all out, only to repeatedly run into a stubborn wall of Japanese defence and goalkeepers Kisho Kuroda and Takumi Kitagawa. So disciplined were the Japanese defenders that India got its first penalty corner only in the 33rd minute despite constantly crowding their circle with half of dozen players.

The match was played predominantly in Japan’s half and India had 22 entries with 12 shots at goal to seven and two for its rival. It didn’t matter.

The Indian forwards spurned chances like millionaires, being out of position and failing to trap properly. Hardik Singh, Vivek Sagar Prasad and Nilakanta Sharma did everything they could, relentlessly and tirelessly effecting turnovers, snatching possession and gliding through defenders, only for the forwards to miss sitters till the 42nd minute.

A third PC saw India try a variation, there was desperation to keep the ball in play and Shilanand Lakra whacked it in to level.

Suddenly, Japan looked deflated, its citadel breached, and the fluid movement that India is known for was in full flow, adding three more.

Earlier, Malaysia beat Korea 5-2 to take the bronze medal.

The results: Final: India 4 (Shilanand Lakra 42-pc, Dilpreet Singh 48, Jugraj Singh 52-pc, Vivek Sagar Prasad 54) bt Japan 1 (Kazumasa Matsumoto 3).
Third-place playoff: Malaysia 5 (Fitri Saari 2, Faisal Saari 34, Abu Kamal Azrai 45, 50, Marhan Jalil 58-pc) bt Korea 2 (Park Geunwoo 5, Chun Semin 13).

Liverpool sinks away to Fenerbahce

CHAMPIONS LEAGUE

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

Liverpool’s perfect record in this season’s Champions League ended in a 3-2 loss to Fenerbahce in Turkey on Wednesday while Como hit nine away to Lens in an incredible performance as it equalled the biggest winning margin in the competition’s history.

Como won 9-1 at Lens in France, as the side coached by Cesc Fabregas became just the third team since the launch of the modern UEFA Champions League in 1992 to win a game by an eight-goal margin.

Como is just the second team to score nine in a game in the competition, after Bayern Munich beat Dinamo Zagreb 9-2 in 2024.

It is fourth in the overall standings after four games with nine points, three points behind Paris Saint-Germain and Real Madrid, and one point behind Arsenal.

Real fought back against AEK Athens to win 3-2 in Greece. Noni Madueke and Viktor Gyokeres scored first-half goals as Arsenal won 2-1 away to Slavia Prague.



Unstoppable: Douvikas’ hat-trick powered Como’s big win over Lens. REUTERS

Manchester City is one of nine teams with nine points after Erling Haaland’s late goal secured a 3-2 victory away to RB Leipzig.

The results:
AEK 2 (Koita 12, Pilios 75) lost to Real Madrid 3 (Bellingham 32, Mbappe 78, Valverde 90+2); Fenerbahce 3 (Greenwood 29, Brown 73, Muriqi 79) bt Liverpool 2 (Nyoni 25, Isak 69).
Porto 4 (Bednarek 11, Veiga 71, Kiwior 80, Samu 90-pen) bt Napoli 1 (McTominay 43); Viking 4 (Botheim 27, 90+4, Tripic 69, Falchener 81) bt Sabah 1 (Mbina 11).
Borussia Dortmund 2 (Silva 49, Karetsas 72) bt Real Betis 1 (Ruibal 67); PSV Eindhoven 1 (Sano 54) lost to Club Brugge 2 (Tresoldi 25, Forbs 66).
Leipzig 2 (Baku 49, Nusa 61) lost to Manchester City 3 (Lukeba 37-og, Fernandez 58, Haaland 78).
Lens 1 (Aguilar 65) lost to Como 9 (Douvikas 7, 32, 57, Paz 40, Da Cunha 47, Kempf 53, Liberali 62, Baturina 69, Papaccioli 90+2).
Slavia Prague 1 (Nowak 90) lost to Arsenal 2 (Madueke 9, Gyokeres 38).

INBRIEF



Jangoo's hundred leads West Indies' recovery

Amir Jangoo's century against Bangladesh helped the West Indies recover from an early collapse to reach 235 for four on day one of the second Test at Sylhet on Thursday. Jangoo led the charge with an unbeaten 111 and his 131-run partnership with debutant Kevin Wickham was critical for the visitor after it slipped to 27 for three.

The scores: West Indies 235/4 in 70 overs (Wickham 61, Jangoo 111 n.o.) vs. Bangladesh. **Toss:** West Indies.

Tanvi storms into Youth Olympics badminton final

Tanvi Patri moved within one win of a historic gold medal after becoming the first Indian badminton player to reach the women's singles final of the Youth Olympic Games in Dakar on Wednesday. The 15-year-old from Odisha stunned Japan's second seed Yuzuno Watanabe 21-14, 11-21, 21-19 in a hard-fought 54-minute semifinal to set up a summit clash with China's Yi Xin Zhang, the reigning World Junior champion.



Kane renews contract, to stay at Bayern until 2029

Harry Kane said he felt "right at home" after he signed a two-year extension at Bayern Munich, keeping the Ballon d'Or winner at the club until 2029, the German champion announced on Thursday. The 33-year-old England captain joined Bayern from Tottenham in 2023 and has scored 156 goals in 161 games in all competitions. "I feel right at home at FC Bayern. I love the club, the fans and the city of Munich. We have a fantastic team and, in Vincent Kompany, a fantastic manager," Kane said in a statement.

Manu, Suruchi and Sainyam help India secure team silver

Manu Bhaker and Suruchi Inder Singh stormed into the women's 10m air pistol final at the ISSF World Championships in Doha on Thursday, while also combining with Sainyam to clinch the team silver for the country. Manu finished third in qualification with a score of 583. She shot 95 in each of the first two series before finding her rhythm, producing scores of 98, 100, 96 and 99 to make the eight-shooter final. Suruchi also made the cut, finishing eighth with 580. Sainyam, finished 22nd with 575 (95, 94, 96, 96, 95, 99). However, Sainyam's score proved valuable in the team event as India's combined tally of 1738 earned them the silver medal. China took the gold with 1745.



Raphinha agrees to a new contract with Barcelona

Raphinha has agreed to a new contract with Barcelona that will keep him at the Spanish club through 2030. Barcelona announced the new deal on Thursday. His prior deal was through 2028. Raphinha, 29, has emerged as a world-class player since joining Barca from Leeds in 2022.

LIVE TELECAST

Bangladesh vs. West Indies: Second Test, Day 2, FanCode, 9 a.m.

Men's u-19 Asia Cup: India vs. Nepal, Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 10.30 a.m.; Pakistan vs. UAE, Sony Sports Ten 5 & LIV, 10.30 a.m.

Afghanistan vs. Zimbabwe: First Test, Day 2, FanCode, 11.30 a.m.

ISL: Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 5 & 7.30 p.m.

New Zealand-A vs. India-A: Third 'Test', Day 1, Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 3.30 a.m. (Saturday).

Ajith Ram's seven-for helps TN make short work of Chandigarh on final day

The third straight win takes the visiting side's tally to 21 points; coach Yo Mahesh says the results are due to collective performances

RANJI TROPHY

Tarun Shastry
CHANDIGARH

The writing on the wall was as clear as the blue sky above. And it took Tamil Nadu just 47 deliveries on the final morning to complete its domination over Chandigarh, crushing the host by an innings and 260 runs in its Ranji Trophy Elite Group D fourth-round encounter at the Sector-16 Ground here on Thursday.

The victory, its third on the bounce this season, fetched TN seven points, including a bonus point, taking its tally to 21.

Left-arm spinner S. Ajith Ram continued from where he left off on Wednesday, dismissing Rohit Dhanda and Nikhil Sharma in the same over before returning to send back Jagjit Sandhu and bring the curtains down on a one-sided contest.



Happy unit: Ajith Ram polished off the Chandigarh tail to seal an emphatic victory. R.V. MOORTHY

Following the victory, head coach Yo Mahesh and skipper R. Sai Kishore spoke to *The Hindu* about how things have fallen into place for their side this season.

"Credit to the support staff for creating an environment where we have a lot of freedom to express ourselves. We feel secure. Because of that energy, a lot of things are going our way," said Sai Kishore.

For Yo Mahesh, the results have come from playing as a unit rather than relying on individual brilliance.

"Historically, we've always had a very skilled and talented bunch of cricketers. Whenever we have played as a team, we've got results going our way," he said.

Sai Kishore, meanwhile, was pleased with the camaraderie within the side.

"Everyone is gelling together. Everyone is happy for each other's success," he said.

And there was perhaps no better illustration of that than what unfolded at the presentation ceremony.

Pradosh Ranjan Paul produced an encore of his own. Adjudged Player of the Match for his double-century, he requested that the honour be given to teammate Ajith Ram, just as he had done last season for Nagaland's Imliwati Lemtur following his match-saving hundred at the Centre of Excellence in Bengaluru.

The scores: Tamil Nadu – 1st innings: 571 for seven decl. **Chandigarh – 1st innings:** 94. **Chandigarh – 2nd innings:** Nehal Pajni c Ajitesh b Sai Kishore 26, Arjun Azad st Jagadeesan b Ajith Ram 60, Manan Vohra lbw b Saravana Kumar 59, Arjit Pannu c & b Ajith Ram 9, Akshit Rana lbw b Ajith Ram 13, Bhagmender Lather c Indrajith b Ajith Ram 0, Chiragvir Dhindsa c Ajitesh b Sai Kishore 1, Nikhil Sharma lbw b Ajith Ram 16, Rohit Dhanda c Ajitesh b Ajith Ram 1, Nishunk Birla (not out) 4, Jagjit Sandhu b Ajith Ram 15; Extras (b-3, lb-9, w-1, nb-1): 14; Total in 64.5 overs: 218.
Fall of wickets: 1-73, 2-122, 3-155, 4-174, 5-174, 6-175, 7-185, 8-193, 9-194.
Tamil Nadu bowling: Gurjapneet 10-1-44-0, Saravana Kumar 11-2-34-1, Sai Kishore 15-2-47-2, Sonu 8-3-28-0, Ajith Ram 19.5-5-48-7, Pradosh 1-0-5-0.



Close call: Indian players celebrate the narrow win. AIFF

India beats Pakistan in SAFF C'ship opener

FOOTBALL

Press Trust of India
DHAKA

Suhail Ahmad Bhat struck a brace as defending champion India began its SAFF Championship campaign with a 3-2 victory over Pakistan in a Group B match on Thursday.

Bhat scored in the 13th and 19th minutes while Manglenthang Kipgen struck in the 31st minute as India led 3-0 at half time.

Pakistan scored two goals in the stoppage time through Najeeb Ullah and Alamgir Ghazi.

Coach Naushad Moosa had only 17 players at his disposal for Thursday's match as the ISL clubs are yet to release some of their players for the tournament with the game not falling in the FIFA match window (November 9 to 17).

The clubs are expected to release their players for the next match against Maldives on November 11.

The result:
India 3 (Suhail Ahmad Bhat 13, 19; Manglenthang Kipgen 31) bt Pakistan 2 (Najeeb Ullah 90+1, Alamgir Ghazi 90+4).

RANJI TROPHY SCORES — ROUND FOUR, FINAL DAY

Elite:
Group A: At Kanpur: Baroda 355 & 169/6 in 76 overs (Dhruv Patel 42, Atit Sheth 40 n.o.) drew with Uttar Pradesh 492 in 137.3 overs (Adarsh Singh 162, Madhav Kaushik 137, Aryan Juyal 67, Shivam Mavi 40, Mahesh Pithiya 6/116); **Baroda 1(18), UP 3(19).**
At Srinagar: Pondicherry 385 & 269/6 in 65 overs (Ankit Sharma 62, Aman Khan 52 n.o.) drew with Jammu & Kashmir 555/6 decl. in 135 overs (Qamran Iqbal 160, Shubham Khajuria 190, Kawalpreet Singh 70); **Pondicherry 1(2), J&K 3(5).**
Group B: At Agartala: Tripura 268 &191 bt Saurashtra 118 & 208 in 77.3 overs (Arpit Vasavada 89, Sandip Sarkar 4/81); **Tripura 6(6), Saurashtra 0(13).**
At Hyderabad: Chhattisgarh 284 & 254 lost to Hyderabad 280 & 259/9 in 79.4 overs (Abhirath Reddy 68, Varun Goud 55); **Hyderabad 6(20), Chhattisgarh 0(7).**
At New Chandigarh: Punjab 592/9 decl. drew with Andhra 505/8 decl. in 178 overs (C.R. Gnaneshwar 49, Shaik Rasheed 176, Karan Shinde 96, Seeram Rahul 76 n.o.); **Punjab 1(13), Andhra 1(4).**
Group C: At Bhubaneswar: Jharkhand 433/8 decl. drew with Odisha 280/7 in 88 overs (Swastik Samal 80, Anil Parida 57); **Jharkhand 1(6), Odisha 1(2).**
At Kolkata: Bengal 143 & 186 in 54.4 overs (Abishek Porel 65, Sumanta Gupta 59, Pradeep Dadhe 4/48, Hitesh Walunj 4/53) lost to Maharashtra 218 & 114/0 in 19.4 overs (Prithvi Shaw 53 n.o., Sachin Dhas 61 n.o.); **Maharashtra 7(19), Bengal 0(18).**
At Ahmedabad: Gujarat 534/9 decl. bt Kerala 279 & 191 in 88 overs (Sachin Baby 52, Arzan Nagwaswalla 4/24); **Gujarat 7(16), Kerala 0(8).**
At New Delhi: Services 266 & 397/9 decl. in 99.1 overs (Ravi Chauhan 56, Mohit Ahlawat 142, Rajat Paliwal 116) drew with Delhi 344 & 168/4 in 37 overs (Yash Dhull 104 n.o.); **Services 1(2), Delhi 3(7).**
Group D: At Mumbai: Mumbai 396 & 234/4 decl. in 42.5 overs (Divyaansh Saxena 100 n.o., Angkrish Raghuvanshi 79) bt Railways 259 & 265 in 77.2 overs (Eshaan Goyal 103, Zubair Ali 115, Shams Mulani 4/69); **Mumbai 6(27), Railways 0(2).**
At Chandigarh: Tamil Nadu 571/7 decl. bt Chandigarh 94 & 218 in 64.5 overs (Arjun Azad 60, Manan Vohra 59, Ajith Ram 7/48); **TN 7(21), Chandigarh 0(1).**
At Dharamshala: Rajasthan 78 & 521/8 decl. drew with Himachal Pradesh 153 & 313/7 in 115 overs (Pukhraj Mann 153 n.o., Mukul Negi 82); **Rajasthan 1(10), HP 3(4).**
Plate:
At Anand: Arunachal Pradesh 285 & 257 in 87.2 overs (Techi Doria 56, Techi Neri 43, Salil Malhotra 48, Kamsha Yangfo 48, Bobby Zothansanga 5/104) lost to Mizoram 571/9 decl.; **Mizoram 7(11), Arunachal 0(0).**
At Ahmedabad: Sikkim 432 & 216/1 decl. in 46.2 overs (Amit Rajera 102 n.o., Parth Palawat 92) bt Manipur 289 & 158 in 62.2 overs (Johnson Singh 40, Satyajeet Bachhav 7/33); **Sikkim 6(15), Manipur 0(12).**
At Shillong: Nagaland 254 & 184 bt Meghalaya 144 & 172 in 57.2 overs (Akshay Karnewar 56, Akash Choudhary 50 n.o.); **Nagaland 6(10), Meghalaya 0(12).**



Thrilling climax: Hyderabad, thanks to its last-wicket pair, pulled off a stunning win over Chhattisgarh. NAGARA GOPAL

Deepti in contention for ICC 'Player of the Month' honour

Press Trust of India
DUBAI

India's Deepti Sharma was among the six players shortlisted for the ICC Player of the Month awards here on Thursday. Deepti scored an unbeaten 106 in her only outing with the bat in a home ICC Women's Championship series match against Zimbabwe and took five wickets at an economy rate of 3.42. India blanked Zimbabwe 3-0 in the 50-overs series.

In three T20Is that preceded the ODIs, Deepti batted only once, scoring 49 off 37 balls and chipped in with two scalps with her off-spin.

The other players who were shortlisted include South Africa's Marco Jansen, Pakistan's Arafat Minhas, West Indies captain Shai Hope, Australia's Annabel Sutherland, and Bangladesh's Sobhana Mostary.

Erwin nets late winner as Bagan remains on top

ISL

Amitabha Das Sharma
KOLKATA

Mohun Bagan Super Giant maintained its position at the top of the standings with a thrilling 3-2 victory over a resilient Odisha FC in an ISL-13 fixture at the Salt Lake Stadium on Thursday.

Odisha twice fought back to restore parity after Bagan had taken the lead, but Lee Erwin's 86th-minute strike eventually settled the issue in the host's favour. All five goals came in the second half.

Registering its third consecutive home win and fourth victory on the trot, Bagan tallied 12 points from five matches while Odisha remained on two from four.

Dejan Drazic broke the deadlock immediately after the restart, finishing Anirudh Thapa's through ball in the 46th minute. Odisha responded six minutes later when Mahmoud Eid converted Nihal Sudeesh's cross to draw level.



The hero: Erwin's goal helped Bagan pick up three points. PTI

Drazic regained Bagan's lead in the 73th, diverting home substitute Lallianzuala Chhangte's cutback with his knee. A defensive mix-up five minutes later allowed Everton Nascimento to unleash a superb right-footed finish past Vishal Kaith to make it 2-2.

With a draw looming, Erwin proved the match-winner in the 86th minute, slotting home after Odisha failed to clear Subhasish Bose's cross that was helped into the box by Thapa.

The first half saw Odisha goalkeeper Hrithik Tiwari produce several impressive saves, while Bagan squandered multiple opportunities. The host also had two penalty appeals for handball against Odisha defender Saurabh Bhanwala turned down by referee Tejas Nagvenkar.

The results: Mohun Bagan SG 3 (Dejan Drazic 46, 73, Lee Erwin 86) bt Odisha FC 2 (Mahmoud Eid 52, Everton Nascimento 78).
At Margao: Churchill Brothers 0 lost to NorthEast United 2 (Ethyan Gonzalez 16, Antonio Moyano 90+3).

Bhupathi, Sania set to be SOM in AITA executive committee

TENNIS

Sports Bureau
BENGALURU

The two were chosen from a roster of 40 players and they are also among four SOMs elected to the AITA General Body

Mahesh Bhupathi and Sania Mirza are set to be the two Sportspersons of Outstanding Merit (SOM) in the 15-member All India Tennis Association Executive Committee that will be formed later this year after fresh elections.

The two were chosen from a roster of 40 players on Thursday, and they are also among four SOMs elected to the AITA General Body (GB). Current Davis Cup coach Ashutosh Singh and former Billie Jean King Cup captain Shalini Thakur Chawla are the other two former players in the GB.

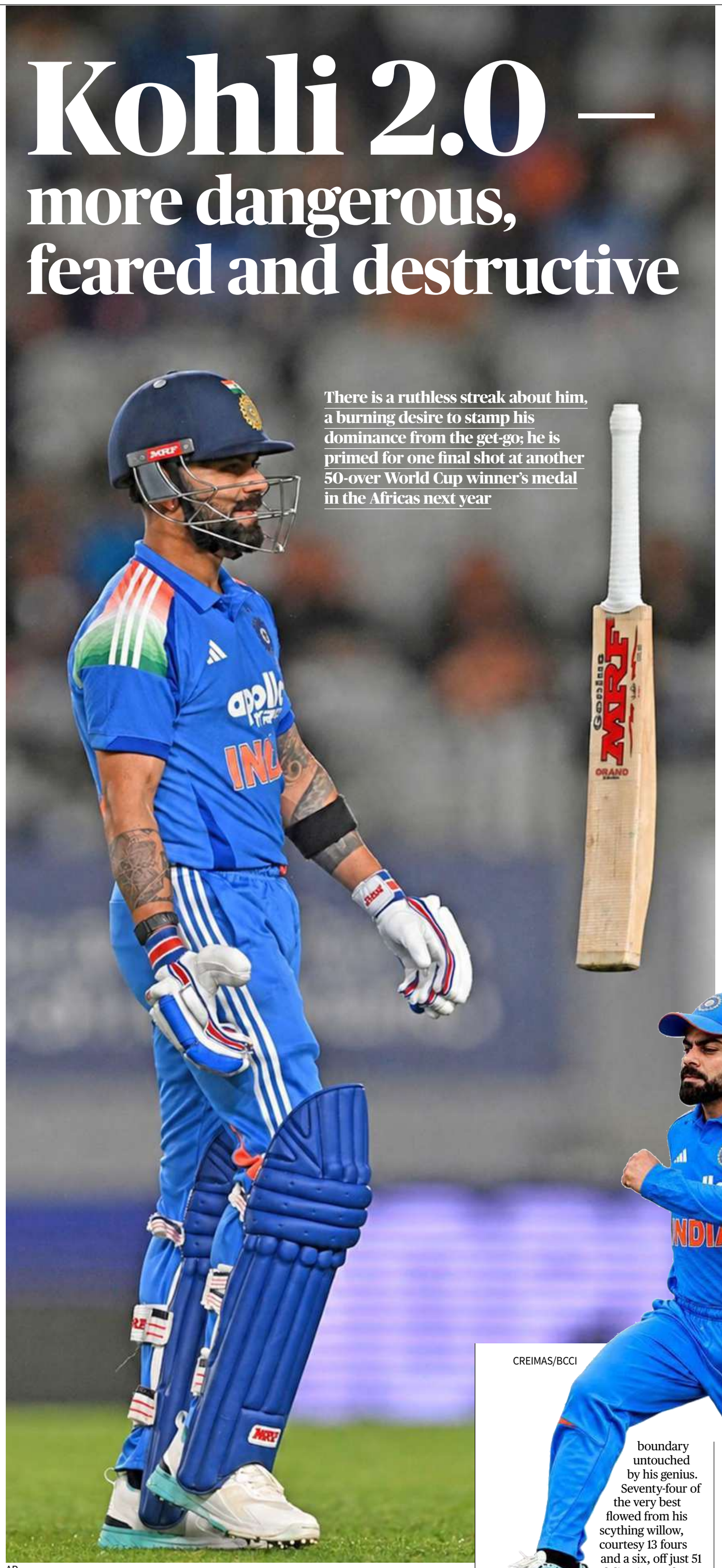
The AITA Constitution, which was amended in line with the National Sports Governance Act back in July, provides for four SOM representatives in the GB (two male and two female) and two in the AITA EC (one male and one female).

With Bhupathi and Sania set to take their places in the EC, they will not be able to contest the polls for other office-bearer posts such as president, general secretary and treasurer.

However, it remains to be seen in which direction proceedings in the Delhi High Court with respect to amending the AITA Constitution go.

The HC is scheduled to hear on Friday administrator Justice (retd.) Gita Mittal's request to implead the AITA Trust and the Delhi Lawn Tennis Association (DLTA) for corruption, and the contempt petition filed against AITA's interim office-bearers for "active obstruction and suppression of information" from the administrator.

Kohli 2.0 — more dangerous, feared and destructive



There is a ruthless streak about him, a burning desire to stamp his dominance from the get-go; he is primed for one final shot at another 50-over World Cup winner's medal in the Africas next year

AP

R. Kaushik
WELLINGTON

Virat Kohli is at that stage of his career where he is thoroughly enjoying himself. It's not as if he isn't as driven as previously; it's just that, having shouldered the burden of the Indian batting for so long, he feels he has earned the right to express himself with greater freedom than ever before, especially considering the wealth of batting riches at India's disposal in white-ball iterations.

This freeing up of the mind in the last year and a half has manifested itself in a new, exciting, exhilarating, compelling Virat Kohli. Just when we thought we had seen it all when it came to Kohli, a senior international for 18 years now, he shook us out of our complacent slumber, uncorking an avatar that is even more attractive and authoritative. As if that were possible, you ask? It most certainly is.

Gentle, significant tweak

This gentle yet significant tweak in mindset coincided, for want of a better term, with his retirement from Test cricket in May 2025. After a forgettable tour of Australia - an unbeaten century in the second innings of the first Test in Perth turned out to be a false dawn, as he repeatedly was snared into edging the ball behind the stumps for the rest of the series - he pulled the plug on his Test odyssey midway through IPL 2025. Only Kohli can tell us if the subsequent deliberate shift in approach had anything to do with his Test retirement; Kohli doesn't talk to us these days, not having attended a press conference for more than three years, so we can only speculate on that count.

What is not up for speculation is the undiluted joy the new look Kohli is providing in what is surely the autumn of a career most storied and celebrated. Not even when he was the lord and master of all he surveyed for five years when he dominated the cricketing landscape across formats did he sets heart aflutter in the manner in which he is doing today. There is a ruthless streak about him, a burning desire to stamp his dominance from the get-go, that is at once a reflection of modern India's approach as well as the one-for-all, all-for-one motto that has become such an unmissable feature of Indian cricket.

To say that Kohli has shed circumspection in adopting a more positive mien will be gross disservice to the bulwark who carried the Indian batting on his sturdy shoulders for so long, not unlike his hero Sachin Tendulkar. From the time he made his debut as a baby-faced, curly-haired teen to the time he bid adieu to the international game when well past 40, the Mumbaikar was the heartbeat of the Indian batting. Even when he was surrounded by the likes of Virender Sehwag, Rahul Dravid and V.V.S. Laxman, Tendulkar was not spared the weight of oppressive expectations. While he has often spoken of trying to meet his own expectations because it was unrealistic to try to live up to the varied demands of the millions who deified him and willed him on, it is impossible that Tendulkar wouldn't have felt the pressure every time he walked out with the bat in hand, every time he took guard.

It is to his eternal credit that despite the external thrust, Tendulkar seldom failed to come up trumps. Understandably, there were more 'misses' than 'hits' because by its very nature, cricket is a game more of failures than successes. Yet, to score a hundred every fourth Test was a phenomenal achievement even in isolation; given the narrative that surrounded his every foray to the middle, it is safe to say that Tendulkar's will remain an unparalleled chapter in the annals of international cricket history.

Worthy successor

Without slipping into the odious comparison game, it can be safely concluded Kohli has proved to be a worthy successor to The Master. Within two and half years of Kohli making his Test debut, Tendulkar walked away into the sunset at his beloved Wankhede Stadium, where he knows every blade of grass. At the time of Tendulkar's retirement, Kohli was yet to prove himself as a dependable Test entity; indeed, by the summer of 2014, big question marks were suffixed to his name after a disastrous tour of England where he only managed 134 runs from ten innings.

With no little help from Tendulkar himself, Kohli dramatically turned his Test career around. By then, he had already established himself as a 50-over behemoth, doing the impossible with such nonchalant regularity that not even the sky seemed to be the limit. By the end of the tour of Australia in 2014-15, which he began as the stand-in captain in Adelaide and ended as the full-time skipper in the fourth and final Test in Sydney, he had rapidly dispelled any lingering doubts with four centuries in as many matches, all produced with flourish and panache as he channelled his inner angst in the most productive manner imaginable.

From that high, Kohli soared to extraordinary heights, stringing together five full years of batting at a stratospheric level. The records kept piling up, the average went soaring northwards and he wowed the connoisseurs with his orthodoxy while winning the younger generations over with his dash, his style and an in-your-face aggression that resonated with the youth of an India that had emphatically shed its diffidence and genuinely believed it was second to none. In Kohli, they found an icon and a role model, a man after their own hearts who unapologetically wore his heart on his sleeve and who, as captain, demanded nothing of his men that he himself wouldn't do.

If, like all good things, this phase too came to an end, it did so after a sustained spell of the most magnificent batsmanship the modern game has been witness to. His prolonged struggles of the next few years merely served to highlight the exalted plane at which he had operated for so long, but just when the epitaphs were being written, Kohli has found a second wind that has made him a more dangerous, feared and destructive version of his previous complete self.

On the go

Today, Kohli thinks little of charging the first ball of his innings and clattering it - or at least attempting to do so - over the infield. If the length is short enough for him to launch into an audacious pull, he lets his instincts take over. If there is a full half-volley that demands his attacking attention, he obliges without a second thought. That's why he is scoring at a faster clip than even at his prime, that's why he is such a feared batter, so much more so than he was at his unmatchable peak.

Wednesday in Auckland was another demonstration of the new Kohli way of thinking that rocked New Zealand and transported more than 30,000 entranced spectators into the throes of ecstasy. No bowler was spared, no part of the leg-side boundary untouched by his genius. Seventy-four of the very best flowed from his scything willow, courtesy 13 fours and a six, off just 51 deliveries. Only two of those 13 fours were drives through the covers, which is also indicative of the lengths and the lines the Kiwi quicks adopted against him.



CREIMAS/BCCI

India's relatively inexperienced faster bowlers had used the bounce in the Eden Park surface to great effect. New Zealand's pacers are collectively bigger and taller than their counterparts and clearly, they had made a mental note of the lines of attack the Indian quartet embraced. Kyle Jamieson, Jacob Duffy, Nathan Smith and Blair Tickner tried to follow suit, but as if he had first-hand knowledge of what the bowlers would send down next, Kohli was in the optimal position to play the ideal shot to every delivery. The pull was his preferred mode of attack and he brought out the entire repertoire to the unalloyed delight of a big crowd that ate unashamedly out of the Kohli hands.

Tickner seemed to have ticked Kohli off, not least because he launched three sixes in a single Arshdeep Singh over right before the end of the Kiwi innings. The Kohli payback was instantaneous, unforgiving, brutal. More than once, Ticker lay on sprawled on his side, overbalancing on his follow through, as Kohli stood tall and banished the short ball from his presence with contemptuous disregard for pace and form. It was like the crack of doom, the ball leaving his bat as if turbo-charged and searing the slightly wet turf as it rattled into the boundary boards. It was Virat Kohli unplugged, a scary (if you were in the Kiwi camp) amalgam of ferocious intent and excellent execution. Each stroke was by itself worth the ticket price. When each of them contributed to be a mellifluous bouquet of sweet fragrance, it enveloped Eden Park in an ecstatic state of feel-good and euphoria.

Kohli did his reputation as the ultimate 50-over chaser no harm. He was part of a winning chase for the 108th time, enhancing his reputation with an 80th 50-over international half-century (to go with 55 hundreds) in 306 innings. His brazen 74 took his tally in winning chases to 6,477 runs at the unbelievable average of 89.95; those 108 knocks have produced 25 tons and 30 further scores of between 50 and 99. Along the way, he became the first No. 3 batter to score 13,000 or more runs in ODIs, giving himself the perfect birthday gift (he turned 38 on Thursday) and his team a 1-0 lead in the five-match series.

Kohli is primed for one final shot at another 50-over World Cup winner's medal in the Africas next year. In 2011, in his first World Cup, he scored a century in his first appearance (against Bangladesh) and rounded off the tournament with a crucial 35 in the final against Sri Lanka, helping current head coach Gautam Gambhir add 83 for the third wicket after India played themselves into a hole at 31 for two, chasing 275. Given his sense of occasion and his propensity for the dramatic, it won't be out of order to expect one telling final flourish, not unlike his Player of the Final performance at the T20 World Cup against South Africa in Bridgetown in June 2024.

THE GIST

- At the time of Tendulkar's retirement, Kohli was yet to prove himself as a dependable Test entity; indeed, by the summer of 2014, big question marks were suffixed to his name after a disastrous tour of England
- By the end of the tour of Australia in 2014-15, which he began as the stand-in captain in Adelaide and ended as the full-time skipper in the fourth and final Test in Sydney, he had rapidly dispelled any lingering doubts with four centuries in as many matches
- The first ODI in Auckland was another demonstration of the new Kohli way of thinking that rocked New Zealand and transported more than 30,000 entranced spectators into the throes of ecstasy

Kohli did his reputation as the ultimate 50-over chaser no harm in the series-opener. He was part of a winning pursuit for the 108th time, underlying his greatness with an 80th half-century in the format